The Chapter Called the Heart of the Speech of All Buddhas from the Noble Sūtra of the Precious Descent into Laṅkā

Āryalaṅkāvatāraratnasūtra sarvabuddhapravacanahṛdaya nāma parivarta · Toh 108 · Derge Kangyur

འཕགས་པ་ལང་ཀར་གཤེགས་པ་རྗེ་པ་ཚོའེ་མིད་ལོས་སངས་རྒྱས་ཐམས་ཅད་ཀྱིས་ཞུས་པ་ཞེས་བ་བྱའོ་ལའེ།

The Noble Sūtra of the Precious Descent into Laṅkā, presented here through its chapter called The Heart of the Speech of All Buddhas, is known in Tibetan as Pakpa Langkar Shekpa Rinpoché Do, and corresponds to the Sanskrit Laṅkāvatāra Sūtra. It is a Mahāyāna discourse set on the summit of Mount Laṅkā by the southern ocean, where the Buddha, surrounded by monks and by bodhisattvas from many buddha fields, answers the questions of the bodhisattva Mahāmati. Its teachings concern the nature of mind and appearances, the idea that the world is mind only, the storehouse consciousness, and the inner realization of the Buddhas' wisdom, themes that made it deeply influential in Yogācāra thought and in the Chan and Zen traditions. This version is Toh 108 in the Kangyur, where it belongs to the general sūtra section. It is generally understood to be the Tibetan rendering of an earlier Chinese translation, standing alongside another Tibetan version of the same sūtra translated from Sanskrit.

From the Noble Sūtra of the Precious Descent into Laṅkā, the chapter called The Heart of the Speech of All Buddhas.

Fascicle one.

Homage to all the buddhas and bodhisattvas.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One was dwelling on the shore of the southern ocean, on the summit of Mount Laṅkā, which was adorned with flowers of many kinds of jewels. He was together with a great Saṅgha of monks and a host of bodhisattva great beings who had gathered from many different buddha fields. Every one of those bodhisattva great beings delighted in immeasurable meditative absorptions, faculties, powers and superknowledges. Foremost among them was the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati. He had been empowered by all the buddhas, who had anointed him with their hands upon the crown of his head. He was supremely skilled in the meaning of the domain that is the appearance of one's own mind. He

displayed fully, just as they are, the minds of various beings, various forms, and immeasurable approaches to discipline. He had realized and fully understood the five dharmas, the natures, the consciousnesses, and the two kinds of selflessness.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati, together with bodhisattvas of great intelligence who travel through all the buddha fields, rose from his seat through the power of the Buddha. He draped his upper robe over one shoulder, placed his right knee on the ground, joined his palms, bowed, and praised the Blessed One with these verses:

The world is wholly free of arising and perishing;
It is just like a flower in the sky.
Though you apprehend no wisdom as existent or nonexistent,
Great compassion arises in you.

All phenomena are like illusions,
Wholly beyond mind and consciousness.
Though you apprehend no wisdom as existent or nonexistent,
Great compassion arises in you.

Wholly free of permanence and annihilation,
The whole world is like a dream.
Though you apprehend no wisdom as existent or nonexistent,
Great compassion arises in you.

You fully know the selflessness of persons and of phenomena,
And the afflictions and the knowable;
Though you are ever pure and without signs,
Great compassion arises in you.

You do not pass into nirvāṇa from anything at all;
Nirvāṇa is not perceived in the Buddha,
Nor is the Buddha perceived to pass into nirvāṇa;
You are free of intellect and of what is to be known.

The sides of existence and nonexistence,
Both of these, you have utterly abandoned.
The yogin of the peaceful Sage,
Having thoroughly abandoned births,
Is called one without grasping,
Wholly pure in this world and in the next.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati, having praised the Blessed One with those verses, stated his family and his name and said:

My name is Mahāmati;
I have come to understand great learning.
Today, here, the meaning of the one hundred and eight
I shall ask of the most excellent of masters.

The supreme being who knows the world
Heard that verse,
And looking over the assembly,
He spoke to the children of the Victor:

You and the other children of the Victor,
Ask whatever you wish,
And the domain proper to each of you
I shall explain to you.

Then the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati touched his head to the feet of the Blessed One, bowed, joined his palms, and asked his questions in verse:

How does mindfulness become pure?
How does mindfulness increase?
What are the delusion of views and error?
How does error increase?
Why are there emanations in the fields,
Characteristics, and non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) as well?
What is signlessness and its sequence?
Why is it done without signs?
Why are they called children of the Victor?
Where does one go to liberation?
Who is bound, and who are released?
What is the domain of meditative concentration?
Why are there three vehicles?
Please teach and explain this to me.
From what do conditions arise?
What are the maker and the made?
Why are the two explained as different?
In what way do they increase?
The formless absorptions
And the absorption of cessation, what are they?

What is the cessation of perception?
How does one rise from meditative absorption?
Why does what is made come about?
What are going and the taking up of a body?
How do conceptions appear?
How do the grounds arise?
Who is it that destroys the three realms of existence?
What is the abode, and what the body?
To what place of birth does one proceed?
How does one become a child of the Victor?
How are superknowledges, masteries,
And meditative absorptions attained?
What is the mind in meditative absorption?
Victor, please explain this to me.
Why is it called the ālaya?
What are mentation and consciousness?
What are arising and perishing?
How, having seen, does one turn back again?
In what way does one come to belong to a lineage?
What are lineagelessness and mind only,
And the characteristic of superimposition?
How does one come to the meaning of selflessness?
What is it that there are no sentient beings?
What is the conventional teaching?
How is it that views
Of permanence and annihilation do not arise?
How is it that the buddhas and the non-Buddhists
Do not conflict in their characteristics?
How in times to come
Will different schools arise?
How is there emptiness, and through what cause?
How does momentary perishing come about?
How does one arise within the womb?
How is one unmoved by the world?
How is it like an illusion and a dream,
Likewise a city of gandharvas,
Like a mirage of the world,

A moon in water, and lights?
Why were the limbs of awakening taught,
And likewise the factors of awakening?
Why do objects become disturbed?
Why does one look upon existence?
How is it that, without arising or ceasing,
The world is like a flower in the sky?
How did you come to comprehend the world?
Why do you speak free of letters?
Who is it that has abandoned conceptions?
How is it like space?
How many are there in suchness?
How many kinds of mind of the perfections?
By what cause does one cross the grounds?
Who goes to the state without grasping?
What are the two kinds of selflessness?
How is the knowable purified?
How many kinds of wisdom are there?
How many are moral discipline and sentient beings?
The families of gems, pearls and the like,
Who brings them forth?
The various kinds of beings
And their expressions, who brings them forth?
The fields of knowledge and the crafts,
Who teaches them, and how?
How many kinds of verse are there?
What are long and short verses?
How many kinds of reasoning are there?
Why is it called speaking?
How do drink and food come about?
How does the desire of craving arise?
Why is one called king?

What are wheel-turning monarchs and petty kings?
How is a realm to be protected?
How many kinds of classes of gods are there?
Why is it called the earth?

What are the planets, the stars, the sun and the moon?
Liberation and the yogins,
How many kinds of these are there?
How many kinds of disciples are there?
And how does one become a master?
How many kinds of buddhas are there?
How many kinds of birth stories?
The māras and the varieties of those in training,
How many kinds of these are there?
Intrinsic natures, and minds as well,
How many of these are there?
And what is mere designation?
Victor, please explain this to me.
What are the sky, the clouds and the wind?
What are mindfulness and clear understanding?
What are forests and trees?
From what do creepers come?
Elephants, horses and wild animals,
How do they come to be capturable?
What are base people like?
By what cause do they become base?
How is it gathered in six terms?
And how does one become an icchantika, one cut off from the roots of virtue?
Men, women and those of neither sex,
Why do they all come about?
How does one turn back from yoga?
How does yoga arise?
By what dharma does the yogin
Establish what kinds of persons?
Beings born into the destinies,
What are the kinds of their characteristics and signs?
What are those who have become wealthy like?
By what cause does one become wealthy?
What is the Śākya clan?
By what cause did the Śākyas arise?
How did the Ikṣvākus arise?
Unsurpassed Lord, please explain.

Who is the sage of long austerities?
How does he give instruction?
In the fields of the tathāgatas,
Names and likewise various forms,
And being surrounded by the Victor's children,
Why are these found everywhere?
Why do you not partake of meat?
Why is meat strictly forbidden?
Those born among the piśācas, the flesh-eaters,
By what cause do they eat meat?
What are the fields shaped like the sun and moon,
Those like Mount Meru and the lotus,
The fields marked with the supreme sign of the lion,
Worlds that stand sideways or upside down,
Those like Indra's net,
Some fields made of every jewel,
The nine, like lutes and drums,
Those shaped like various flowers,
And some devoid of the light of sun and moon?
These and other questions are beyond measure.
What is the emanated buddha?
The buddha born of karmic ripening,
And what is the buddha of suchness?
What is the buddha of wisdom?
Why is it that in the desire realms
One does not attain complete and perfect awakening?
Why is it that in Akaniṣṭha,
Among those free of passion, awakening is attained?
After the Sugata has passed into nirvāṇa,
Who will uphold the true teaching?
How long does the Teacher of gods remain?
How long does the true Dharma endure?
Tenets and views as well,
How many kinds of these are there?
The Vinaya and the categories of monks,
Why are they, and what are their causes and conditions?
Those children of the Victor,

The pratyekabuddhas and the śrāvakas,
By what cause do they undergo a hundred transformations?
By what cause are there a hundred non-appearances?
What are the worldly higher knowledges?
And what are those beyond the world?
That mind is present in the seven grounds,
How and why, tell me.
How many kinds of Saṅgha are there?
How does the Saṅgha come to be split?
The treatises for healing beings,
By what causes and conditions do they come about?
Why did the Great Sage
Declare thus: "Kāśyapa, Krakucchanda,
And Kanakamuni too are I"?
Why did he teach permanence and annihilation,
And likewise self and selflessness?
Why does he not at all times
Teach the true meaning,
And for the sake of beings
Make divisions within mind only?
Why groves of men and women,
Myrobalan and emblic,
Kailāsa and the Cakravāla range,
The Vajra and other mountains,
Richly adorned with various jewels,
And filled everywhere with sages and gandharvas,
How and why, tell me.

The unsurpassed Knower of the World,
Having heard his verses
On the gateways of deliverance of the Great Vehicle,
The supreme heart of all the buddhas, said:
"Excellent! Your questions are most excellent.
Mahāmati, listen well.
Here and now, in due order,
I shall explain what you have asked:
Arising and non-arising,

Nirvāṇa, emptiness and momentariness,
Entering into the absence of intrinsic nature;
Buddhas and the perfections,
The Victor's children and the śrāvakas,
Pratyekabuddhas and non-Buddhists (tīrthikas),
The practices of the formless,
And likewise the various things;
Mount Meru, the seas and the mountains,
The continents, the fields and the lands,
The planets, the stars, the sun and the moon,
The tīrthikas, the gods and the asuras;
The liberations, the masteries and the higher knowledges,
The powers, meditative concentration and meditative absorption,
Cessation and the bases of miraculous power,
The limbs of awakening and the factors of the path;
The meditative concentrations and the immeasurables,
The aggregates, the bodies, coming and going,
The meditative attainments and cessation,
The explanation of the mind that rises from absorption;
Mind, mentation and consciousness,
Selflessness and the five dharmas,
The natures, conceptualizing and the imagined,
Appearance and the two views,
The vehicles and the spiritual families,
Gold, silver, gems and the like;
Icchantikas and the great elements,
Disturbances, and the oneness of the buddhas;
Knowing and the knowable, entering and attaining,
What is possible and impossible for beings;
Elephants, horses and wild animals,
For what reason they are capturable;
Examples, causes and tenets,
Agents and what is made;
Forests, error and the higher knowledges,
The non-appearance of beings,
The grounds without passing on in stages,
The hundred transformations and the hundred non-appearances;

The treatises on healing and the crafts,
The arts and the fields of knowledge;
The mountains, Meru and the lands,
The measures of the ocean, the sun and the moon;
How many particles there are
In the bodies of superior, middling and inferior beings;
How many particles in each field,
And how many in each bow;
In a cubit, a pace, an earshot,
In half a league and in a league;
How many particles of hare, of sunbeam, of nit,
Of sheep, and of barley too;
How many barley grains in one measure,
How many barley grains in half a measure;
In one full measure and in ten,
In hundreds of thousands and in ten millions,
And likewise in a shudok,
How great their number is;
How many atoms there are,
How many atoms
Make one mustard seed,
How many mustard seeds
Make one olmasé seed,
How many olmasé seeds
Make one māṣa bean;

How many māṣas make one dharaṇa?
How many dharaṇas make a pala?
And in a single pala, how many karṣas are there?
Following the sum of calculations in this way,
"How many palas does Mount Meru weigh?"
These and other kinds of questions:
why do you ask about such other matters?
About the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas,
the buddhas and the Victor's sons,
"How many atoms are in their bodies?"
Why do you not ask in that way?

How many atoms are in a tongue of flame?
How many atoms are in the wind?
How many atoms in each sense faculty?
How many pores for the hairs of the eyebrows?
How do the lords who guard wealth, the kings,
and also the wheel-turning kings
protect their kingdoms?
How do they come to liberation?
How is a verse alone spoken,
just as you have asked?
The various kinds of sexual union among beings,
the many kinds of food and drink,
how men, the young, and groves,
mountains hard like vajra,
how things are like illusions and dreams,
like a deer tormented by thirst,
how mountains, sages, gods,
and gandharvas are richly adorned,
where the liberated go,
who is bound, and by what is he freed?
What is the domain of meditators?
Why do emanations and the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas)
act from a cause that does not exist?
Why do they act from a cause that exists?
Acting from a cause both existent and nonexistent,
and likewise a cause neither existent nor nonexistent;
how does one turn back from appearances?
How is speculation completely purified?
How does speculation come to arise?
By what activity does it arise?
How is perception to be cut off?
How does one rise from samādhi?
Who is it that has destroyed the three realms of existence?
What is his place, and what is his body?
Why, though there are no sentient beings,
is a self asserted to exist?
What is the teaching of the conventional?

"Please distinguish these extensively."
Why ask about characteristics?
What is the asking about selflessness?
How is one born within the womb?
The bodies, distinct and various,
what are the views of permanence and annihilation?
How is the mind placed in equipoise?
Speech, and likewise wisdom,
moral discipline, lineage, and the Victor's sons,
and what are reasoning and speaking?
What are master and disciple?
The various kinds of sentient beings,
and these and others, what are they like?
What are food and drink like?
The wise, māras, and mere designations,
"Why are there trees and vines?"
Such are the kinds of questions the Victor's son has asked.
Why are the buddha fields so various?
The sages' long austerities,
and what is it that is called lineage?
From which teacher is the training to be taken?
Why are people wicked?
Why do yogins
not awaken in the desire realm,
but reach the culmination in Akaniṣṭha?
Why are the higher perceptions worldly?
Why are monks called monks?
What is the emanated buddha like?
What is the buddha of maturation like?
Which is the buddha of suchness?
The buddha of the wisdom of equality,
and the Saṅghas too, what are they like?
Likewise the kinds of questions of the Victor's son:
the nine, the lute, the flower, the drum,
the fields, and the abandoning of appearances,
mind only, and the seven grounds;
the questions asked are perfectly correct.

These and many others besides,
the Victor's son has asked as questions.
Each fully endowed with its characteristics,
free from the faults of wrong views,
free from the assertions of doctrinal systems,
I shall now teach them here.
The statements set out in their proper order,
son of the Victor, listen well:
these one hundred and eight statements
I shall explain just as the buddhas have spoken them.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, what are these hundred statements?"

The Blessed One said: "The statement of arising and the statement of non-arising, the statement of permanence and the statement of impermanence, the statement of characteristics and the statement of the absence of characteristics, the statement of abiding and changing and the statement of not abiding and changing, the statement of the momentary and the statement of the non-momentary, the statement of intrinsic nature and the statement of freedom from intrinsic nature, the statement of emptiness and the statement of non-emptiness, the statement of annihilation and the statement of non-annihilation, the statement of mind and the statement of non-mind, the statement of the extreme and the statement of the non-extreme, the statement of the middle and the statement of the non-middle, the statement of perpetuity and the statement of non-perpetuity, the statement of conditions and the statement of non-conditions, the statement of causes and the statement of non-causes, the statement of afflictions and the statement of non-afflictions, the statement of craving and the statement of non-craving, the statement of means and the statement of non-means, the statement of skill and the statement of non-skill, the statement of purity and the statement of impurity, the statement of reasoning and the statement of non-reasoning, the statement of examples and the statement of non-examples, the statement of disciples and the statement of non-disciples, the statement of teachers and the statement of non-teachers, the statement of lineage and the statement of non-lineage, the statement of the three vehicles and the statement of the non-three vehicles, the statement of existence and the statement of non-existence, the statement of aspiration

and the statement of non-aspiration, the statement of the three spheres and the statement of the non-three spheres, the statement of signs and the statement of non-signs, the statement of the side of existence and the statement of what is not the side of existence, the statement of both and the statement of neither, the statement of abiding in bliss in this very life, whose object is the noble wisdom realized individually within oneself, and the statement of not abiding in bliss in this very life, the statement of fields and the statement of non-fields, the statement of atoms and the statement of non-atoms, the statement of water and the statement of non-water, the statement of the bow and the statement of the non-bow, the statement of the real and the statement of the unreal, the statement of number and the statement of non-number, the statement of calculation and the statement of non-calculation, the statement of manifestation and the statement of non-manifestation, the statement of space and the statement of non-space, the statement of clouds and the statement of non-clouds, the statement of crafts, arts, and fields of learning and the statement of non-crafts, non-arts, and non-fields of learning, the statement of wind and the statement of non-wind, the statement of earth and the statement of non-earth, the statement of mind and the statement of non-mind, the statement of designation,

the statement of non-designation, the statement of intrinsic nature and the statement of non-intrinsic nature, the statement of the aggregates and the statement of non-aggregates, the statement of sentient beings and the statement of non-sentient beings, the statement of intellect and the statement of non-intellect, the statement of nirvāṇa and the statement of non-nirvāṇa, the statement of the knowable and the statement of the non-knowable, the statement of non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) and the statement of non-non-Buddhists, the statement of tumult and the statement of non-tumult, the statement of illusion and the statement of non-illusion, the statement of dream and the statement of non-dream, the statement of mirage and the statement of non-mirage, the statement of reflection and the statement of non-reflection, the statement of the wheel and the statement of non-wheel, the statement of gandharvas and the statement of non-gandharvas, the statement of gods and the statement of asuras, the statement of food and drink and the statement of non-food and drink, the statement of sexual union and the statement of non-sexual union, the statement of views and the statement of non-views, the statement of the perfections and the statement of

non-perfections, the statement of moral discipline and the statement of non-moral discipline, the statement of the sun, moon and stars and the statement of non-sun, moon and stars, the statement of truth and the statement of non-truth, the statement of fruit and the statement of non-fruit, the statement of emerging from cessation and the statement of not emerging from cessation, the statement of healing and the statement of non-healing, the statement of characteristics and the statement of non-characteristics, the statement of limbs and the statement of non-limbs, the statement of skill in the fields of knowledge and the statement of non-skill in the fields of knowledge, the statement of meditative concentration and the statement of non-meditative concentration, the statement of error and the statement of non-error, the statement of appearance and the statement of non-appearance, the statement of protection and the statement of non-protection, the statement of lineage and the statement of non-lineage, the statement of sages and the statement of non-sages, the statement of kings and the statement of non-kings, the statement of taking hold and the statement of not taking hold, the statement of jewels and the statement of non-jewels, the statement of prophecy and the statement of non-prophecy, the statement of the icchantika and the statement of the non-icchantika, the statement of male, female and neuter and the statement of non-male, non-female and non-neuter, the statement of taste and the statement of non-taste, the statement of things and the statement of non-things, the statement of the body and the statement of non-body, the statement of reasoning and the statement of non-reasoning, the statement of movement and the statement of non-movement, the statement of the sense faculties and the statement of non-sense faculties, the statement of the conditioned and the statement of the non-conditioned, the statement of the unconditioned and the statement of the non-unconditioned, the statement of cause and effect and the statement of non-cause and effect, the statement of Akaniṣṭha and the statement of non-Akaniṣṭha, the statement of the seasons and the statement of non-seasons, the statement of trees, shrubs and creepers and the statement of non-trees, shrubs and creepers, the statement of diversity and the statement of non-diversity, the statement of what is held by the teaching and the statement of what is not held by the teaching, the statement of the Vinaya and the statement of non-Vinaya, the statement of monks and the statement of non-monks, the statement of the basis and the statement of non-basis, the statement of letters and the statement of non-letters.

Mahāmati, these one hundred and eight statements were spoken by the buddhas of the past, and you and the bodhisattva great beings should train in them.

Then the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, of how many kinds are the arising, abiding and cessation of the consciousnesses?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, the arising, abiding and cessation of the consciousnesses are each of two kinds, and they are not to be known by logicians. The arising of the consciousnesses is of two kinds, namely the arising of the continuum and the arising of characteristics. Abiding too is of two kinds, namely the abiding of the continuum and the abiding of characteristics. Cessation too is of two kinds, namely the cessation of the continuum and the cessation of characteristics.

"Now, the characteristics of the consciousnesses are of three kinds, namely the characteristic of evolving, the characteristic of karma, and the true characteristic. Mahāmati, in brief there are three consciousnesses; explained in detail, there are eight characteristics. What are the three? They are the true consciousness, the appearing consciousness, and the consciousness that discriminates things one by one.

"Mahāmati, just as a perfectly clear mirror holds reflections, so too the appearing consciousness appears.

"Mahāmati, these two, the appearing consciousness and the consciousness that discriminates things one by one, have the characteristic of perishing and not perishing, and each is the cause of the other.

"Mahāmati, thorough permeation by inconceivable habitual tendencies and inconceivable transformation are the cause of the appearing consciousness. Mahāmati, the grasping of various objects and thorough permeation by the conceptuality of beginningless time are the cause of the consciousness that discriminates things one by one.

"Mahāmati, when the various untrue things and the conceptual elaborations that obscure the true consciousness have ceased, all the sense consciousnesses cease. Mahāmati, this is called the cessation of characteristics.

"Mahāmati, as for the cessation of the continuum: when the cause that links it ceases, the continuum ceases. When that from which it arises has ceased, and

when that which it takes as its object has ceased, the continuum thereby ceases. Mahāmati, if one asks why that is, it is because that is its basis.

Here, as for what is called "the basis": I shall explain the cessation of the suffering of the three realms of existence, which is beginningless conceptuality; the reversal of ignorance, craving, karma, and conditions; the illusory objects that are appearances of one's own mind; and the views that follow from them.

Mahāmati, some ascetics or brahmins hold that results appear from a cause that is either seedless or possessed of seeds. They hold that the aggregates, elements, and sense sources arise from the time, the abiding, and the conditions of things, and then abide, or else perish once they have arisen. Mahāmati, such people end up proclaiming the destruction or the annihilation of continuity, of activity, of birth, of existence, of nirvāṇa, of the path, of karma, of the result, or of the truths. Why is that? Because this is not perceived directly and its beginning is not seen, since it is not a part of that.

Mahāmati, a pot that has broken into shards no longer performs the function of a pot. Likewise, a burnt seed does not perform the function of a sprout. In the same way, Mahāmati, the things that are aggregates, elements, and sense sources, whether they have ceased, are ceasing, or will cease, are seen through the conceptuality of one's own mind. Since there is no cause, they do not arise in succession.

Mahāmati, suppose consciousnesses arose from what is seedless or possessed of seeds, through the meeting of three conditions. Then it would also follow that hair could grow from a tortoise and sesame oil could come from sand. In that case you would fall away from your own thesis, and you would also contradict the definitive meaning. Since such faults attach to the teaching of what is possessed of seeds and what is seedless, all activities and deeds performed would become meaningless.

Mahāmati, those non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) say that what is called "arising from the meeting of three conditions" does not arise from a gathering of activity and appearance. Rather, they say, there exists a cause that is separate and distinct. Mahāmati, that cause is the Principal (pradhāna), the Supreme, the Person (puruṣa), the Lord (Īśvara), Time, and atoms.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are seven kinds of intrinsic nature. They are as follows: the intrinsic nature that is the assemblage of entities, the intrinsic nature of characteristics, the intrinsic nature that is the entity of the great

elements, the intrinsic nature of cause, the intrinsic nature of condition, and the intrinsic nature of accomplishment.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are seven kinds of ultimate. They are as follows: the domain of mind, the domain of wisdom, the domain of primordial wisdom, the domain of view, the domain that transcends the two views, the domain that transcends the ground of the sons of the buddhas, and the domain of the Tathāgata's own coming forth. Mahāmati, these are the essence of the ultimate, the intrinsic nature of the entity of the tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas of the past, future, and present.

Because they possess that essence of the ultimate, the intrinsic nature of entities, the tathāgatas have perfected the noble eye of wisdom with respect to worldly dharmas, transcendent dharmas, and supreme transcendent dharmas. They therefore set about establishing specific and general characteristics. Because they establish these exactly as they are, they do not come to share in the doctrines and wrong views of the non-Buddhists.

Mahāmati, if one asks how they are not shared with the doctrines and wrong views of the non-Buddhists, it is as follows. Childish ordinary beings do not understand the view that conceptualizes their own objects, and they do not realize that these are merely appearances of the mind, their own consciousness. Because of this, Mahāmati, they come to proclaim two views with regard to the ultimate intrinsic nature of entities and non-entities.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, it is thoroughly permeated by the conceptuality of time. What is called "the object of focus" is this: conceptualizing the appearances of one's own mind as the objects of consciousness.

Mahāmati, a lump of clay and its atoms, for example, are neither different nor non-different. The same is true of gold and its ornaments. Mahāmati, if the lump of clay and the atoms were different, the lump would not be made from them. But since it truly is made from them, they are not different. And if they were non-different, there would be no distinction between the lump of clay and the atoms.

In the same way, Mahāmati, consider the engaging consciousnesses and the true characteristic of the all-base consciousness. If they were different, the all-base consciousness would not be their cause. If they were not different, then when the engaging consciousnesses ceased, the all-base consciousness would cease as well. Yet its own true characteristic does not in fact cease. Therefore, Mahāmati, what ceases is not the own true characteristic of the

consciousnesses, but the characteristic of their activity. If their own true characteristic also ceased, the all-base consciousness would cease too. And Mahāmati, if the all-base consciousness were to cease, this would be no different from the annihilationism of the non-Buddhists.

Mahāmati, those non-Buddhists speak as follows: "When grasping at objects ceases, the continuum of consciousness ceases." But if the continuum of consciousness ceased, it would follow that the beginningless continuum of time would also be cut off.

Mahāmati, the non-Buddhists say that the cause of the arising of the continuum is eye consciousness and form. They say that the means exists as the specific characteristics of cause and result, and that past, future, and present are the characteristics of what is possessed of seeds and what is seedless. They teach this because they follow the logicians, who have handed down reasoning about things from one to another since former times, and because they are permeated by the habitual tendencies of the faults of their own views. In this way, Mahāmati, childish ordinary beings, gripped by wrong views, utterly confused by perverse crookedness, and intoxicated with ignorance, falsely claim: "This was taught by the Omniscient One."

Mahāmati, moreover, suppose some śramaṇa or brahmin sees all phenomena as devoid of intrinsic nature, like clouds, like a firebrand's wheel, and like a city of the gandharvas; as unborn, like an illusion, a mirage, the moon in water, and a dream. Suppose he sees that conceptual thought is mind appearing as inner and outer; that the proliferations of beginningless time do not exist apart from the conceptual thought of one's own mind; and that when causes and conditions have ceased and been exhausted, phenomena are free of conceptual thought. Suppose he sees them as free of expressing and what is expressed, and of examining and what is examined. Suppose he follows and discerns that they are merely what has arisen from one's own mind: dissociated from the all-base consciousness set up as enjoyments and body, and from the object of consciousness, apprehended and apprehender; a domain without appearance that is rid of arising, abiding, and destruction. Then, Mahāmati, those bodhisattvas will before long attain the sameness of saṃsāra and nirvāṇa, great compassion, skill in means, and effortless application.

Mahāmati, they see all those realms of sentient beings as like an illusion, as not taken up with causes and conditions, and as utterly isolated from inner

and outer objects, and they see nothing outside the mind. Because of this they gradually enter the signless state, and gradually, from ground to ground, enter the domain of meditative absorption. Through deep conviction that the three realms are like an illusion, and through discerning analysis, they will attain the illusion-like meditative absorption. Going beyond the appearances of their own mind and entering non-appearance, they come to attain abiding in the Perfection of Wisdom. By fully abandoning the application of producing these, they attain the vajra-like meditative absorption and then enter the ground of a Tathāgata. Such a bodhisattva is adorned with emanations that accord with suchness, with the superknowledges, the masteries, compassion, and skillful means. He enters all buddha fields at once and goes even to the abodes of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Being free of mind, mentation, and consciousness, that bodhisattva, through the stages of the transformation of the basis, will attain the body of a Tathāgata.

Mahāmati, therefore those who wish to attain the body that accords with the Tathāgata should completely abandon the conceptual proliferations of aggregates, elements, sense bases, mind, causes, conditions, activities, applications, arising, abiding, and destruction. Striving straightforwardly by way of mind only, they examine the faults of the proliferations of beginningless time. They see that the habitual tendencies of conceptual thought are the cause, and that the three realms of existence are without appearance. Through the buddhas they encounter non-arising, and so they reach the course of the noble ones, realized by oneself. Gaining mastery over their own mind, they fully understand and realize effortless conduct. Like a jewel that takes on the hues of various forms, they follow the very subtle minds of sentient beings, and with emanated bodies they bring them to liberation in accordance with the inclinations of their minds. Thus they will establish the successive linking of the grounds. Therefore, Mahāmati, one should thoroughly accomplish skill in one's own established tenets.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati again said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain mind, mentation, and consciousness, the five dharmas, and the characteristics of the natures. This is what all buddhas and bodhisattvas traverse. It does not accord with the domain apprehended by seeing and so forth with one's own mind. It fully teaches all the characteristics of expression or reasoning and of reality. It is the heart of the speech of all the buddhas. Blessed One, for the sake of the bodhisattva great beings who dwell in the city of Laṅkā, on Mount Malaya, and in the ocean, please explain the

domain of the all-base consciousness, which is like the waves of the ocean, and the Dharma body, which the tathāgatas have highly praised."

Then the Blessed One said this to the bodhisattva Mahāmati: "Mahāmati, eye consciousness arises because of four conditions. What are the four? They are these: not understanding that what is grasped is the appearance of one's own mind; clinging to the habitual tendencies toward form that come from the dysfunctional states of proliferation since beginningless time; the intrinsic essential nature of consciousness; and the desire to see the characteristics of the various kinds of form. Mahāmati, this is called the arising, through the four causes and conditions, of the waves of the active consciousnesses from the all-base consciousness, which is like the bed of a river.

"Mahāmati, just as it is with eye consciousness, so it is too with the minute particles of all the faculties and with the pores: they arise simultaneously, and they arise successively in accordance with their objects, just as reflections appear in a perfectly clear mirror.

"Mahāmati, for example, just as a fierce wind stirs the waters of the great ocean, so too the wind of external objects moves the ocean of the mind, and the waves of consciousness flow on without interruption. Because cause and action, whose characteristics are different and not different, are mingled as one; because of intense clinging to the characteristics of karma and birth; and because the essential nature of form and the rest is not realized; for these reasons the five groups of consciousness arise.

"Mahāmati, since the characteristics of the aspects are made known by distinguishing the cause that accompanies those five groups of consciousness, it should be understood that the cause of mental consciousness follows along with their body. They do not think, 'We act as causes for one another.' Rather, clinging arises through conceptual thought about the appearances of one's own mind, and each of them arises together with the characteristic of destruction. Distinguishing the particular aspects of objects: that is how they arise."

Mahāmati, consider yogins absorbed in meditative concentration and samādhi who do not know the extremely subtle workings of the habitual tendencies. They think, "We have entered the meditative attainment with consciousness stopped." Yet they have not truly entered the attainment with consciousness stopped. Because the extremely subtle seeds of the habitual tendencies have not ceased, it has not ceased. Because it is no longer engaged with objects

and no longer grasps them, it has ceased.

Mahāmati, this extremely subtle all-base consciousness can be fully realized only by the tathāgatas and by bodhisattvas well established on the grounds. Others, the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas and the non-Buddhist (tīrthika) yogins, cannot realize it, not even by the power of the samādhi and wisdom they have attained.

It is otherwise for those who discern the characteristics of the grounds, wisdom, gnosis and skill in means. They have no doubt about how the meanings of words are analyzed. They have amassed roots of virtue under infinite victors. They are free of conceptual proliferation about what appears as their own mind. They dwell in mountains, dense forests and groves, and they have cultivated yoga at the lesser, middling and superior levels. Such yogins see the stream of conceptual thought of their own mind. They receive empowerment from the buddhas of immeasurable fields, and they also obtain the masteries, the strengths, the superknowledges, the samādhis, and a retinue of spiritual friends who are children of the Buddha. Through this they understand the characteristic of proliferation, the domain of the intrinsic nature of mind, mentation, consciousness and what appears as one's own mind. They are then able to conquer the ocean of saṃsāra and existence, and its causes, such as karma, craving and ignorance. Therefore, Mahāmati, yogins should rely on the victors as their spiritual friends.

Then, to teach that same point again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Just as the waves of the ocean
Arise through the force of a fierce wind,
And the great-waved ocean, stirred up,
Flows on without a break,

So the all-base ocean, ever abiding,
Stirred up by the wind of objects,
Sets the waves of the various consciousnesses
Dancing and rolling forth.

Blue, red, forms of many kinds,
Conch, milk and molasses,
Astringent things, flowers and fruits,
The sun and moon and their rays:
They are neither one nor different.
As the ocean brings forth its waves,

So too the seven consciousnesses
Arise together with mind.

Just as the ocean, transformed,
Sends forth its various waves,
So it is with the seven consciousnesses:
They arise together with mind.

From the ground of the all-base consciousness
The various consciousnesses roll forth;
Thus mentation and that consciousness
Reflect upon characteristics and objects.
The eight are undivided in character;
Even the signless has no sign.

Just as the ocean and its waves
Have no distinction between them,
So too between consciousness and mind
No difference can be found.

Mind is said to perform karma and the rest;
Mentation is what amasses it widely;
The consciousnesses cognize,
Relying on appearing objects, as was explained before.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati made a request in verse:

Forms that are blue and red
Give rise to the consciousness of beings;
Why are the various phenomena like waves?
I beg you, explain this to me.

Then the Blessed One spoke in verse:

Blue, red and forms of many kinds
Do not exist as waves.
That karma and the rest are taught as mind
Is so that people may understand.
That karma, too, does not exist;
One's own mind is free of anything grasped.
Since there is nothing grasped, there is no grasper either.
It is just like those waves.

The setting up of enjoyments and bodies
Is consciousness appearing to beings;
From it, karmas are made to appear,
Just like the waves of the ocean.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati again addressed him in verse:

The waves of the ocean, as things,
Are known by their dancing and motion.
If it is so with the all-base as well,
Why is it not known by the intellect?

Then the Blessed One spoke in verse:

The childish, lacking intelligence,
Come to understand by relying on the example
Of the all-base being like the ocean
And the characteristic of karma like its waves.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati again addressed him in verse:

Just as the sun rises equally
On people good, bad and middling,
So the Sugata, Light of the World,
Should rightly speak to the childish
The true Dharma, fully discerned.
Why then do you not speak the truth?

Then the Blessed One spoke in verse:

Even if the truth were taught,
There is no truth in their minds.
Like the waves of the ocean,
Reflections in a mirror, and dreams,
All of these appear at once;
So it is with the domain of mind.
Because it is not joined with objects,
Karmas proceed and arise in sequence.
Consciousness cognizes;
Mentation likewise reflects;
The five come to appear;
For them there is no fixed order.

Just as a master painter
And the painter's apprentices
Spread out colors for a painting,
So too is my teaching.

The picture is not in the colors,
nor is it in the brush or the surface.
In order to bring joy to beings,
a picture is produced with colors.
Teachings are employed for the sake of others;
reality itself is beyond letters.
Through analysis, reality is taught
to yogins who are beginners.
The reality known personally by oneself
is utterly free of conceiving and conceived.
This is taught to the Victor's children;
for the childish, something else is set forth.
Just as various illusions
appear, yet are not real,
so the various teachings, too,
are laid down to accord with what is to be done.
A teaching that does not suit someone
becomes no teaching for that person.
Just as a skilled physician
prescribes treatments for each patient,
so the Tathāgata teaches beings
according to their inclinations.
The domain of personal realization,
proclaimed out of love,
is not the domain of logicians,
and even the śrāvakas have no share in it.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva mahāsattva who wishes to fully understand the domain of conceptuality, of grasped object and grasping subject, which is the appearance of one's own mind, should completely abandon gatherings, socializing, and sleep. In the evening, at dawn, and in the midnight session, he should always remain mindful and apply himself diligently to practice without lying down. He should completely abandon the

treatises and talk of those with wrong views, and the signs of the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. He should come to comprehend and realize the characteristic of conceptuality, which is the appearance of one's own mind.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva mahāsattva, abiding in the establishment of the characteristics of wisdom and discernment, should strive diligently to accomplish the three characteristics of noble wisdom that lie beyond. And what are these three characteristics of wisdom to be striven for and accomplished beyond? They are the characteristic of nonappearance, the characteristic of the abode of the personal aspirations of all buddhas, and the characteristic of the culmination of the wisdom personally known by noble ones. When the yogin has comprehended these, he abandons the mind that is like a lame donkey and the characteristics of discernment and wisdom, and, having attained the eighth ground, the Victor's child strives diligently in the three characteristics beyond it.

Therein, Mahāmati, the characteristic of nonappearance arises from thorough familiarity with the characteristics of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas, and the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Mahāmati, the characteristic of the abode of one's own aspiration arises from earnest striving in the abode of the personal aspirations of the buddhas of the past. Mahāmati, the characteristic of the culmination of the wisdom personally known by noble ones arises, through being free of attachment to the characteristics of any phenomena and through attaining the body of the illusion-like samādhi, from the practice of striving toward and entering the abode of the buddhas' ground. Mahāmati, these are called the three characteristics of noble wisdom. If one possesses these three characteristics of noble wisdom, one will comprehend the domain of the culmination of noble wisdom known by oneself. Therefore, Mahāmati, one should strive diligently in the three characteristics of noble wisdom.

From the Noble Sūtra of the Precious Descent into Laṅkā, the second fascicle.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati, knowing the thoughts in the minds of that assembly of bodhisattvas, by the power of the blessing of all the buddhas, requested from the Blessed One this Dharma discourse called "Distinguishing the Things and Intrinsic Nature of Noble Wisdom": "Blessed One, please explain to me the Dharma discourse called Distinguishing the Things and Intrinsic Nature of Noble Wisdom. On the basis of this topic, in which the one hundred and eight statements are thoroughly distinguished, the

tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas have distinguished and taught. Through that teaching, bodhisattva mahāsattvas enter into the intrinsic nature of conceptuality that belongs to specific and general characteristics. In order to show the intrinsic nature of conceptuality by the method of distinguishing, they become skilled in individual investigation; they contemplate the selflessness of persons and of phenomena; they thoroughly dispel conceptuality and become fully clear about the grounds; they utterly transcend the bliss of the meditative concentrations and absorptions of all the śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and non-Buddhists; they individually investigate the inconceivable domain of the Tathāgata; they will definitely abandon the five dharmas and the natures; they are thoroughly adorned by the tathāgatas with the nature of the wisdom of the dharmakāya; having generated the domain of illusion, they enter all the buddha fields, the palace of Tuṣita, and on up to Akaniṣṭha, the highest heaven; and they will also attain the permanently abiding dharmakāya of the Tathāgata."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, here some non-Buddhists, attached to the conception of nonexistence, conceive with a conceptual mind that since the cause is exhausted, the hare has no horns, and they say, 'Just as the hare has no horns, so too are all phenomena.' Furthermore, Mahāmati, some non-Buddhists, seeing the phenomena posited as elements, qualities, atoms, substances, shapes, and locations as separate and distinct, are attached to the hare's having no horns and, imagining, conceive that the cow does have horns. Mahāmati, they fall into the two views and, not understanding that it is mind only, the conceptuality that posits body and possessions appears to them from the proliferation of the domain of their own minds and of conceptuality. Mahāmati, the things of all phenomena are likewise: since they are free of existence and nonexistence, they should not be conceptualized. Mahāmati, moreover, if one conceives that, because they are free of existence and nonexistence, they do not exist, like a hare's horn, that is called wrong conception. Because these are causes mutually dependent on one another, one should not conceive that the hare's horn does not exist.

Even when it is analyzed down to the atom, no entity is found. Therefore, Mahāmati, one should not imagine that the cow's horn, which lies outside the domain of the noble ones, exists.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, is it that one who has attained nonconceptuality, having seen the characteristic of non-arising and having reflected thoroughly by means of

inference, calls it 'nonexistent' with respect to the discerning examination in which conceptuality does not arise?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, it is not the case that it is called 'nonexistent' with respect to the discerning examination in which conceptuality does not arise. Why is that? Because conceptuality arises from that cause: in dependence on it, conceptuality arises. In this way conceptuality arises in dependence on the horn, and therefore the horn is called its dependent cause. And because the horn is free from being either different or not different from it, it is not the case that one says 'there is no horn' with respect to the discerning examination in which conceptuality does not arise.

"Mahāmati, if the horn were different from conceptuality, then conceptuality would not arise from the horn as its cause. If it is not different, then, because conceptuality arises from that cause, when it is analyzed down to the atom it is not found; and because it is not different from the horn, it too is not an entity. If neither of the two is an entity, then by what phenomenon, and why, does one say 'nonexistent'? Mahāmati, if the hare's horn is nonexistent because of nonexistence, then one should not imagine that the hare's horn is nonexistent in dependence on existence. Mahāmati, because there is no correct cause, neither the proponents of existence nor the proponents of nonexistence will be established.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, those who hold the views of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), who are attached to phenomena imagined as entities of form, as shape and as location, and who do not properly understand the divisions of space, say, 'Space is devoid of form,' and so give rise to the conceptuality that views things as divided. Mahāmati, space is form, for it pervades the elements of form. Mahāmati, form should be understood as follows: in the case of entities established by way of a receptacle and what it holds, one distinguishes between the entity of form and the entity of space. Mahāmati, when the great elements arise, each has its own distinct characteristic, and they do not abide in space; yet it is not that space is absent in them.

"In the same way, Mahāmati, the hare's horn is nonexistent in dependence on the existence of the cow's horn. But, Mahāmati, the cow's horn too can be divided into minute particles, and when the minute particles are broken down in turn, they do not remain even for an instant. Then in dependence on what does one say 'nonexistent'? If one says that it is a substance dependent on something else, that too is of the same nature."

Then the Blessed One said this to the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati: "Mahāmati, you and the other bodhisattvas, the great beings, should completely abandon the conceptuality that views the hare's horn, the cow's horn, space, shape and form as different, should contemplate the conceptuality that is what appears as one's own mind, and should enter all the buddha fields; and you should teach the children of the Victor the practice of examining what appears as one's own mind."

Then, in order to teach this very meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Mind is not form and the like,
Yet mind proliferates as form and the like;
That which sets up body and enjoyments
Is the storehouse, appearing to beings.
Mind, mentation and consciousness,
The natures and the five phenomena,
The two kinds of selflessness, and purity:
These the Guide has proclaimed.
Long and short, existent and nonexistent, and the rest
Arise in mutual dependence.
Because of nonexistence, existence is established;
Because of existence, nonexistence is established.
When things are analyzed into particles,
No conceptions of form are produced.
The ground where mind only is established
Those with wrong views will not embrace.
That which the Protector of the World has spoken,
Which is one's own domain,
Is not the domain of those who conceptualize,
Nor likewise that of the śrāvakas.

Then, in order to purify the continuum of what appears as one's own mind, the bodhisattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, how is the continuum of what appears as one's own mind purified? Is it all at once, or is it gradual?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, it is purified gradually, not all at once. Just as the fruits of the mango tree ripen gradually and not all at once, so too the Tathāgata's purification of the continuum of what appears as beings' own

minds proceeds gradually and not all at once. Just as a potter makes his vessels gradually and not all at once, so too the Tathāgata's purification of the continuum of what appears as beings' own minds proceeds gradually and not all at once. Just as things grow from the great earth gradually and do not grow all at once, so too the Tathāgata's purification of the continuum of what appears as beings' own minds proceeds gradually and not all at once. Just as when some people study music, writing, painting and the various crafts, they gain mastery gradually and not all at once, so too the Tathāgata's purification of the continuum of what appears as beings' own minds proceeds gradually and not all at once.

"Just as a well-polished mirror, free of conceptual signs, makes all reflections appear at once, so too is the Tathāgata's complete illumination of the continuum of what appears as the own minds of all beings: he shows at once the pure domain, which is without signs and without appearance. Just as the discs of the sun and moon with their rays make manifest at once everything that appears as form, so too the Tathāgata shows at once, to beings who are free of what appears as their own minds and of the habitual tendencies of negative states, the domain of the victors, the inconceivable wisdom."

For example, the all-base consciousness cognizes and knows, all at once, the body, the dwelling, and the array of enjoyments, all of which are appearances of one's own mind. The dependent buddhas are likewise. All at once they bring sentient beings to maturity, and they settle those yogis in Akaniṣṭha, the highest heaven, the domain where they are to dwell. In the same way, the buddha of the nature of reality displays the dependent buddhas and shines resplendent with rays of light. The way of noble self-awareness is likewise. It shines resplendent by thoroughly examining the conceptions of the wrong views of existence and nonexistence regarding the characteristics of phenomena.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the buddha who depends on the nature of reality teaches that all phenomena, which fall under specific and general characteristics, arise from the cause of clinging to the imagined nature, which is bound up with the cause of the habitual tendencies of what appears to one's own mind. Clinging to the various unreal illusions as various is not apprehended.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the characteristic of the imagined nature arises from clinging to the dependent nature. Mahāmati, it is like a magician who, relying

on grass, wood and pebbles, uses various illusions to make the shapes and distinct forms of beings, and so gives rise to various conceptions; those conceptions are not real. In the same way, Mahāmati, the imagined nature arises in dependence on the dependent nature. Because of the various conceptual minds, the characteristics of many kinds, and the conceiving of the habitual tendencies of clinging through conceptualizing things as real entities, Mahāmati, this is called the imagined nature that arises from conceptuality. Mahāmati, this is what the dependent buddha teaches.

Mahāmati, the buddha of the nature of reality establishes the domain that is free of the characteristic of the nature of mind and is to be apprehended by noble self-awareness.

Mahāmati, the emanated buddha produced by emanation teaches generosity, moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration, mind, wisdom and discernment; freedom from the aggregates, the elements and the sense sources; liberation; the characteristics of consciousness; the establishment of discrimination and analysis; and the characteristic of utterly transcending the views of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) and the views of the formless.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the buddha of the nature of reality teaches what is without any object and free of objects; what is turned away from all characteristics of activity, of the faculties and of valid cognition; what is not the domain of the clinging and attachment to characteristics of ordinary childish beings, śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and non-Buddhists; and what is established by the characteristic of the domain of noble self-awareness. Therefore, Mahāmati, one should strive earnestly at the distinctive characteristic of noble individual self-awareness, and should completely abandon the views that are appearances of one's own mind.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the characteristic that distinguishes the ways of the Śrāvaka Vehicle is of two kinds: the characteristic of attaining the distinctive characteristic of noble individual self-awareness, and the characteristic of clinging to the nature of conceptualizing things as real entities.

Of these, who is the śrāvaka who has attained the distinctive characteristic of noble individual self-awareness? It is this. He fully understands, just as it truly is, the genuine truth that the body is impermanent, suffering, empty and without self; he is free of desire and utterly secluded; the aggregates, elements and sense sources are finally pacified in him; he enters into specific and general characteristics and has the characteristic of not being frightened

by outsiders. Having understood this, he attains complete pacification of mind. Once his mind is completely pacified, he is not separated from the concentrations, the liberations, the meditative absorptions, the paths, the fruits, the attainments of absorption, release, the habitual tendencies, and the inconceivable death and transmigration of transformation. That śrāvaka, who has attained dwelling in the bliss of noble individual self-awareness, is called the śrāvaka who has attained the distinctive characteristic of noble individual self-awareness.

Mahāmati, the bodhisattva great beings who have attained dwelling in the distinctive bliss of noble individual self-awareness do not dwell in the bliss of the gateway of cessation or in the bliss of meditative equipoise. Because they regard sentient beings with compassion, and because of their former aspirations, they do not actualize it. Mahāmati, this is called the śrāvakas' attainment of the bliss of the distinctive characteristic of noble individual self-awareness. The bodhisattva great beings should not train in the bliss of the distinctive characteristic of noble individual self-awareness that those śrāvakas have attained.

Mahāmati, who is the śrāvaka characterized by clinging to the nature of conceptualizing things as real entities? It is this. They see that the great elements, blue, yellow, red and white, hardness, wetness, warmth and motion arise without a creator, and they see the specific and general characteristics well taught by the former Victors; and then the conceptualization of an intrinsic nature arises in them with regard to these. The bodhisattva great beings should understand these and completely abandon them. Having entered into the characteristic of the selflessness of phenomena, they turn back the view that rests in the characteristic of the selflessness of persons, and they abide in the establishment of the gradual linking of the grounds. Mahāmati, this is called the śrāvakas' characteristic of clinging to the nature of conceptualizing things as real entities.

Then the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One:

"Blessed One, you have declared the permanent and inconceivable to be the domain of the noble ones' individual self-awareness and the domain of the ultimate. Blessed One, is that not the same as the permanent and inconceivable cause and condition of which the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) speak?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, the causes and conditions of the tīrthikas do not attain permanence and inconceivability. And why is that? Because the permanence and inconceivability of the tīrthikas is not established from the own-characteristic of a cause. If the cause of permanence and inconceivability is not established from its own characteristic, then by what cause is the permanent and inconceivable made manifest? Further, Mahāmati, if permanence and inconceivability were established from the own-characteristic of a cause, it might thereby be permanent. But since it has the characteristic of a cause that produces, it is not established as permanent and inconceivable.

"Mahāmati, my ultimate permanence and inconceivability is established from the characteristic of the ultimate cause. It possesses a characteristic, because it has attained the characteristic of self-awareness, free of existence and nonexistence. It possesses a cause, because it has become the cause of ultimate wisdom. Because it is free of existence and nonexistence, it is permanent, for it is like the unconditioned: space, nirvāṇa, and cessation. Therefore, Mahāmati, this is not the same as the tīrthikas' assertion of permanence and inconceivability. Mahāmati, this permanence and inconceivability is to be realized by the tathāgatas' noble wisdom of individual self-awareness. Therefore one should strive diligently to realize the permanent and inconceivable, the noble wisdom of individual self-awareness.

"Further, Mahāmati, the permanence and inconceivability of the tīrthikas is in fact impermanent. Because its cause has a characteristic other than itself, and because of the force of the characteristic of a cause that is self-made, it is not permanent. Further, Mahāmati, the tīrthikas, seeing that made things are impermanent because they cease to exist, conclude about their permanence and inconceivability, 'It is permanent.' Mahāmati, I too likewise see that things made by causes and conditions are impermanent because they cease to exist. But by the noble wisdom of individual self-awareness I show that there is no cause of permanence in that.

"Mahāmati, if moreover the tīrthikas' permanence were established as the characteristic of a cause, then, because the own-characteristic of the cause of permanence and inconceivability has no existence as an entity, that permanent and inconceivable would be like the horn of a rabbit, and it would be nothing but verbal conceptualization. The tīrthikas have faults such as these. And why is that? Because verbal conceptualization, too, is like the horn of a rabbit, and has no entity with the characteristic of a cause of its own.

"Mahāmati, my cause of permanence and inconceivability is permanent because it has the characteristic of realizing the noble wisdom of individual self-awareness, and because it fully rejects both made things and nonexistence. It is not something imagined to be permanent by inference, from external things having ceased to exist and become impermanent. Mahāmati, if one imagines permanence and inconceivability by inference from the nonexistence and impermanence of external things, one does not know the characteristic of the inconceivable's own cause. Mahāmati, such people are very far removed from the domain in which the noble wisdom of individual self-awareness is realized. This should not be taught to them.

"Further, Mahāmati, frightened by the suffering of saṃsāra's conceptuality, they seek nirvāṇa. Not knowing the difference between saṃsāra and nirvāṇa, they perceive as nirvāṇa the nonexistence of conceptuality with regard to all things and the cutting off of the objects of the sense faculties in the future. They do not place first the noble wisdom of individual self-awareness, which is the transformation of the all-base. Therefore those fools speak of three vehicles, and do not teach that what appears as mind only is without appearance. Therefore, Mahāmati, they do not clearly know the domain of the appearances of one's own mind taught by the tathāgatas of the past, future, and present. Clinging to what mind itself makes appear as an external domain, they forever turn on the wheel of saṃsāra.

"Further, Mahāmati, the tathāgatas of the past, future, and present have taught that all phenomena are unborn. And why is that? Because the things that are appearances of one's own mind are nonexistent, and are free of arising either as existent or as nonexistent. Mahāmati, all phenomena are unborn: all phenomena are like the horns of a rabbit, a horse, and so on. Because childish ordinary beings conceive of the imagined nature, which is unreal, Mahāmati, all phenomena are unborn. In the domain of the noble wisdom of individual self-awareness, the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of all things does not arise. Therefore it is not a characteristic in the manner of the nature that establishes body and possessions, which is the nature of the domain of the dualistic conceptuality of childish ordinary beings.

"Mahāmati, while the all-base consciousness operates with the characteristics of the grasped and the grasper, childish ordinary beings, whose minds have fallen into the two views of arising, abiding, and perishing, imagine that the arising of all things is an arising from existence or nonexistence. The noble

ones do not. Mahāmati, you should strive diligently in this."

Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are five lineages of realization. What are the five? They are the lineage of realization of the śrāvaka vehicle, the lineage of realization of the pratyekabuddha vehicle, the lineage of realization of the Tathāgata vehicle, the lineage that is not fixed in any of them, and the lineage that is separate and distinct.

How is the lineage of realization of the śrāvaka vehicle to be understood? It is someone who hears the teaching on the specific and general characteristics of the aggregates, the elements and the sense sources, and on what is to be abandoned and what is to be known. The hair on his body stands on end and he rejoices greatly. He is drawn to knowledge of characteristics that are to be made familiar, but he does not familiarize himself with the characteristics of dependent origination that are to be understood. This is the lineage of realization of the śrāvaka vehicle.

Through the realization of the śrāvaka, one comes to see the eighth ground. Having fully abandoned the afflictions that actively arise, and having abandoned the afflictions of habitual tendencies, they have not passed beyond the inconceivable death of transformation, yet they have fully passed beyond the death and transmigration of entities. So they truly roar the lion's roar: "My birth is exhausted. I have lived the holy life. I shall not take any further existence." They know things truly, just as they are, they cultivate the selflessness of the person, and they come to the conviction that they have attained nirvāṇa.

Mahāmati, the distinct realization is this: those beings seek nirvāṇa with such notions as self, person, sentient being, living being, life force, nourisher and man.

Furthermore, certain various non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), seeing all things as dependent upon a creator, come to the notion, "This is nirvāṇa." Since they lack the fortune to see the selflessness of phenomena, there is no liberation for them.

Mahāmati, those who realize the śrāvaka vehicle and those of the non-Buddhist lineage hold the notion of deliverance with regard to what is not deliverance. One should strive to turn them back from these wrong views.

Mahāmati, the lineage of realization of the pratyekabuddha vehicle is this: when someone hears of the realization of distinct conditions, the hair on his

body stands on end and tears flow. He has no attachment to the conditions of social bustle. When he hears an explanation of how one emanates and displays manifold forms through one's own various bodies and through various miracles of uniting and separating, his mind follows after it. Knowing him to be of the lineage of realization of the pratyekabuddha vehicle, one should speak words in harmony with the pratyekabuddha vehicle. Mahāmati, this is the characteristic of one who has the lineage of realization of the pratyekabuddha vehicle.

Mahāmati, the lineage of realization of the Tathāgata vehicle is of four kinds. They are the lineage that realizes phenomena with intrinsic nature, the lineage that realizes phenomena without intrinsic nature, the lineage that realizes the noble wisdom cognized individually by oneself, and the lineage that realizes the outer, excellent buddhafields.

Mahāmati, whenever any one of these four is taught, and when someone hears the explanation of the body that is the appearance of one's own mind, of the arrangement of enjoyments, and of the inconceivable domain, the one who is not frightened and not terrified should be known as one who has the lineage of realization of the Tathāgata vehicle. This is the characteristic of one who has the lineage of realization of the Tathāgata vehicle.

Mahāmati, one of indeterminate lineage is this: whichever of those three is explained, he enters into what is explained and practices in accordance with it.

Mahāmati, these are the initial preparation of the ground, namely, the establishment of the lineages. The establishment was made in order to enter the ground of non-appearance. Those who abide in what is cognized individually by oneself, having purified in the ālaya the habitual tendencies of their own afflictions, see the selflessness of phenomena; and the śrāvakas who have attained the dwelling in the bliss of samādhi will also attain the very body of the Tathāgata that has become supreme.

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The fruit of the stream-enterer,
the once-returner, the non-returner,
and likewise the arhat:
the minds of these are deluded.

Three vehicles, and one vehicle,
and no vehicle I have taught,
for the childish of immature mind
and for noble ones who delight in utter seclusion.

The door of the ultimate Dharma
is wholly free of the two teachings.
Since it rests in non-appearance,
how could it be set out as three vehicles?

The dhyānas and the immeasurables,
and the samādhis of the formless,
by utter isolation from feeling and perception:
not even mind-only exists.

Mahāmati, these icchantikas are not icchantikas: who in the world would enter into liberation?

Mahāmati, there are two kinds of icchantika: those who have abandoned all roots of virtue, and those who have made aspirations for the sake of sentient beings from beginningless time.

What is it to have abandoned all roots of virtue? It is to disparage the bodhisattva piṭaka and to speak evil words, saying, "This does not accord with the sūtras, the Vinaya, or liberation." Because they have abandoned all roots of virtue, they do not pass into nirvāṇa.

The second: because bodhisattvas have put first their own former aspirations and skillful means, it is not that they do not fully pass into nirvāṇa; they cause all sentient beings to pass into nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, this nirvāṇa of theirs is the characteristic of one whose nature is not to pass into nirvāṇa, and by this they too fully attain the way of the icchantikas.

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One (the Buddha), "Blessed One, who here is the one who never passes into nirvāṇa?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, the bodhisattva icchantika knows that all phenomena are in nirvāṇa from the very beginning, and so he never passes into nirvāṇa. He is not the icchantika who has abandoned all roots of virtue. Mahāmati, even the icchantika who has abandoned all roots of virtue may, by chance, give rise to roots of virtue through the blessing of the Tathāgata. Why is that? Because the tathāgatas never forsake any sentient being. That is why bodhisattva icchantikas do not pass into final nirvāṇa.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva great being should become skilled in the characteristics of the three natures. What are these three natures? They are the imputed nature, the dependent nature, and the perfected nature. Mahāmati, the imputed nature arises from signs."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, how does the imputed nature arise from signs?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, the characteristic of the entities of the dependent nature appears like the characteristic of the signs of conditioned entities. The tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas establish that the imputed nature of clinging is of two kinds: the characteristic of clinging to the signs of names, and the characteristic of clinging to the signs of things. The characteristic of clinging to the signs of names is clinging to inner and outer phenomena. The characteristic of clinging to the signs of things is clinging to the specific and general characteristics of those very inner and outer phenomena. Mahāmati, this is called the characteristic of the twofold imputed nature. That which arises from what it rests on and what it apprehends is called the dependent.

"And what is the perfected nature like? It is free from conceptualizing the characteristics of the things of names and signs. It is to be attained by noble wisdom. It is the domain traversed by the noble wisdom of individual self-awareness. This perfected nature is called the heart of the essence of the tathāgatas."

Then, to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Names and signs, and conceptualization,
Are the characteristics of two natures.
Right knowledge and suchness
Are the characteristic of the perfected.

"Mahāmati, this Dharma discourse called 'Discerning the Five Dharmas and the Characteristics of the Natures' is the domain traversed by the noble wisdom of individual self-awareness. You and the bodhisattva great beings should train in it.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva great being should become skilled in discerning the characteristics of the two kinds of selflessness. What are the characteristics of the two kinds of selflessness? They are the selflessness of persons and the selflessness of phenomena.

"What is the selflessness of persons? It is this. There is a collection of aggregates, elements and sense bases, devoid of self and of what belongs to a self, born from ignorance, karma and craving. Consciousness arises from clinging to the grasping of name, form and the like. All the faculties, the world that is the appearance of one's own mind, the body and its abode are differentiated by being imagined through one's own conceptuality. Like a river, a seed, a lamp, the wind and clouds, they perish from one instant to the next. They are restless like a monkey. Like a fly, they delight in impure places. Like a blazing fire, they are never satisfied. Their cause is the habitual tendencies of the dysfunction of conceptual proliferation, from beginningless time. Like the wheel of a water mill they turn, becoming the wheel of existence that circles through the destinies. They take on the forms of many kinds of bodies. They operate and arise like an illusion, a spell, or a mechanical device. The knowledge that is skilled in these characteristics is called knowing the selflessness of persons.

"And what is knowing the selflessness of phenomena? It is this. The aggregates, elements and sense bases are a collection whose nature is the imputed characteristic. The aggregates, elements and sense bases are devoid of self and of what belongs to a self. They are a mere collection of aggregates, elements and sense bases, tied together by the thread of continuum, karma and existence, arising from mutual conditioning, and without movement. In just the same way, phenomena too are devoid of specific and general characteristics. They are unreal, having the characteristic of imagination. The power of imagination is produced by the childish, not by the noble ones, because the noble ones are free of mind, mentation, mental consciousness, the five dharmas and the natures. Mahāmati, the bodhisattva great being should become skilled in discerning the selflessness of all phenomena.

"Mahāmati, the bodhisattva great being skilled in the selflessness of phenomena will before long attain the first bodhisattva ground. Realizing the discernment of the characteristics of the ground of meditation on non-appearance, he is filled with joy. Progressing step by step, ever more distinguished, he passes beyond the knowledge of the characteristics of nine grounds and attains the Cloud of Dharma. There he enters a great lotus king of jewels and a great jewel palace, arrayed and adorned with countless jewels, which arise from thoroughly cultivating the domain whose nature is illusion. Surrounded by a retinue of children of the Victor of equal fortune, he is consecrated by the hands of buddhas who have come from all the buddha

fields, who empower him at the crown of his head, just as the son of a wheel-turning king is consecrated."

"Having passed beyond the grounds of the children of the Buddha, they realize the way of the Dharma that is known personally by noble wisdom, and so they will attain the Dharma body, the mastery of the Tathāgata, because they see the selflessness of phenomena. This is called the characteristic of the selflessness of phenomena. You and the bodhisattvas should train in it."

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, again said this to the Blessed One (the Buddha): "Blessed One, please explain the characteristics of superimposition and denial, so that I and the bodhisattva great beings may fully abandon the bad views of the two extremes of superimposition and denial, swiftly awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and, once fully and perfectly awakened, also abandon the views that superimpose permanence and deny through annihilation, and so never come to deny the true Dharma."

Then the Blessed One, having understood the request that the bodhisattva Mahāmati had made, spoke these verses:

Superimposition and denial
Do not exist: this is mind only.
Not truly knowing body, enjoyments and abode,
Nor even the mind,
The childish, who lack intelligence,
Superimpose and deny.

Then, to show the meaning of those very verses, the Blessed One declared this: "Mahāmati, superimposition upon what does not exist is of four kinds. What are the four? They are: superimposing a nonexistent characteristic, superimposing a nonexistent view, superimposing a nonexistent cause, and superimposing a nonexistent entity. These are called the four kinds of superimposition. Denial is this: because one fails to discern that those very superimpositions cannot be apprehended, one gives rise to denial. This is the characteristic of superimposition and denial.

"Further, Mahāmati, what is the characteristic of superimposing a nonexistent characteristic? It is to give rise to attachment to specific and general characteristics of the aggregates, elements and sense sources that do not exist, and to say, 'This is so, and not otherwise.' This is the characteristic of superimposing a nonexistent characteristic. This conceptuality that

superimposes a nonexistent characteristic arises from attachment to the various habitual tendencies of the dysfunction of conceptual elaboration from beginningless time.

"Mahāmati, the characteristic of superimposing a nonexistent view is to view those very aggregates, elements and sense sources as a self, a person, a sentient being, a life, a nourisher, or a man, and so to superimpose. This is called the characteristic of superimposing a nonexistent view.

"Mahāmati, the characteristic of superimposing a nonexistent cause is this: to say that the first consciousness arises without a cause, and that afterwards, unreal and like an illusion, having not arisen before and not existing, it comes about from the eye, form, light, the element, and the preceding operation of memory, and that once it has arisen it perishes. This is the characteristic of superimposing a nonexistent cause.

"Mahāmati, the characteristic of superimposing a nonexistent entity is this: to be attached to space, cessation and nirvāṇa as uncreated entities, and to superimpose them so. These are free from entity and non-entity. All phenomena appear like the horns of a rabbit, a horse and so on, or like a tangle of hairs, and they are free from existence and non-existence. Those whose minds, through childish conceptuality, do not realize that they are merely appearances of their own mind superimpose and deny, but the noble ones do not. This is the characteristic of superimposing a nonexistent entity. Therefore one should strive earnestly to fully abandon the bad views of superimposition and denial.

"Further, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva great beings, being skilled in the way of the characteristics of mind, mentation and mental consciousness, of the five dharmas, of the natures, and of the two selflessnesses, and having understood them through realization, display various forms for the benefit of sentient beings, just as the imputed nature rests upon the dependent. Like a precious wish-fulfilling jewel of various forms, they go everywhere in the buddha fields to all the gathered assemblies of the tathāgatas, and in all of them they listen to those who teach the Dharma, namely that all phenomena are like an illusion, a dream, light, a reflection, and the moon in water; that all phenomena are free from arising and ceasing, from permanence and annihilation; and that this Dharma is free from the vehicles of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. They attain a hundred thousand samādhis, and even up to a hundred thousand koṭis of niyutas of samādhis. Having attained these

samādhis, they go to all the buddha fields and make offerings to the buddhas. They are born in all the abodes of the gods, proclaim the praises of the Three Jewels, and manifest the body of a buddha surrounded by assemblies of śrāvakas and bodhisattvas. Through the mere appearance of their own mind they guide sentient beings and liberate them, and by analyzing and showing that external entities are without entity, they cause them to abandon the views of existence and non-existence."

Then, to show that very meaning once more, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

When the Victor's children examine
The worlds and see them as mind alone,
They gain a manifold form, like clouds,
Free of deliberate formation;
The powers, the superknowledges, and the masteries,
All of these will be accomplished.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, again made a request of the Blessed One (the Buddha): "Blessed One, for the sake of myself and others, please explain the characteristic of the emptiness, the nonarising, the nonduality, and the absence of intrinsic nature of all phenomena. Through that, I and the other bodhisattvas will understand and realize emptiness, nonarising, nonduality, and the absence of intrinsic nature. Having fully abandoned conceptual thought about existence and nonexistence, we will swiftly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening."

Then the Blessed One spoke thus to the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati: "Mahāmati, then listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you, analyzing it in detail."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Excellent, Blessed One, I will do so," and listened. The Blessed One said:

"Mahāmati, what is called 'emptiness, emptiness' is the domain of the imputed nature. Mahāmati, it is to those who are attached to the imputed nature that the characteristic of emptiness, nonarising, nonduality, and absence of intrinsic nature is taught.

"Mahāmati, in brief, emptiness is of seven kinds, namely: the emptiness of characteristics, the emptiness of the intrinsic nature of entities, the emptiness of formations, the emptiness of nonformation, the emptiness of all phenomena

being inexpressible, the great emptiness of the ultimate, noble wisdom, and the emptiness of one by another.

"What, then, is the emptiness of characteristics? All entities are empty of specific and general characteristics. Because one examines them individually out of their mutual assemblage, and distinguishes them as being without entity, specific and general characteristics do not arise. And because there is no entity of self, of other, or of both, characteristics do not abide. Therefore all entities are said to be empty of characteristics. This is called the emptiness of characteristics.

"What is the emptiness of the intrinsic nature of entities? It is this: because the intrinsic nature of an entity does not arise of itself, it is called the emptiness of the intrinsic nature of the entities of all phenomena. Therefore it is said to be the emptiness of the intrinsic nature of entities.

"What is the emptiness of formations? It is this: the aggregates are devoid of self and of what belongs to a self, and they arise from causes and what brings them about, from activity, from karma, and from effort. This is called the emptiness of formations.

"Mahāmati, by this very emptiness of formations, since things arise through mutual conditions but have no entity of intrinsic nature, it is called the emptiness of nonformation.

"What is the emptiness of all phenomena being inexpressible? It is this: because the imputed nature cannot be expressed, all phenomena are beyond expression. This is called the emptiness of all phenomena being inexpressible.

"What is the great emptiness of the ultimate, noble wisdom of all phenomena? It is this: the attainment of the noble wisdom that is individually and personally realized is empty of the habitual tendencies of all views and faults. This is called the great emptiness of the ultimate, noble wisdom of all phenomena.

"What is the emptiness of one by another? It is this: being empty in that one thing is absent from another is called the emptiness of one by another. Mahāmati, for example, in the house of Mṛgāramātā there are no elephants, horses, cattle, sheep, and so forth, yet it is not without the Saṅgha of monks. Although it is said to be empty of those, the house is not empty of being a house, and the monks are not empty of being monks, nor is it the case that elephants, horses, and so forth do not exist elsewhere. That is the specific characteristic of all phenomena: wherever something is absent, that is called

the emptiness of one by another.

"These are the seven kinds of emptiness. This emptiness of one by another is the lowest among the emptinesses, and you should abandon it.

"Mahāmati, things do not arise of themselves, and yet it is not that they do not arise, except for one abiding in meditative absorption; this is what is called nonarising.

"As for what is called the absence of intrinsic nature: that very nonarising is called the absence of intrinsic nature. Because there is no continuity of a momentary continuum, and because they appear as distinct entities, all entities are devoid of intrinsic nature. Therefore all entities are called devoid of intrinsic nature.

"What is nonduality? It is this: all phenomena are like shade and heat, long and short, black and white. Mahāmati, because all phenomena are nondual, they are not other than nirvāṇa, and nirvāṇa is not other than saṃsāra either; since entities exist by way of causes with distinct characteristics, this is called nonduality. Just as it is with nirvāṇa and saṃsāra, so it is with all phenomena. Therefore one should strive diligently in the characteristic of emptiness, nonarising, nonduality, and the absence of intrinsic nature."

Then, to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

I have always taught the emptiness of phenomena,
Free of permanence and annihilation;
And though I have said saṃsāra is like an illusion or a dream,
Karma does not perish.

Space, nirvāṇa,
And the two cessations are likewise.
Fools conceive of them,
But the noble ones have abandoned existence and nonexistence.

Then the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati: "Mahāmati, the characteristic of emptiness, nonarising, nonduality, and the absence of intrinsic nature is found in all the sūtras of the buddhas; in every sūtra these meanings are taught. The sūtras are differentiated according to the dispositions of sentient beings, in order to show the meaning. Reality does not lie in the words."

It is like a mirage that deceives a deer through the conceptual thought of its thirst. The deer clings to the mirage's appearance as if it were water, yet there

is no water there. In the same way, the phenomena taught in all the sūtras are meant to bring delight to childish ordinary beings. Therefore reality and the wisdom of the noble ones are not found in talk. So one should follow the meaning and not become attached to the words.

The Noble Sūtra of the Precious Descent into Laṅkā, fascicle three.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One (the Buddha): "In the sūtras spoken by the Blessed One, the tathāgatagarbha is said to be pure by its very nature, to carry the thirty-two major marks, and to be present in the bodies of all sentient beings. It is like a precious jewel of great value wrapped in a soiled cloth. In the same way, all the buddhas have taught, the tathāgatagarbha, though permanent and unchanging, is wrapped in the soiled cloth of the aggregates, the elements, and the sense bases, and stained by the dust of attachment, aversion, delusion, and false imagining. Why, then, has the Blessed One declared that there is a tathāgatagarbha, just like the self that the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) teach? Blessed One, the non-Buddhists also speak of something permanent, an agent, free of qualities, all-pervading, and imperishable. Blessed One, that is what they teach as the self."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, the tathāgatagarbha that I have taught is not the same as the self the non-Buddhists speak of. Mahāmati, on certain occasions the tathāgatas teach the tathāgatagarbha with words such as emptiness, signlessness, wishlessness, suchness, the limit of reality, the nature of reality, the dharma body, nirvāṇa, free of intrinsic nature, unarisen, unceasing, quiescent and at peace from the very beginning, and naturally in nirvāṇa. The tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas teach the gateway of the tathāgatagarbha, the domain that is free of conceptual thought and without appearance, in order to remove entirely the fear of childish beings who would be frightened by the words of selflessness. Mahāmati, bodhisattva great beings of the future and of the present should not cling to the view of a self.

"Mahāmati, a potter, for example, makes vessels of many kinds from a single lump of clay, by applying the skill of his hands, water, a rod, a wheel, and string. In the same way the tathāgatas, through their many kinds of skill in wisdom and means, teach the selflessness of phenomena, which is free of every characteristic of conceptual thought, either as the tathāgatagarbha or as selflessness. For this cause and for this reason, the teaching of the

tathāgatagarbha is not like the self taught by the non-Buddhists. This is called the teaching of the tathāgatagarbha.

"The tathāgatagarbha is taught in order to guide the non-Buddhists who cling to the doctrine of a self, so that they may become free of the conceptual thought of a false view of self, may have the resolve to enter the domain of the three gates of liberation, and may swiftly attain unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. For that reason the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas teach the tathāgatagarbha in this way. Were it otherwise, they would be the same as the non-Buddhists. Therefore, Mahāmati, in order to abandon the self taught by the non-Buddhists, one should abide in the tathāgatagarbha that is selflessness."

Then the Blessed One spoke this verse to teach that same meaning again:

The person, the continuum, the aggregates,
the conditions, and the atoms,
primal matter, Īśvara, and the creator:
these are imagined within mind alone.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, looked upon the multitudes of beings of the future and again said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the realization of the great means of yoga of the bodhisattva great beings."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, a bodhisattva great being who possesses four qualities will attain the great means of yoga. What are the four? They are these: being skilled in discerning what appears as one's own mind; contemplating external things as having no existence; abandoning views of arising, abiding, and perishing; and attaining the excellent bliss of the noble wisdom that is personally self-realized. When a bodhisattva great being possesses these four qualities, this is called attaining the great means of yoga.

"Now, how is a bodhisattva great being skilled in discerning what appears as his own? It is like this. He contemplates thus: 'This threefold realm is merely an aspect of mind alone. It is free of self and of what belongs to a self. It is without movement and free of coming and going. It is imbued with the habitual tendencies of conceptual elaboration from beginningless time. It is tightly bound by the enjoyment of the many kinds of form in the three realms. It appears in conformity with the conceptual thought that posits a body and possessions.' This is called the bodhisattva great being's skill in discerning what appears as his own mind."

How is a bodhisattva mahāsattva skilled in investigating external things as being without real existence? It is like this. He investigates the nature of all things, seeing that all things are like a mirage, a dream, and so forth, and that they have arisen from the cause that is the habitual tendencies of conceptual thought, which are the detrimental tendencies of conceptual elaboration since beginningless time. When bodhisattva mahāsattvas investigate external things in this way as being without real existence, this is called the bodhisattva mahāsattva's skill in investigating external things as being without real existence.

How is a bodhisattva mahāsattva skilled in abandoning views of arising, abiding, and perishing? It is like this. Because all things are like an illusion, a dream, and so forth, things do not arise from themselves, from another, or from both. Because he follows what is merely the appearance of his own mind, he sees external things as without real existence. He sees that the consciousnesses do not engage, and that conditions do not accumulate. Because he sees that the three realms have arisen from the condition of conceptual thought, he does not apprehend any outer or inner phenomena. Because he sees them as devoid of intrinsic nature, the view of arising is turned back. Because he understands the nature of phenomena as being like an illusion and so forth, he attains forbearance toward the unborn nature of phenomena, and then he fully abandons the views of arising, abiding, and perishing. This is called the bodhisattva mahāsattva's skill in abandoning views of arising, abiding, and perishing.

How does a bodhisattva mahāsattva attain the sublime bliss of the noble wisdom that is known by oneself individually? It is like this. Having attained forbearance toward the unborn nature of phenomena, he abides on the eighth bodhisattva ground. Free from mind, mentation, and mental consciousness, and from the five dharmas, the natures, and the characteristics of the two kinds of selflessness, he also attains the mind-made body.

"Blessed One, why is it called the mind-made body?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, the so-called mind-made body is called a body of mind because it is swift as the mind and unobstructed. For example, the mind moves unobstructed by mountains, walls, and the like, to those various directions many hundreds of thousands of yojanas away. Because it recollects what it saw before, it does not forget, and so the body of one's own mind, its continuity unbroken, travels there without obstruction. Mahāmati, in

the same way, the mind-made body too is attained all at once, simultaneously. The mind-made body of the bodhisattva mahāsattva is adorned with the power of the illusion-like samādhi, with the masteries and the higher knowledges, and with the excellent marks. It is a body of the noble lineage, born all at once, simultaneously; it moves as the mind does and is unobstructed. Because it brings sentient beings to maturity by recollecting the objects of former aspirations, he attains the sublime bliss of the noble wisdom that is known by oneself individually.

"Thus the bodhisattva mahāsattva, having attained forbearance toward the unborn nature of phenomena, abides on the eighth bodhisattva ground. Being free from mind, mentation, and mental consciousness, and from the body characterized by the five dharmas, the natures, and the two kinds of selflessness, he attains the mind-made body and the sublime bliss of the noble wisdom that is known by oneself individually. This is the great method of yoga of the bodhisattva mahāsattva, endowed with four qualities. You should train in it."

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, please explain the characteristics of the causes and conditions of phenomena. By understanding the characteristics of causes and conditions in this way, I and the bodhisattvas will be free from the conceptual thought that views all things as existent or nonexistent, and we will be without conceptual views about arising gradually or all at once."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, the characteristics of the conditions of all phenomena are of two kinds, namely external and internal. Of these, external conditions are like this: a pot comes about from the conditions of a lump of clay, a stick, a wheel, string, water, human labor, and application. Just as a pot comes about from a lump of clay, so too cloth from thread, a mat from grass, a sprout from a seed, butter from curd, and all other things that arise from the conditions of application are the same. This is called the external conditions arising through transformation from earlier to later.

"What, then, are the internal conditions? They are like this: phenomena such as ignorance, craving, and karma receive the name 'conditions,' and the phenomena that arise from them, called the aggregates, elements, and sense sources, likewise receive the name 'dependent origination.' Although they are without distinction, the childish imagine them as distinct. These are called the internal conditioning phenomena.

"Mahāmati, of these, causes are of six kinds, namely the cause of what will come to be, the connecting cause, the characteristic cause, the efficient cause, the manifesting cause, and the dependent cause.

"Of these, the cause of what will come to be performs the causal function of producing outer and inner phenomena. The connecting cause performs the function of an object-support for producing outer and inner phenomena such as the aggregates and seeds. The characteristic cause, by acting as the immediately preceding characteristic, produces without breaking the continuity. The efficient cause performs the function of sovereignty, like a wheel-turning king. The manifesting cause, once a conceptualized thing has arisen, performs the function of making its characteristics appear, just as a lamp makes forms and so forth visible. The dependent cause is this: at the time of cessation, the continuity of activity is cut off, and it arises as a nonconceptual thing."

Mahāmati, these are the characteristics of the conceptuality of childish ordinary beings. Things do not arise gradually, nor do they arise all at once. Why is that? If they arose all at once, there would be no distinction between agent and act, and so the characteristic of a cause would not apply. If they arose gradually, their own characteristic would not be found, so they do not arise by gradual arising. It is just as there is no name "father" while no son has been born. Mahāmati, the logical connection that rests on gradual arising, with cause and effect set apart, is also untenable; that is mere conceptuality. People hold that what is to be produced is produced by the causal condition, the objective-support condition, the immediately preceding condition, the dominant condition, and so on. But, Mahāmati, nothing arises by gradual arising, because this belief has the character of clinging to the imputed nature. Things arise neither gradually nor all at once, because they are body and possessions, which are appearances of one's own mind. Since specific and general characteristics, and external things, have no real existence, Mahāmati, there is no gradual or simultaneous arising. Signs arise only because it is not understood that the appearances of one's own mind are mere conceptuality. Therefore the views of gradual and of simultaneous arising, which involve causes, conditions, things that perform activities, and the joining of these, should be completely abandoned.

Then, to teach that very point again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

All phenomena are unborn;
there is no ceasing of causes and conditions either.
In those that arise and cease,
one produces the notion of causes and conditions.

Arising again from what has ceased,
and connected causes and conditions, are not denied;
this is so that the deeply deluded childish
may wholly abandon conceiving of conditions.

Existent and nonexistent, dependently arisen phenomena:
for these there is no arising.
They come forth through the delusion of habitual tendencies,
and from that the three realms of existence appear.

In truth there is no arising from conditions,
and there is no ceasing either.
When all conditioned things are well examined,
they are just like flowers in the sky.

Abandon entirely the mistaken view
of the grasped and the grasper.
There is no producing and no arising;
causes and conditions do not exist either.
Since nothing at all appears,
all of these are mere expression.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati again said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain the Dharma discourse called the Essence of the Characteristics of Verbal Conceptuality. Blessed One, by fully understanding this Dharma discourse called the Essence of the Characteristics of Verbal Conceptuality, I and the other bodhisattva mahāsattvas will grasp the meaning of the two, expression and what is expressed. Then, having quickly and fully awakened into unsurpassed, perfect and complete enlightenment, we will purify all sentient beings by means of the two kinds of expression."

The Blessed One said, "Therefore, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Excellent, Blessed One," and listened as instructed. The Blessed One then spoke as follows:

"Mahāmati, verbal conceptuality has four kinds of characteristic, namely: the speech of characteristics, the speech of dreams, the speech of clinging to the conceptuality of dysfunctional tendencies, and the speech of beginningless conceptuality. Of these, the speech of characteristics arises from clinging to the characteristics of forms conceived by one's own conceptuality. The speech of dreams arises from recollecting objects experienced before, and from those objects having no real existence once one has woken. The speech of clinging to the conceptuality of dysfunctional tendencies arises from recollecting harmful deeds done in the past by enemies. The speech of beginningless conceptuality arises from the habitual tendencies of one's own seeds of dysfunction, which cling to the conceptual proliferations of beginningless time. These are called the four kinds of characteristic of verbal conceptuality."

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati, for the sake of that same matter, again made a request to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain further the domain in which conceptuality manifests. Blessed One, from where, for what purpose, how, and through what cause does the conceptual speech of sentient beings arise?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, sound and speech arise from the coming together of the head, the chest, the throat, the nose, the lips, the tongue, the palate and the teeth."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, are speech and conceptuality different, or are they one?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, speech and conceptuality are neither different nor not different. Why is that? Because speech has the characteristic of arising from conceptuality as its cause. Mahāmati, if speech and conceptuality were different, conceptuality could not be its cause. If they were not different, speech could not make its meaning clear, yet it does make it clear. Therefore they are neither different nor not different."

Mahāmati again said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, is speech itself the ultimate, or is what speech expresses the ultimate?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, speech is not the ultimate, and what speech expresses is not the ultimate either. Why is that? Because the ultimate is the truth of the noble ones. Although speech is directed toward the ultimate, this speech itself is not the ultimate. The ultimate is to be realized by the individually self-aware wisdom of the noble ones; it is not the domain of an intellect bound by verbal conceptuality. Therefore verbal conceptuality does

not make the ultimate clear. Speech, moreover, is set in motion by arising and perishing, and comes about from causes and conditions that depend on one another.

If words arise from one another's causes and conditions, they do not make the ultimate clear. Mahāmati, because there is no entity that is self, other, or both, the characteristic of words does not make the ultimate clear. Furthermore, Mahāmati, because words follow what is merely the appearance of one's own mind, and because the various kinds of signs and external entities are not entities, conceptualization through words does not make the ultimate clear. Therefore, Mahāmati, one should completely abandon the characteristics of conceptualizations through words.

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

All things are without intrinsic nature,
And words too do not exist.
The profound meaning of emptiness, of the empty,
The childish are unable to realize.
All things and their intrinsic nature,
And the phenomena of words, are like illusions.
The wisdom of self-awareness, the limit of reality,
I have taught to my sons.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, again addressed the Blessed One with these words: "Blessed One, please explain the following. It is free of existence and nonexistence, of oneness and difference, of both and neither, of neither existence nor nonexistence, and of permanence and impermanence. It cannot be traversed by any non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). It is traversed by the noble wisdom that each one realizes for oneself. It is free of the imputed particular and general characteristics. It enters the meaning of ultimate reality itself. It is the characteristic of purification, which links the grounds and becomes progressively more distinguished, higher and higher. It is the characteristic of entering the ground of the Tathāgata. Through former aspirations, without effort, like a wish-fulfilling jewel of various forms, it takes the aspect of the characteristic of an infinite range of activity. Please explain these, and all phenomena with the distinguishing characteristics of the way one's own mind appears, so that I and the other bodhisattva great beings may abandon such views as those of the imputed nature and of particular and

general characteristics, quickly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening, and then bring the perfect happiness of all sentient beings to completion."

The Blessed One said: "Excellent, Mahāmati, excellent! Your asking me about this matter has come about for the happiness of many people, for the benefit of many people, and out of compassion for the whole world of gods and humans. Therefore, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall analyze it and explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Excellent, Blessed One," and listened to his words. The Blessed One then spoke thus:

"Mahāmati, childish ordinary beings do not understand that things are merely the appearance of their own minds, and they grasp at inner and outer entities. Relying on the cause, the habitual tendencies, of the natures of oneness and difference, both and neither, existence and nonexistence, neither existence nor nonexistence, and permanence and impermanence, they conceptualize with fixation.

"For example, deer tormented by thirst mistakenly conceive of a springtime mirage as water and run toward it, not recognizing that it is not water. In the same way, childish ordinary beings, their minds tormented by the fire of the three poisons, saturated through beginningless time with the conceptuality of elaboration, deeply attached to the domain of form, viewing arising, abiding and perishing, and grasping at outer and inner entities, perceive things as one or different, both or neither, existent or nonexistent, neither existent nor nonexistent, and permanent or impermanent, and so fall into holding conceptual views.

"For example, in a city of the gandharvas, childish ordinary beings lacking understanding form the perception of a city. Though it appears to them through perceptions fixated on habitual tendencies since beginningless time, it is neither a city nor not a city. In the same way, the non-Buddhists, fixated since beginningless time on the habitual tendencies of elaboration, abide in views of oneness and difference, both and neither, existence and nonexistence, neither existence nor nonexistence, and permanence and impermanence, and therefore do not understand that things are merely the appearance of their own minds.

"For example, a certain person in a dream imagines that he has entered a place beautified with various kinds of men, women, elephants, horses,

chariots, foot soldiers, villages, towns, parks, forests, mountains, rivers and ponds. Then he wakes up and recollects it. Mahāmati, what do you think? If that man keeps recollecting what he dreamed before and does not let it go, is he of a wise nature?"

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "No, Blessed One."

The Blessed One said to Mahāmati: "In the same way, childish ordinary beings, gripped by wrong views, with the minds of non-Buddhists, do not know that the entities that appear to their own minds are like a dream, and so they rely on views of oneness and difference, both and neither, existence and nonexistence, neither existence nor nonexistence, and permanence and impermanence.

"For example, although a painted picture has no high and low, the childish conceive of it as having high and low. In the same way, in the future, because the habitual tendencies of the wrong views of the non-Buddhists will have grown very strong, they will rely on views of oneness and difference, both and neither, existence and nonexistence, neither existence nor nonexistence, and permanence and impermanence, and so destroy both themselves and others. There will also arise those who call nonexistent others who teach non-arising, which has abandoned existence and nonexistence. These people deny the view of cause and effect, uproot the roots of virtue, and destroy the cause of purification. Therefore those who seek the supreme should keep far away from them."

Those who speak in this way fall into the views of self, of other, and of both. Having imagined existence and nonexistence, they fall into the bad views of superimposition and denial, and so they will fall into hell.

Take people whose eyes are affected by cataracts. They see a net of hairs and say to great crowds of people, "Friends, look at this!" Yet that net of hairs is ultimately neither an existent thing nor a nonexistent thing, because it is both seen and not seen. In the same way, the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), whose outlook is shaped by bad views, rely entirely on the views of oneness, difference, both, and neither; of existence, nonexistence, and neither existence nor nonexistence; and of permanence and impermanence. By denying the true Dharma, they bring about their own downfall and the downfall of others as well.

Take the wheel of a whirling firebrand. Although it is not a wheel, the childish imagine it to be a wheel, but the wise do not. In the same way, the

non-Buddhists, whose outlook is shaped by bad views, rely on imagining oneness, difference, both, and neither; existence, nonexistence, and neither existence nor nonexistence; and permanence and impermanence, and so they produce all things.

Take a water bubble that looks like a jewel. Childish people who lack understanding perceive it as a jewel, cling to it, run after it and try to take it. Yet those bubbles are neither jewels nor non-jewels, because they are both taken and not taken. In the same way, the non-Buddhists, thoroughly imbued with the habitual tendencies of conceptual thought born of bad views, will claim that what does not exist arises, and that what exists through conditions is destroyed.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are the three kinds of valid cognition and the five members of a formal argument. Having set these out one by one, they say, "We will realize the noble wisdom to be known by oneself, which is free of the entities of the two natures," and they conceive of things as existent and cling to them. Mahāmati, consider the yogin who has transformed the basis of mind, of mentation, of mental consciousness, and of the body, who has completely abandoned the conceptual thought of grasped and grasper, which are appearances of his own mind, and who has attained the ground of the Tathāgata, the noble wisdom known by oneself. That yogin should not form any perception of it as an existent thing or as a nonexistent thing. If a yogin were to produce, toward such domains of experience, signs that grasp at existence or nonexistence, that would amount to grasping at a nourisher, grasping at a self, and grasping at a person.

Mahāmati, all teachings of this kind about the intrinsic nature of things and their particular and general characteristics are taught by the emanation buddha, not by the buddha of the nature of reality. Moreover, these teachings arise by force of the dispositions of childish ordinary beings who hold views. They do not set apart, distinguish and teach the Dharma whose very nature is the attainment of abiding in the bliss of the meditative absorption of noble wisdom known by oneself.

Take the reflection of a tree that appears in water. It is neither a reflection nor a non-reflection, neither the shape of a tree nor something other than the shape of a tree. In the same way, those who cling to conceptual thought thoroughly imbued with the habitual tendencies of non-Buddhist views rely on perceiving oneness, difference, both, and neither; existence, nonexistence,

and neither existence nor nonexistence; and permanence and impermanence. Therefore they do not understand that all this is merely the appearance of their own mind.

Take a well-polished mirror. Within it, according to the conditions, all reflections appear without any conceptual thought. They are neither form nor non-form. Yet the childish, who conceive of them as seen to be form and non-form, form the perception of form. In the same way, the non-Buddhists who hold bad views and cling, through conceptual thought, to the forms that are appearances of their own mind, rely entirely on the views of oneness, difference, both, and neither; of existence, nonexistence, and neither existence nor nonexistence; and of permanence and impermanence.

Take the sound that arises when wind meets flowing water. It is neither a thing nor a non-thing. In the same way, the non-Buddhist logicians who hold bad views rely entirely on the views of oneness, difference, both, and neither; of existence, nonexistence, and neither existence nor nonexistence; and of permanence and impermanence.

Take a great expanse of land without grass or trees, where, under the light of a scorching sun, the waves of a mirage shimmer. That mirage is neither a thing nor a nonthing, because it is both clung to and not clung to. In the same way, childish ordinary beings, imbued since beginningless time with the habitual tendencies of conceptual elaboration, who through conceptual thought cling to arising, abiding, and perishing, rely entirely on oneness, difference, both, and neither; existence, nonexistence, and neither existence nor nonexistence; and permanence and impermanence. Therefore even their apprehension of the gateway to what is to be known by oneself is just like those mirage waves.

Take someone who, by means of mantras and mechanical devices, causes something not reckoned a sentient being to appear and, joined with a spirit, to perform the act of moving. The childish, through conceptual thought, cling to it as going and coming. In the same way, the non-Buddhists, whose outlook is shaped by bad views, rely on the views of oneness, difference, both, and neither; of existence, nonexistence, and neither existence nor nonexistence; and of permanence and impermanence. Clinging to conceptual elaborations, they superimpose what is not real.

Therefore, Mahāmati, those who long for the reality of the noble wisdom that is personally realized should completely abandon the concepts of wrong views:

arising, abiding and perishing; oneness, difference, both and neither; existence, nonexistence, and neither existence nor nonexistence; permanence, impermanence, and the rest.

Then, to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Like an illusion, a dream, a tree's reflection in water,
Like a tangle of floating hairs, like a mirage:
When one fully realizes the three realms of existence in this way,
In the end one becomes completely liberated.

A thirsty deer's perception stirs,
And because its mind is deceived by this,
It imagines water in the mirage,
Yet no real water is there at all.

In the same way consciousness, bearing its seeds,
Stirs and changes, and appears as objects.
The concepts that arise in the childish
Are like the specks seen by one with cataracts.

Throughout beginningless saṃsāra
They grasp at things as real and cling to them.
As one peg is driven out by its opposite peg,
Abandon the grasping that is the cause of desire.

When one fully sees things as an illusion, a vetāla, a mechanical puppet,
As a cloud, a dream, or lightning,
One is liberated,
And abandons the three streams forever.

Here there is no agent whatsoever;
It is just like a mirage in the sky.
When one fully knows phenomena in this way,
There is nothing whatever to be known.

The teachings are mere names;
They have no defining characteristics.
The formations of the aggregates, in which concepts are produced,
Are like floating hairs.

A painting, a tangle of floating hairs,
An illusion, a dream, a city of gandharvas,
A firebrand's wheel, a mirage:

Though they do not exist, they appear to beings.

Permanent and impermanent, one and different,
Both and neither, likewise:
Bound by beginningless faults,
The childish imagine these out of their inclinations.

In a mirror, in water, in eyes,
And in the precious wish-fulfilling jewel,
Reflections do appear,
Yet they do not truly exist.

All that appears as real things
Is like a painting or a mirage.
Though forms appear in many different aspects,
They are like a dream and do not exist.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the Dharma taught by the tathāgatas is free from the four alternatives. That is to say, it abandons oneness, difference, both and neither; existence, nonexistence, and neither existence nor nonexistence; permanence and impermanence; and it is liberated from superimposition and denial with respect to existence and nonexistence. The Tathāgata's teaching of the Dharma, because it discloses and gathers together truth, dependent origination, the path, cessation and liberation, puts these first. It does not teach the Dharma in connection with primal nature (prakṛti), with a supreme Lord (Īśvara), with causelessness, with atoms, with time, or with inherent nature.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, in order to purify the obscurations of the afflictions and of the knowable, it proceeds step by step, like a caravan leader, into the hundred and eight statements, and into the characteristics that thoroughly distinguish the imageless, the vehicles, and the grounds.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are four kinds of meditative concentration. What are the four? They are the concentration practiced by the childish, the concentration that examines meaning, the concentration that takes suchness as its object, and the concentration of the tathāgatas.

Of these, what is the concentration practiced by the childish? It is this: śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and yogis among the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) begin with attachment to the selflessness of persons and to the specific and

general characteristics of things, to the skeleton, to impermanence, to suffering, and to the characteristic of the unattractive. Having examined these, thinking, "This has such and such a characteristic and not otherwise," they become more and more distinguished, each stage beyond the one before. That which does not bring perception to cessation is called the concentration practiced by the childish.

What is the concentration that examines meaning? It is this: having examined the selflessness of persons, the specific and general characteristics, and the self, other and both of the non-Buddhists as having become nonentities, one examines the selflessness of phenomena, and the meaning of the characteristics of those grounds becomes more and more distinguished. This is called the concentration that examines meaning.

What is the concentration that takes suchness as its object? It is this: abiding in the state of reality as it is, one no longer gives rise to the concept that conceives the two kinds of selflessness by means of conceptuality. This is called the concentration that takes suchness as its object.

What is the concentration of the tathāgatas? It is this: entering into the aspect of the tathāgata ground, one abides in the bliss of the threefold characteristic of the noble wisdom that is personally realized, and performs inconceivable deeds for the benefit of sentient beings. This is called the concentration of the tathāgatas.

Then, to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The concentration practiced by the childish,
The concentration that examines the characteristics of meaning,
The concentration that takes suchness as its object,
And the virtuous concentration of the tathāgatas.

When the yogi strives,
Things like the shape of the sun and the moon,
Like a lotus and like an abyss,
Like space and like a spent fire,

Whatever the yogi imagines,
Those various signs
Are concentrations that open the path of the tīrthikas,
And also make one fall
Into the domain of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas.

When all of these are entirely abandoned,
That is the imageless.
The buddhas of all the buddhafields,
With their inconceivable hands,
Stroke that one's head,
And he is deemed to have entered in accord with suchness.

Then the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, as for what is called nirvāṇa, to what kind of phenomenon is the name nirvāṇa given?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, the transformation of the ālaya, which holds the habitual tendencies of all intrinsic natures, of manas and of mental consciousness, and of the habitual tendencies of views, is called nirvāṇa. The nirvāṇa of the buddhas and of myself is the domain of the reality that is the emptiness of intrinsic nature.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, nirvāṇa is the domain of the noble wisdom that is personally realized. It is free from conceiving permanence and annihilation, and from conceiving existence and nonexistence."

How is it not permanent? It is not permanent because it has abandoned conceptualization in terms of individual and general characteristics. How is it not annihilation? It is not annihilation because all the noble ones of the past, future, and present have attained personal realization.

Mahāmati, nirvāṇa does not perish and does not die. If nirvāṇa were something that dies, it would take up once again the continuum of rebirth. If it were something that perishes, it would fall into the characteristics of the conditioned. Therefore, because nirvāṇa is free from perishing and dying, it is the refuge to which yogins go.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, what is not abandoned, not attained, not annihilated, not permanent, not of one meaning, and not of various meanings is called nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the nirvāṇa of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas consists in understanding individual and general characteristics, in being free from the bustle of sense-objects, and in conceptual thought not arising from seeing things in an inverted way. For them, this becomes the notion of nirvāṇa.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the characteristic of intrinsic nature is of two kinds. What are the two? They are attachment to the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of verbal expression, and attachment to the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of things. Of these, attachment to the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of verbal expression arises from attachment to the habitual tendencies of verbal proliferation since beginningless time. Attachment to the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of things arises from not understanding that it is merely the appearance of one's own mind.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, because the Tathāgatas establish two kinds of sustaining power, the bodhisattva great beings bow their heads at the feet of the buddhas and ask their questions. What are the two kinds of sustaining power that are established? They are the sustaining power of entering into meditative absorption and of fully displaying the body, face, and speech; and the sustaining power of empowerment by the hand.

Here, Mahāmati, on the first bodhisattva ground the bodhisattva great beings abide in the sustaining power of the buddhas. Thus they enter the meditative absorption called the Illumination of the Great Vehicle of Bodhisattvas, and immediately upon entering that meditative absorption, through the force of the sustaining power of the buddhas dwelling in the worlds of the ten directions, they fully display body, face, and speech in every way, just as with the bodhisattva great being Vajragarbha and other bodhisattva great beings endowed with qualities of that kind. Mahāmati, this is called the full attainment by the bodhisattva great beings on the first bodhisattva ground of the sustaining power for entering meditative absorption, and it is accomplished through roots of virtue accumulated over a hundred thousand eons.

Gradually, by thoroughly understanding the characteristics of the antidotes and the adverse factors of the grounds, the bodhisattva enters the ground called Cloud of Dharma. Dwelling in a special great lotus palace, seated on a lion throne of a great jeweled lotus, surrounded by a retinue of bodhisattva great beings of equal fortune, the body thoroughly adorned with garlands of various jewels, he is like refined gold, like the campaka flower, and like the rays of the sun and moon. The Victors who have come from the ten directions confer empowerment from the crown of the head upon the one seated on the throne in the great lotus palace. Because they confer empowerment on the crown just as is done for a sovereign lord, for a wheel-turning king, or for the son of the lord of the gods (Indra), this is called the bodhisattvas' sustaining power of empowerment by the hand.

Mahāmati, these are called the two kinds of sustaining power of the bodhisattva great beings. If bodhisattva great beings abide in these two kinds of sustaining power, they are able to see all the buddhas; otherwise they are not able to see them.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, whatever the bodhisattva great beings have in the way of meditative absorption, miraculous powers, and the various distinctions of the activity of teaching the Dharma, all of it is due to their abiding in the two kinds of sustaining power of the Tathāgata. Mahāmati, if bodhisattva great beings were able to teach the Dharma through eloquence even when entirely separated from the sustaining power of the buddhas, then all childish ordinary beings would also be able to teach the Dharma. Why is that? Because they do not abide in the sustaining power.

Mahāmati, through the sustaining power of the Tathāgata when he enters a city, the sound of music arises spontaneously from mountains, rocks, trees, timber, all kinds of musical instruments, cities, towns, houses, and palaces, from all of them; what need then to speak of those who have minds? Even the deaf, the blind, and the mute are freed from their various sufferings. In this way, the Tathāgata benefits sentient beings through immeasurable sustaining powers such as these.

The bodhisattva Mahāmati again asked the Blessed One, "Blessed One, for what cause and for what condition do the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, bestow their sustaining power on bodhisattva great beings at the time they enter meditative absorption, and on those who are at the time of the special empowerment?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, it is in order to remove the deeds of māra and the afflictions. It is so that they do not fall into the stage of the śrāvakas and into meditative concentration, and so that they attain the Tathāgata's stage of what is personally realized. And it is in order to increase the qualities to be attained and make them ever more excellent. Therefore the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, bestow their sustaining power on the bodhisattva great beings by establishing it in them. If they were not sustained by that sustaining power, they would fall into the conceptual thought of the evil views of the tīrthikas, into that of the śrāvakas, and into the intentions of māra, and they would not fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfectly complete awakening. For this reason, then, the Tathāgatas take the bodhisattva great beings into their care through their sustaining power."

Then the Blessed One, in order to teach that same meaning once more, spoke these verses:

The sustaining power of the lords of men,
with their great and utterly pure aspirations,
brings meditative absorption and empowerment,
from the first ground and through the ten.

From the Noble Sūtra of the Precious Descent into Laṅkā, the fourth fascicle.

Then the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati again addressed the Blessed One, saying, "When the Blessed One taught dependent origination, he merely gave an account of causes and conditions, but did not speak of his own system. Blessed One, the tīrthikas too teach dependent origination; that is, they state that things arise from the Principal (pradhāna), from the Lord (Īśvara), from time, and from atoms. The Blessed One, too, says and states that things arise from causes and conditions; so in this statement as well there is a tenet with something intervening and a tenet with nothing intervening. Blessed One, the tīrthikas too state that things arise from what exists and from what does not exist. The Blessed One too says that things come about from what did not exist, and that once they have come about they perish. Thus, when the Blessed One taught that with ignorance as condition there are formations, and so on up to aging and death, here too the Blessed One gave the account of those who assert causelessness; he did not teach the view of those who assert causes. The Blessed One's formulation, 'Because this exists, this arises,' this third one, is not established as a gradual arising; so it is the tīrthikas' account that should be upheld, and not the Tathāgata's. Why is that? Blessed One, the tīrthikas bring about a result through a cause that is not dependently originated. But for the Blessed One the cause depends on the thing, and the thing in turn depends on the cause, so that causes and conditions become confused, and likewise there would be an endless regress of mutual dependence."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, I am not one who asserts causelessness, nor one who asserts a confusion of causes and conditions. For the statement 'Because this exists, this arises' rests on understanding that the grasped and the grasper have no essential nature, and that they are merely appearances of one's own mind. Mahāmati, such a fault befalls those who cling to the grasped and the grasper, who do not understand that the things that are external objects are not things, and who do not understand that these are merely

appearances of one's own mind; but it does not befall my dependent origination."

Mahāmati again asked, "Blessed One, if expressions are not existent things, would not all things also be nonexistent? Blessed One, if things were nonexistent, then expressions could not arise either. Therefore, Blessed One, since expressions exist as things, all things exist as well."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, there are expressions even for things that do not exist, such as the horns of a rabbit and the hair of a tortoise. These do appear as expressions in the world, Mahāmati, yet they are neither things nor non-things; they are nothing but mere expressions. If, as you have said, all things existed because expressions have inherent existence, then your argument would collapse. Mahāmati, expression does not exist in all the buddha-fields; expression is something fabricated. Mahāmati, in some buddha-fields the Dharma is taught by not blinking, in some by showing signs, in some by moving the eyebrows, in some by glancing of the eyes, in some by laughing, in some by yawning, in some by the sound of snapping the fingers, in some by recollecting the field, and in some by trembling. Mahāmati, for example, in the world-system Animiṣa, in Gandhakūṭa, and in the buddha-field of the Tathāgata Samantabhadra, merely by gazing with unblinking eyes the Tathāgata causes the bodhisattvas to attain acceptance of the nonarising of phenomena, as well as other special samādhis. Therefore, Mahāmati, it is not the case that all things exist because expressions exist. Mahāmati, this can be seen in this world as well: beings such as insects and bees carry out their own activities without any speech."

Then the Blessed One, in order to teach that same meaning once more, spoke these verses:

Space, and the horns of a rabbit,
and the sons of a barren woman, too,
are spoken of in words though they do not exist;
so too is the conceptualizing of things.
In phenomena gathered from causes and conditions
the childish imagine an arising;
because they do not understand this principle,
they wander on in the abode of the three existences.

Then once more the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati addressed the Blessed One, saying:

"To what does the Blessed One apply the word 'permanent'?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, to delusion. This delusion appears even to the noble ones, but not as something inverted. Mahāmati, in the world the unwise grasp mirages, the wheel of a whirling firebrand, tangled hair, the cities of the gandharvas, illusions, dreams and reflections in an inverted way. The wise do not, though it is not that these things fail to appear to them.

"Mahāmati, although those delusions appear in many forms, the delusion is not thereby made impermanent. Why is that? Because it is free of both existence and nonexistence.

"How, Mahāmati, is delusion free of existence and nonexistence? Because the domains of experience of all the childish are various. The river Ganges is seen by some hungry ghosts and not seen by others. In the same way, delusion is not an existent thing. Yet because it appears to others, it is not nonexistent either. So for the noble ones delusion is free of being either inverted or not inverted, and therefore delusion is permanent, because the defining mark of signs does not perish. Mahāmati, delusion is not a variety of signs. Because the signs of conceptual thought perish, delusion is permanent.

"How, Mahāmati, is delusion itself reality? When the noble ones give rise neither to an inverted cognition nor to a non-inverted cognition toward this delusion of causes and conditions. Mahāmati, apart from the noble ones, holding even the slightest perception regarding this delusion is not the mark of the reality of noble wisdom. Mahāmati, this word 'slightest' is spoken through the imaginings of the childish. It is not spoken by the noble.

"That same delusion, imagined as inverted or not inverted, gives rise to two kinds of lineage: the lineage of the noble ones and the lineage of childish ordinary beings. The noble lineage is further divided into three: the vehicle of the śrāvakas, the vehicle of the pratyekabuddhas, and the vehicle of the buddhas.

"How do childish ordinary beings, through their imagining, give rise to the lineage of the śrāvaka vehicle? By clinging to particular and general characteristics they come to belong to the śrāvaka lineage. In this way, through purification, they give rise to the lineage of the śrāvaka vehicle.

"Mahāmati, imagining that very delusion gives rise to the lineage of the pratyekabuddha vehicle: when one meditates on that very delusion in terms of its particular and general characteristics, but without clinging, one gives rise to

the lineage of the pratyekabuddha vehicle.

"How do the wise, imagining that very delusion, give rise to the lineage of the buddha vehicle? When, having realized that it is merely the appearance of one's own mind, one does not conceptualize external things as either existent or nonexistent, one gives rise to the lineage of the buddha vehicle. This is called giving rise to the lineage of the buddha vehicle from that very delusion.

"Moreover, when the childish imagine delusion as the intrinsic nature of various things, they give rise to the lineage of childish ordinary beings. That which is neither an existent thing nor a nonexistent thing is called the meaning of lineage.

"Mahāmati, because the noble ones do not conceptualize that very delusion, they pass beyond mind, mentation and mental consciousness. The reality that has become other than phenomena whose nature is habitual tendencies is called suchness. That is why I have spoken the words 'Suchness is liberated from mind,' and, to show the abandonment of signs, I have said, 'It is free of all signs.'"

Mahāmati asked the Blessed One, "Blessed One, does delusion exist, or does it not exist?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, like an illusion, it has no characteristic of clinging. If delusion had the characteristic of clinging, the clinging to things could not be turned back, and this dependent origination would become like the arising from causes taught by the tīrthikas."

Mahāmati asked the Blessed One, "Blessed One, if that delusion is like an illusion, it would then act as the cause of further afflictions."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, an illusion is not a cause of delusion, because it does not produce the faults of negative tendencies (dauṣṭhulya). Mahāmati, an illusion does not produce the faults of negative tendencies, because it is free of conceptual thought. Mahāmati, an illusion arises from the power of someone else's spell. It is not born from the habitual tendencies of the negative tendencies of one's own conceptual thought, and therefore it does not produce faults. Mahāmati, this clinging belongs to the deluded minds of childish ordinary beings, not to the noble ones."

Then, to teach that same point again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"The noble do not see delusion,
Nor is there reality in the middle.

If that middle were real,
Delusion too would be real.
Even when all delusion is abandoned,
If one still gives rise to a sign,
That too is delusion,
Like the impurity of blurred sight.

"Moreover, Mahāmati, since nothing other than illusion is comparable to phenomena, all phenomena are seen as like illusions."

Mahāmati asked the Blessed One, "Blessed One, are all phenomena like illusions because of clinging to the characteristics of various illusions, or because of clinging to distinct characteristics? If all things are like illusions because of clinging to the characteristics of illusions of various kinds, then, Blessed One, things would be like illusions."

"Why is that? Because the characteristic of various forms does not lack a cause, Blessed One, while there is no cause at all that makes the characteristic of various forms appear like an illusion. Therefore, Blessed One, since things share no common property with clinging to the characteristic of various illusions, things are not like illusions."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, it is true that all phenomena are not like illusions by sharing a common property with clinging to the characteristic of various illusions. Nevertheless, Mahāmati, all phenomena are unreal, and because they perish swiftly, like lightning, they are called illusion-like. Mahāmati, a flash of lightning, for example, arises in an instant, and once it has arisen it perishes, yet this does not appear to ordinary childish beings. In the same way, all phenomena also appear because one does not discern that the specific and general characteristics imagined by one's own conceptual thought have no reality as entities, and because one is not free from attachment to the characteristic of form."

Then the Blessed One spoke this verse to teach that same meaning again:

"Not through sharing illusion's nonexistence
Are things declared to be illusion.
Because they are unreal, like lightning,
For that reason they are called illusion-like."

Mahāmati again said to the Blessed One, "The Blessed One has said that all things are unborn and that they are like illusions. In declaring this, would not the Blessed One's earlier and later words fall into the fault of contradiction, since he has said that things are without arising and that they are like illusions?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, although I declare things to be without arising and to be like illusions, my earlier and later words do not fall into the fault of contradiction. Why is that? Because arising is understood as without arising, as merely the appearance of one's own mind, and because external entities and non-entities are seen not to arise from existence or from nonexistence. Therefore, Mahāmati, my earlier and later words do not fall into the fault of contradiction. Rather, in order to refute the arising from causes asserted by the tīrthikas, I have taught that all things are unborn.

"Mahāmati, the many assemblies of foolish tīrthikas maintain that things arise from what exists and from what does not exist, and not through the condition of clinging to the diversity of their own conceptual thought. Mahāmati, for me, things do not arise from existence, nor do they arise from nonexistence. That is why I speak in the language of non-arising.

"Mahāmati, it is explained that I teach things as entities in order to encompass saṃsāra, in order to turn back the annihilationist view that says 'there is nothing,' and in order to show my disciples how the place of birth is taken up through various actions; it is for this that the word 'entity' is used to encompass saṃsāra.

"Mahāmati, the teaching of the illusion-like nature and characteristic is in order to abandon the nature and characteristic of entities. Because ordinary childish beings, whose minds have fallen into the characteristic of wrong views, do not understand that this is merely the appearance of their own mind, and in order to set straight those who cling to the specific characteristics of cause, condition and activity, all phenomena are taught as having the nature and characteristic of an illusion and a dream. This is so that ordinary childish beings with wrongly viewing minds, clinging to self, to others and to all phenomena, should by no means speak wrongly against those who see the abode of reality just as it is. Mahāmati, seeing the true abiding of all phenomena just as it is means going beyond what is merely the appearance of one's own mind."

Then the Blessed One spoke this verse to teach that same meaning:

"Non-arising: there is no maker, no entity.
Through entities saṃsāra is gathered in.
When one sees them as like illusion and the rest,
One does not conceive of characteristics."

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, I shall explain the characteristic of the groups of names, phrases and letters. The bodhisattva great being who thoroughly understands the groups of names, phrases and letters, and who thereby follows the meaning and the groups of phrases and letters, swiftly awakens fully and perfectly to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening; and having fully and perfectly awakened, he brings all sentient beings likewise to understanding.

"Mahāmati, among these, what is called the group of names is this: that by which a name is designated in dependence on some thing is called the group of names. Mahāmati, the group of phrases is this: a phrase that possesses a group of meanings, that is definite in its own essential nature, and that is complete is called the group of phrases. Mahāmati, the group of letters is this: that by which names and phrases are made clear is called the group of letters. Again, the group of letters is this: long, short, high and low. Again, the group of phrases is like the tracks of those who go: the tracks of elephants, horses, people, deer and others that go upon the ground receive the name 'group of phrases.'

"Mahāmati, name and letter are as follows. It is name because by name the four formless aggregates are expressed. It is letter because it makes its own characteristic appear. These are called the groups of names and letters. This is the characteristic of expressing the groups of names, phrases and letters, and you should train in it diligently."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses to teach that same meaning again:

Among names, among groups of words,
and in the distinctions of collections of letters,
the ignorant, childish ones become attached,
like an elephant sunk in a mire.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, in times to come, the wise will ask those unskilled ones about the meanings I have realized, which are free from the defining marks of the views of oneness, otherness, both, and neither. Then those unskilled ones will say, "This is not a proper question." The questions are these: whether form and the like are one with impermanence or different from

it; and likewise whether formations are one with nirvāṇa or different from it, the basis of characteristics with the characteristic, the possessor of a quality with the quality, the elemental derivatives with the elements, what is seen with seeing, the minute particle with dust, and the yogin with the practice. Of these and other such questions, put in the manner of characteristics inferred mutually, one from the other, they will say, "The Blessed One has answered them."

The answer by setting aside will not be understood by those deluded persons. Because they lack the intelligence needed to listen, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, do not answer what is not to be answered, so as to spare them a cause of fear. Moreover, these matters are left unexplained in order to dismantle the view-doctrines of the tīrthikas.

Mahāmati, the tīrthikas speak like this: "The life principle is the very same as the body," and so on, speaking of what is not to be answered. Mahāmati, it is the tīrthikas, bewildered about causes, who speak of what is not to be answered; it is not so in that scripture of mine. Mahāmati, my scripture is free from grasped and grasper, and in it conceptual thought does not arise.

If one asks how these questions are set aside: Mahāmati, for those who cling to grasped and grasper and do not know them to be merely the appearance of their own mind, there is setting aside.

Mahāmati, the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, teach the Dharma to sentient beings by four kinds of answer. Mahāmati, the answer by setting aside I have given from time to time to those whose faculties are not fully matured, but not to those whose faculties are fully matured.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, all phenomena are unarisen because they are free from the causes and conditions of production, and all phenomena are also unarisen because there is no maker.

Mahāmati, if one asks how all things are without essential nature: when one examines them with one's own intelligence, no thing is found that has either a particular or a general characteristic. Therefore all phenomena are said to be unarisen.

Mahāmati, if one asks how all phenomena are without coming and going: even if one wishes to take up particular and general characteristics, there is no place from which they come, and even if one wishes to cast them off, there is no place to which they go. Therefore all phenomena are free from coming and

going.

Mahāmati, if one asks why all phenomena are unceasing: because things have no characteristic of intrinsic nature, and because no phenomenon can be apprehended, all phenomena are unceasing.

Mahāmati, if one asks how all phenomena are impermanent: the arising of characteristics is impermanent. Therefore all phenomena are said to be impermanent.

Mahāmati, if one asks how all phenomena are permanent: the arising of characteristics is a non-arising, so the impermanence of things is itself permanent. Therefore all phenomena are said to be permanent.

Then, to teach that very meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Answers are of four kinds:
the categorical, the one by counter-question,
the one by analysis, and the one by setting aside.
By these the doctrines of the tīrthikas are refuted.

Arising from what exists and from what does not
is held by the Sāṃkhyas and the Vaiśeṣikas.
All that is not to be answered
was proclaimed by those very ones.

Even when the intellect examines them,
intrinsic natures are not apprehended.
Because they are beyond expression,
their freedom from intrinsic nature is taught.

Then the bodhisattva mahāsattva Mahāmati again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain the defining marks of the way the courses of stream-enterers are distinguished. Bodhisattva mahāsattvas who are skilled in the defining marks of the way the courses of stream-enterers are distinguished will understand the distinctions in the defining marks of the means of becoming a once-returner, a non-returner, and an arhat, and will then teach the Dharma to sentient beings in just that way. That is to say, having thoroughly purified the defining marks of the two selflessnesses and the two obscurations, they will realize and comprehend the passing beyond the defining marks of the grounds, ground after ground. Having attained the ultimate domain of the Tathāgata, which is inconceivable, they will greatly benefit all sentient beings, like a jewel that shows various forms, and they will

sustain them all with the domain of all phenomena, with bodies that answer their aspirations, and with enjoyments."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, listen well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Excellent, Blessed One. I shall do just that," and he listened as instructed. The Blessed One then spoke thus:

"Mahāmati, the fruit of stream-entry attained by stream-enterers is distinguished in three ways. What are the three? They are the lowest, the middling, and the supreme. Of these, the lowest is the one who, from the outset, has seven more lives of existence. The middling is the one who attains complete nirvāṇa after three or five existences. The supreme is the one who attains complete nirvāṇa in that very life. For these three there are three fetters, lesser, middling, and great. What are the three fetters? They are the view of the transitory collection, doubt, and holding moral discipline and ascetic observances as supreme. Through the distinctions of these three fetters they become ever more excellent and attain the fruit of arhatship."

Mahāmati, the view of the perishing collection (satkāyadṛṣṭi) is also of two kinds, namely, the innate and the imputed. It is like the conceptualization of the imputed nature upon the dependent nature. For example, in dependence on the dependent nature, various kinds of clinging to the imputed nature arise. That imputed nature is neither existent, nor nonexistent, nor both, because it has the characteristic of an unreal imputation. The clinging, through the conceptual thought of childish ordinary beings, to the characteristic of a varied nature is like the perception of water that arises in thirsty deer at a mirage. This is the stream-enterer's imputed view of the perishing collection. Because, through the selflessness of persons, it is apprehended as without substance, the long-standing ignorance and clinging are abandoned.

Mahāmati, as for the innate view: the stream-enterer sees his own body and the bodies of others as equal. The four aggregates lack the characteristic of form. Form arises from the elements and is derived from the elements. The elements have the characteristic of being mutual causes. Elements and forms are not an accumulation. For these reasons, when the stream-enterer examines the alternatives of existence and nonexistence, nothing appears to him, and so he abandons the view of the perishing collection. Having thus abandoned the view of the perishing collection, attachment does not arise in him. This is the characteristic of the view of the perishing collection.

Mahāmati, the characteristic of doubt is as follows. Because he has the characteristic of seeing clearly the Dharma he has attained, and because he has abandoned the conceptuality of the two kinds of view of the perishing collection described above, doubt about phenomena does not arise in him. He therefore does not give rise to a view of anyone else as his teacher, nor to views of pure or impure. This is the characteristic of the stream-enterer's abandonment of doubt.

Mahāmati, if one asks why the stream-enterer does not cling to moral discipline, it is like this: because he clearly sees the characteristic of suffering in the places of rebirth, he does not cling to it. Mahāmati, clinging is like this: childish ordinary beings unwaveringly take up austerities and observances, and through them seek rebirth, out of desire for enjoyments and happiness. He does not cling in that way. Rather, he dedicates otherwise, in this manner: in order to apply himself fully to the characteristic of undefiled phenomena, the distinctive state realized by oneself alone and free of conceptuality, he takes up and guards the factors of moral discipline. This is the characteristic of the stream-enterer's abandonment with regard to moral discipline and vows.

For the stream-enterer who has abandoned the three fetters, attachment and delusion do not arise. If a stream-enterer were to think, "These fetters are not established in me," there would be two faults: he would have fallen into the view of the perishing collection, and he would not have abandoned the fetters.

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Since the Blessed One has spoken of many kinds of attachment, which attachment has he abandoned?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, there is attachment that arises from the various means of craving and desiring women, of clinging and being attached to them, together with faulty actions of body and speech, by which one craves present happiness and suffering arises in the future. These do not occur in him. Why is that? Because he has attained abiding in the bliss of meditative absorption, he has abandoned that attachment. It is not that he has abandoned the attachment to realizing nirvāṇa.

"Mahāmati, what is the characteristic of the once-returner? It is like this: the vision in which the characteristic of form appears once and conceptuality arises no longer arises in him. Because he clearly sees the characteristic of meditative concentration, he comes back to this world and then all at once makes an end of suffering and attains nirvāṇa. Therefore he is called a once-returner.

"Mahāmati, how is one a non-returner? It is like this: past, future and present things with the characteristic of form are without substance for him; the afflicted conceptuality born of the fault of views does not arise in him; and he has abandoned the fetters. Therefore he is called a non-returner.

"Mahāmati, as for the arhat, it is like this: for him there is no substance in the conceptualization of meditative concentrations, meditative absorptions, liberations, powers, knowledges, afflictions and suffering. Therefore he is called an arhat."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "The Blessed One has declared that there are three kinds of arhats. To which arhats does the Blessed One declare that this applies here? Blessed One, is it the one who has attained the path through the single vehicle of solitary peace? Or is it the arhat whom bodhisattva mahāsattvas display in this way through skillful means? Or is it an emanation produced by the miraculous power of the Buddha?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, it is the śrāvaka who has attained it on the path of the single vehicle of solitary peace, not the others. The others are those who practice the conduct of bodhisattvas and those emanated by the miraculous power of the Buddha. Through skill in means and by the power of their former aspirations, they display birth within the circle of the retinue, in order to adorn the circle of the Buddha's retinue.

"Mahāmati, the various kinds of teaching given in the domain where conceptuality operates are these: the fruit to be attained and the meditative concentration to be attained. As for concentration: when one enters concentration, because of utter seclusion, and because one's own mind is shown as appearance, the characteristic of attaining the fruit is called attaining the fruit.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, if one wishes to pass completely beyond the meditative concentrations, the immeasurables and the formless realm, one should turn away from the characteristic of the appearances of one's own mind. Mahāmati, the meditative attainment of the cessation of perception and feeling cannot be called a passing beyond the appearances of one's own mind. Why is that? Because the appearances of mind are still present."

Then, in order to teach this very meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses.

Meditative concentrations and the four immeasurables,
the absorptions of the formless realm,
and the cessations of feeling and perception:
these do not exist in mind-only.
The fruit of the stream-enterer,
the once-returner and the non-returner,
and the fruits of the arhat:
all of these are confusions of the mind.
Meditative concentration and the support of concentration,
abandonment, and the correct seeing of the truths:
whoever realizes that these
are mere conceptualization is liberated.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, there are two kinds of intellect, namely the discerning intellect, and the intellect that establishes things through attachment to grasping the characteristics of conceptuality.

Of these, Mahāmati, the discerning intellect is this: when an intellect thoroughly analyzes the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of things, nothing is apprehended, because it is free of the four extremes. This is called the discerning intellect. Here, Mahāmati, the four extremes are these: one, different, both, and neither; existent, nonexistent, neither existent nor nonexistent; permanent and impermanent. These are explained as the four extremes. Mahāmati, what is free of these four extremes is called "all phenomena." Mahāmati, one should train thoroughly in examining all phenomena by means of these four extremes.

Then, Mahāmati, what is the intellect that establishes things through attachment to grasping the characteristics of conceptuality? It is this: it is the attachment to grasping the characteristics of conceptuality by which one asserts as a thesis that hardness, wetness, heat and motion, which are false conceptual characteristics, are the great elements, and which, through attachment to reasons and examples, establishes by a false establishment. That is called the intellect that establishes things through attachment to grasping the characteristics of conceptuality. These are the characteristics of the two kinds of intellect.

A bodhisattva, a great being, who possesses the characteristics of these two intellects comes to understand and realize the characteristic of the selflessness of persons and of phenomena, becomes skilled in the intellect free

of appearances, and, through discerning each of the grounds of practice, attains the first ground. He enters into a hundred samādhis, and attains also the samādhi without distinctions. He sees a hundred buddhas and a hundred bodhisattvas. He enters into the events of the past and future limits across a hundred eons. With his light he illuminates a hundred fields. Knowing the characteristics of the grounds, each higher than the last, through his distinguished great aspirations he gains mastery over miraculous displays, and he is empowered with the empowerment of the Cloud of Dharma. Having attained the Tathāgata's ground of personal self-realization, he comes to possess the ten culminating states. To bring sentient beings to maturity he is beautified with the various light rays of emanation, and he also attains meditative equipoise in the bliss of personal self-awareness.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva, a great being, should become skilled in the great elements and in what is derived from the elements. How does a bodhisattva become skilled in the great elements and in what is derived from the elements? Mahāmati, the bodhisattva, the great being, examines correctly in this way: in ultimate truth the great elements do not arise. He examines in this way that the great elements have no arising. Having examined thus, he realizes that names and signs are mere conceptuality and mere appearance of his own mind, and that external things have no existence; this is called the mere conceptuality of the appearance of one's own mind. That is to say, when one examines the elements of the three realms and what is derived from the elements, one sees that, being by their essential nature free of the four extremes, they are pure in mode, free of self and of what belongs to a self, abiding in the form of their own characteristic as the true characteristic, and established as the characteristic of non-arising.

Mahāmati, if one asks how the four great elements produce the forms of which they are the cause: the great element conceived as wetness produces the water element, outer and inner. The great element conceived as capacity for activity produces the fire element, outer and inner. The great element conceived as motion produces the wind element, outer and inner. The great element conceived as form that can be divided produces the earth element, outer and inner. Through attachment to a false truth regarding both form and space, the five aggregates come together, and the great elements and what is derived from the elements arise. Mahāmati, consciousness, through the cause of its attachment to various kinds of places and objects, takes rebirth in another destiny.

Mahāmati, the four great ones, earth and the others, and what is derived from the elements have the four great elements as their support, but the four great elements are not their condition. Why is that? Because thing, shape, characteristic, location, activity and application are nonexistent, the great elements do not arise. Mahāmati, because they arise from the coming together of thing, shape, characteristic, location, activity and application, they are not without shape. Therefore, Mahāmati, the characteristics of the great elements and of what is derived from the elements are imagined by the tīrthikas, but not by me.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, I shall teach the characteristic of the own-nature of the aggregates. What is the characteristic of the own-nature of the aggregates? It is the five aggregates. What are the five aggregates? They are form, feeling, perception, formations and consciousness. Among these, four aggregates are formless, namely feeling, perception, formations and consciousness. Mahāmati, form has the characteristic of the four great elements and what is derived from the elements being mutually discordant. Mahāmati, what is formless cannot be counted as four; it is like space. For example, space transcends the characteristic of number and is free from counting, yet through conceptuality it is called "space."

Mahāmati, in the same way the aggregates also transcend the characteristic of number. Being free of counting, they are free of both existence and nonexistence, and free of the four extremes. Number and the characteristic of counting are expressed by the childish, not by the noble ones. Mahāmati, the noble ones designate the many different forms as like an illusion, free of oneness and difference. Again, this is because, like a person in a dream or a person in a reflection, they are free of oneness and difference. Mahāmati, in the way of the noble ones' wisdom, it is through conceptual thought that things appear as resembling aggregates. That is the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of the aggregates, and you should dispel it. Having dispelled it, you should, by teaching the Dharma of utter solitude, dispel the views of the tīrthikas in all the buddhafields.

Mahāmati, when the Dharma of utter solitude is taught, the seeing of the selflessness of phenomena becomes pure, and one also enters the Immovable Ground. Having entered the Immovable Ground, one gains mastery over immeasurable meditative absorptions. By obtaining a mind-made body, one attains the illusion-like meditative absorption. By fully realizing the powers, the superknowledges and the masteries, one gathers and benefits all sentient

beings. Just as the great earth supports and benefits sentient beings, so too the bodhisattva, the great being, benefits all sentient beings.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the tīrthikas have four kinds of nirvāṇa. What are the four? They are: the nirvāṇa that is the nonexistence of the intrinsic nature of entities; the nirvāṇa that is the nonexistence of entities with various characteristics; the nirvāṇa that is the realization of the nonexistence of the intrinsic nature of particular characteristics; and the nirvāṇa that is the cutting off of the stream of the continuum of the particular and general characteristics of the aggregates. These are the nirvāṇas of the tīrthikas; they are not found in my teaching. Mahāmati, in my teaching, the turning back of consciousness accompanied by conceptual thought is called nirvāṇa.

Mahāmati asked, "Has the Blessed One not established eight consciousnesses?"

The Blessed One said, "I have established them."

Mahāmati asked, "Blessed One, if they are established, how is it that this is eliminated by the turning back of the mental consciousness, and not by that of the seven consciousnesses?"

The Blessed One said to Mahāmati, "Because it is their cause and the condition that is their object, the seven consciousnesses do not arise. Here the mental consciousness discriminates objects and, through clinging to them, generates habitual tendencies and so nourishes the all-base consciousness. Together with mentation it clings to self and to what is grasped as one's own, and since it arises through the condition of the thought 'I,' the characteristic of a body does not fall apart. It becomes the cause of the all-base consciousness and takes it as its object, and through clinging to objects that are the appearances of one's own mind, the assembled minds arise, each as the cause of the other. It is like the waves of the ocean: stirred by the wind of the domain of one's own appearances, they rise and subside in just the same way. Therefore, by turning back the mental consciousness, the seven consciousnesses also cease."

Then, in order to teach that very meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Not through activity, characteristics,
Or entities do I pass into nirvāṇa.
Consciousness conceives the knowable;

By turning it back I pass into nirvāṇa.

With that as cause and that as its object,
Through mentation the body, its going and so forth, are formed.
That which brings forth the cause is mind;
It acts as the basis of consciousness.

Just as when a great body of water is exhausted
Waves no longer arise in a stream,
So too, when mentation ceases,
The various consciousnesses do not arise.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, I shall explain the characteristics of the divisions of the imputed nature and the manner of realizing it. Skilled in the characteristics of the divisions of the imputed nature and the manner of realizing it, you and the other bodhisattvas, the great beings, will abandon imagining and abide in the noble wisdom realized individually by oneself; you will understand the ways of the tīrthikas; and having abandoned, with an intelligence that sees clearly, the conceptualization of grasped and grasper, you will not conceive the various characteristics of the dependent as formations of the imputed nature.

Here, Mahāmati, what are the characteristics of the divisions of the imputed nature? They are: conceptualization of expression, conceptualization of what is to be expressed, conceptualization of characteristics, conceptualization of wealth, conceptualization of intrinsic nature, conceptualization of cause, conceptualization of views, conceptualization of reasoning, conceptualization of arising, conceptualization of non-arising, conceptualization of connection, and conceptualization of bondage and non-bondage. These are the characteristics of the divisions of the imputed nature.

Here, Mahāmati, what is conceptualization of expression? It is clinging to sounds and to various melodious songs. This is called conceptualization of expression.

Mahāmati, what is conceptualization of what is to be expressed? It is this: whatever the intrinsic nature of an entity to be expressed may be, which is to be known by noble wisdom, abiding on that a form of expression arises. That is called conceptualization of what is to be expressed.

Mahāmati, what is conceptualization of characteristics? It is this: clinging to those very entities to be expressed, which are like a mirage, by clinging to them as having various characteristics; that is, conceiving all things in terms of the characteristics of hardness, wetness, heat and motion. That is called conceptualization of characteristics.

Mahāmati, what is conceptualization of wealth? Attachment to gold, silver and the many kinds of precious jewels is called conceptualization of wealth.

"Mahāmati, what is the conceptuality concerning intrinsic nature? It is this: holding things to have an essential nature, which is no different from the conceptuality of wrong view that thinks, 'This is just so and not otherwise.' That is called the conceptuality concerning intrinsic nature.

"Mahāmati, what is the conceptuality concerning causes? It is this: that by which, through causes and conditions, the characteristic of a cause is produced for the conceptions of existence and nonexistence. That is called the conceptuality concerning causes.

"Mahāmati, what is the conceptuality of views? It is this: the conceptuality that clings to the conceptions of the tīrthikas, who wrongly view things in terms of existence, nonexistence, oneness, difference, both, and neither. That is called the conceptuality of views.

"Mahāmati, what is the conceptuality of reasoning? It is this: arguing by reasoning about the characteristics of a self and of what belongs to a self. That is called the conceptuality of reasoning.

"Mahāmati, what is the conceptuality of production? It is this: clinging to the production of existent and nonexistent things through conditions. That is called the conceptuality of production.

"Mahāmati, what is the conceptuality of non-production? It is this: holding that all things were unborn from the very beginning, and that from no seed, through causes and conditions, a causeless body is produced. That is called the conceptuality of non-production.

"Mahāmati, what is the conceptuality of connection? It is this: connecting things as having the characteristic of being together with one another, just as gold and thread are. That is called the conceptuality of connection.

"Mahāmati, what is the conceptuality of bondage and non-bondage? It is this: clinging to a cause that binds and to something to be bound, like a person in full possession of his faculties who ties a knot in his hand and then loosens it.

That is called the conceptuality of bondage and non-bondage.

"Mahāmati, in these characteristics of the ways the imputed nature is divided, all childish ordinary beings cling to existence and nonexistence. Mahāmati, those who have come to cling by clinging to the dependent cling to the various imputed natures. Just as a magical illusion displays various bodies, so childish beings, through their conceptuality, see various forms as something other than the illusion. Mahāmati, the illusion and the various forms are neither different nor non-different. If they were different, the illusion would not be the cause of the various forms. If they were non-different, there would be no distinction between the illusion and the various forms; but since their distinction is seen, they are therefore neither one nor different. Therefore, Mahāmati, you and the other bodhisattva great beings should not cling to the illusion-like dependent nature and the imputed nature as different or non-different, as existent or nonexistent."

Then, in order to teach that very meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"The mind is bound by objects all around;
From reasoning, knowledge comes forth.
From the imageless and the distinctive,
Wisdom is brought forth evenly.

It exists by way of the imputed nature,
But in the dependent it does not exist.
The imputed are grasped through error;
The dependent is not the imputed.

The arising of distinct parts, too,
Is not established, just like an illusion.
Its signs are many and various;
That imputed is not established.

Its signs are ingrained dysfunction,
Born from the bondage of the mind.
Those who do not understand conceptuality
Conceive in terms of the dependent.

These imputed things
Are themselves the dependent.
The imputed are many and various;

They are conceived upon the dependent.

There is the conventional and the ultimate;
A third does not arise from causes.
The imputed is taught to be conventional;
Its cutting off is the domain of the noble ones.

Just as with the things a yogin displays,
Though he shows variety in what is one,
There is no variety in it;
Such is the characteristic of the imputed.

Just as, for those with clouded eyes,
Conception appears as various forms,
Yet the blur is neither form nor non-form,
So it is with the dependent, unrealized.

Just as gold that is well refined
Has had its impurities removed,
And just as the sky is free of clouds,
So too is the imputed.

The thing of the imputed nature
And likewise the dependent do not exist;
Yet beings superimpose and deny,
And are ruined through the force of conceptual imputation.

If the imputed were a non-thing
While the dependent existed,
Then since a thing would exist from a non-thing,
An existing thing would arise from a non-thing.

Through the imputed as the cause it relies upon,
That dependent is perceived.
From sign, name, and connection
The imputed come to arise.

When one realizes they are utterly unestablished,
One passes beyond the imputed.
Then the knowing of complete purity:
That is called the ultimate.

The imputed is of twelve kinds,
The dependent is of six kinds.
For the wisdom of individual self-awareness,
There is no distinction in what is to be known.

The five dharmas are reality itself;
In intrinsic nature there are three kinds.
When yogins meditate on this,
They do not pass beyond suchness.

Signs and the dependent:
Name produces the imputed.
Those signs of the imputed
Have arisen from the dependent.

When the intellect investigates them one by one,
There is no dependent and no imputed either.
If in the thoroughly established there is no thing,
What could the intellect conceive?

Upon those imputed natures
The two natures are set forth.
The imputed appear in various ways;
The pure is the domain of the noble ones.

The imputed is like the forms in a painting,
Imputed from the dependent.
If one imputes it in any other way,
One comes to dwell in the doctrines of the tīrthikas.

It is said to be imputed by conception,
Because it is seen to arise from combination.
Freedom from both kinds of conceptuality
Is itself the thoroughly established."

Then the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati again addressed the Blessed One with these words:

"Blessed One, please explain the characteristic of the noble wisdom that is individually self-realized, and of the one vehicle. Through that characteristic of the noble, individually self-realized wisdom and that characteristic of realizing the one vehicle, I and the other bodhisattva great beings will become skilled in the characteristic of the noble, individually self-realized wisdom and in the one

vehicle. Then, without depending on others, we shall realize all the qualities of a buddha."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, then listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "I shall do so," and listened as instructed. The Blessed One then spoke thus:

"Mahāmati, there is a teaching that the imputed is without real entity. The noble ones of the past understood it and handed it down from one to another. Relying on that teaching, a bodhisattva great being goes alone into solitude and examines with his own intellect. He does not depend on others, and he abandons views and conceptual thought. Becoming ever more distinguished, stage after stage, he fully enters the ground of the Tathāgata. That is called the characteristic of the noble wisdom that is individually self-realized.

"Next, Mahāmati, what is the characteristic of the one vehicle? It is this: knowing the path of the one vehicle is what I call the one vehicle. And what is understanding the path of the one vehicle? It is this: when conceptual thought about the grasped and the grasper does not arise, abiding in reality just as it is, that is called understanding the one vehicle. Mahāmati, this understanding of the one vehicle is not attained by anyone apart from the Tathāgata: not by the tīrthikas, the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas, Brahmā, or any others. Therefore it is called the one vehicle."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Why has the Blessed One taught three vehicles, and not spoken of a single vehicle?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are not such as to attain final nirvāṇa by themselves. For that reason the one vehicle is not taught to any of them. All śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas attain liberation through the Tathāgata's discipline and through the practice of complete seclusion, not by their own power. For that reason the one vehicle is not taught to them.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas have not abandoned the obscuration of afflictions and the habitual tendencies of karma. For that reason the one vehicle is not taught to any of them. They have not realized the selflessness of phenomena, and they have not abandoned the death and transmigration that still involves real entities. For that reason three vehicles are taught.

"Mahāmati, there comes a time when they abandon all the habitual tendencies of faults and realize the selflessness of phenomena. Having then abandoned the habitual tendencies that produce all the faults of affliction, they are no longer intoxicated by savoring the bliss of samādhi, and they awaken from the undefiled realm. Once awakened, they enter the supramundane again. Then, in the undefiled realm, they fulfill the accumulations stage after stage, until they fully attain mastery over the inconceivable Dharma body of the Tathāgata."

Then the Blessed One, to teach this very meaning again, spoke these verses:

"The vehicle of the gods and that of Brahmā,
the vehicles of śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas,
and the vehicle of the tathāgatas:
these vehicles, I have said,
are not final
so long as minds continue to operate.
If that mind should be exhausted,
there is no vehicle, and no one who rides it.
Since there is no setting up of vehicles,
I have taught a single vehicle.
In order to lead sentient beings,
I have spoken of distinct vehicles.
There are three kinds of liberation,
and there is the selflessness of phenomena itself.
When one is liberated from the afflictions
by wisdom and the rest, there is emptiness.

"Just as a log adrift upon the ocean
is ever tossed about by the waves,
so too the deluded śrāvakas
are tossed about by the wind of characteristics.
Though they have turned back from the active afflictions,
they are deluded still by the other, the afflictions' habitual tendencies.
Intoxicated by the bliss of samādhi,
they dwell within the undefiled realm.
For them there is no reaching of the final goal,
yet neither do they turn back from it again.
Having obtained a body of samādhis,
they do not awaken for eons.

Just as people drunk on liquor
grow sober when the intoxicant is spent,
so too do they come to realize the Dharma
and attain the unsurpassed body of a buddha."

From the Noble Sūtra of the Precious Descent into Laṅkā, the fifth section.

Then again the Blessed One said to the bodhisattva great being Mahāmati, "Mahāmati, I shall teach the characteristic of understanding the distinctions of the mind-made body. Listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Excellent, Blessed One, I shall do so," and listened as instructed. The Blessed One then spoke thus:

"Mahāmati, the mind-made body is of three kinds. What are the three? They are these: the mind-made body of absorption in the bliss of samādhi; the mind-made body of realizing the essential nature of phenomena; and the mind-made body that is born together with its class and free of deliberate effort. From the first ground onward, yogins fully understand the characteristics of the grounds, stage after stage, and so they attain these three bodies.

"Now, Mahāmati, what is the mind-made body of absorption in the bliss of samādhi? It is this. On the third, fourth, and fifth grounds, one is absorbed in the bliss of samādhi. Practicing the many aspects of one's own mind in seclusion, one abides in the ocean of mind. The characteristics of the waves of consciousness do not arise, and so one fully understands the existence and nonexistence of the objects that appear as one's own mind. This is called the mind-made body of absorption in the bliss of samādhi."

"Mahāmati, what is the mind-made body that realizes the essential nature of phenomena? It is this. On the eighth ground, by fully understanding phenomena that are like illusions and the rest as without appearance, the body and mind are completely transformed. One fully attains the illusion-like samādhi, and also attains countless gateways of samādhi, signs, powers, masteries, and higher knowledges. Blossoming like a flower and swift as thought, it is like an illusion, a dream, the moon in water, or a reflection. Though it is not made of the elements, it resembles something made of the elements. Its limbs are perfectly adorned with every kind of form, and it follows the circles of the assemblies in all buddha fields. Because it has fully

understood the realization of the essential nature of phenomena, it is called the body arising from the realization of the essential nature of phenomena.

"Mahāmati, what is the mind-made body that is born together with its class and is free of deliberate effort? It is this. To realize all the qualities of the Buddha and to rest in the character of the bliss one has attained oneself is called the mind-made body that is born together with its class and is free of deliberate effort. Mahāmati, you should strive diligently to understand the precise distinctions among the characteristics of these three bodies."

Then, to set forth that very meaning correctly, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

My vehicle is not the Great Vehicle;
It is not a teaching, nor is it letters;
It is not the truths, nor is it liberation;
Nor yet is it a domain where nothing is.
And yet the vehicle of the Great Vehicle
Is mastery over samādhi,
And the various mind-made bodies
Adorned with the flowers of mastery.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "As the Blessed One has taught, so that any son or daughter of noble family who has committed the five acts of immediate retribution should not fall into the Avīci hell, and in order to inspire great enthusiasm, the Tathāgatas, through their blessing, show emanations attaining realization. Nor is it absolutely certain that those who have done the deeds of immediate retribution will never attain realization; but it comes only through understanding that things are merely appearances of one's own mind, through freedom from conceptualizing body and possessions, through freedom from grasping at self and what belongs to self, and, if by rare chance they meet a spiritual friend, through being freed from the conceptual thought that links rebirth in another destiny."

Then, to teach that very meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Existence in desire is called the mother;
Ignorance is the father;
The consciousness that knows objects is the buddha;
The latent tendencies are the arhat;
The assemblage of aggregates is the Saṅgha.
Because these are cut off in sequence without interval,

These are the five of immediate retribution;
By them one does not fall into the Avīci hell.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please tell me of the buddhahood of the buddhas. Blessed One, in what way is there the buddhahood of the buddhas?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, realizing the selflessness of persons and of phenomena, fully knowing and understanding the two obscurations, being free of the two kinds of death and transmigration, and having abandoned both kinds of afflictions: this is called the buddhahood of the buddhas. Mahāmati, when śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas understand these same qualities, that too is called buddhahood. For that reason, therefore, I have taught a single vehicle."

Then, to teach that very meaning again, the Blessed One spoke this verse:

Skilled in the two kinds of selflessness,
Having fully abandoned the two obscurations and the afflictions,
Utterly free of the two kinds of death and transmigration:
That is what is called buddhahood.

Then again the bodhisattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Why has the Blessed One said in the assembly, 'I am all the buddhas who have passed,' and in the various birth stories, 'At that time I myself was the wheel-turning king Māndhātṛ, the six-tusked elephant, the parrot, Indra, the sage Sunetra, and others,' thus telling a hundred thousand birth stories?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, it is because of four kinds of sameness that the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, say in the assembly, 'At that time, on that occasion, I myself was the buddha Krakucchanda, Kanakamuni, and Kāśyapa.' What are the four kinds of sameness? They are sameness of letters, sameness of speech, sameness of Dharma, and sameness of body. These are called the four kinds of sameness, and it is because of these four kinds of sameness that the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, speak in that way.

"Now, what is sameness of letters? The very letters by which my name is spoken as 'Buddha' also speak of all the buddhas. Since the nature of those letters has no distinction, this is called sameness of letters.

"What is sameness of speech? It is this. My speech arises in sixty-four aspects, with the character of the melodious voice of Brahmā. Likewise the speech of those Tathāgatas, arhats, perfectly complete buddhas also arises in sixty-four aspects, with the character of the melodious voice of Brahmā. Like the kalaviṅka bird and the melodious voice of Brahmā, in nature there is no distinction among them, nothing more and nothing less.

"What is sameness of body? It is this. I and all the buddhas are the same and without distinction in the Dharma body and in the body of form, the major marks, and the excellent minor marks, except that, in order to tame the various particular classes of beings, we display diverse and differing forms. This is called sameness of body."

What, then, is sameness of Dharma? It is this: I and those buddhas have realized the thirty-seven factors of awakening. The qualities of a buddha and unobstructed wisdom, taught in brief, are called the four kinds of sameness. That is why the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, speak in this way amid the assembly.

Then, in order to teach this same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke this verse:

"Kāśyapa and Krakucchanda,
And Kanakamuni too, are I":
Because we are equal in the four samenesses,
I have declared this to the Victor's children.

Mahāmati again said to the Blessed One, "The Blessed One has said, 'From the night I attained perfect, complete awakening until the night I pass into parinirvāṇa, in all that time I have not spoken a single syllable, I do not speak, and I will not speak; not speaking is the speech of the Buddha.' Blessed One, on what grounds do the Tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, say that not speaking is the speech of the Buddha?"

The Blessed One declared, "Mahāmati, I said that with two dharmas in mind. What are the two? They are the dharma realized by oneself and the dharma that abides by its own nature. These are called the two dharmas. It is with these two dharmas in mind that I said it.

"What, then, is the dharma realized by oneself? Just as those Tathāgatas realized it, so I too have realized, without excess or deficiency, the dharma realized by oneself, the ultimate domain, free from the conceptualization of

words and liberated from the two modes of letters.

"What, then, is the dharma that abides by its own nature? It is this: the ancient path of the noble ones of old. Like the nature of gold, silver and the like, the dharmadhātu abides permanently, whether Tathāgatas appear in the world or do not appear in the world. The permanent abiding of the dharmadhātu remains just as a path leading to those cities remains.

"Mahāmati, suppose a certain person wandering in the wilderness sees an even, unswerving path leading to an ancient city, enters that city, and enjoys its pleasures as he wishes. Mahāmati, what do you think of that? Did he make that path and the various pleasures found in that city?"

He replied, "No, he did not."

The Blessed One declared, "Mahāmati, the unchanging abiding of the dharmadhātu realized by me and by the Tathāgatas of the past is just like that. For that reason I said, 'From the night I attained perfect, complete awakening until the night I pass into parinirvāṇa, in all that time I have not spoken a single syllable, I do not speak, and I will not speak.'"

Then, in order to teach this same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

From the night I fully awakened
To the night I passed beyond sorrow,
In all the time between the two
I have taught nothing whatsoever.
Because of the self-realized and the abiding dharma,
For that reason I have spoken thus.
Between me and those buddhas
There is no difference at all.

Then again the bodhisattva Mahāmati made a request to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain the characteristics of the existence and nonexistence of all phenomena, so that I and the other bodhisattva great beings, having abandoned existence and nonexistence, may swiftly awaken fully to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening."

The Blessed One declared, "Then, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Excellent," and listened to his words. The Blessed One declared, "Mahāmati, these worlds rest on two things: they rest

on existence, and they fall into the view that inclines toward things being nonexistent, conceiving of deliverance where there is no deliverance.

"Now, Mahāmati, how do worldly people rest on existence? It is this: the world arises when causes and conditions exist, not from what does not exist; therefore it arises from what exists and does not arise from what does not exist. Mahāmati, whoever speaks in this way speaks of the world as causeless.

"Mahāmati, how does the world rest on nonexistence? It is this: having first accepted attachment, aversion and delusion as things, they afterward imagine and cling to attachment, aversion and delusion as nonexistent things. Mahāmati, not accepting things as existent is because the characteristic of things is utterly void; thus the Tathāgatas, śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas do not accept the things that are attachment, aversion and delusion either as 'existent' or as 'nonexistent.' Mahāmati, who then is it that destroys?"

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, it is those who accept the things that are attachment, aversion and delusion and afterward do not accept them."

The Blessed One declared, "Excellent, Mahāmati, excellent! That you understand it in this way is excellent. Mahāmati, such a person not only destroys the things that are attachment, aversion and delusion by making them nonexistent; he destroys the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas as well. Why is that? Because inner and outer are not apprehended, and because the afflictions are both distinct and not distinct. Mahāmati, attachment, aversion and delusion are not apprehended either inwardly or outwardly, because the things that are attachment, aversion and delusion have no body, and because there is nothing to be accepted.

The buddhas, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas are not destroyers. This is because those buddhas, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas are liberated by their very nature, and because there is neither binding nor any entity that is the cause of bondage. Mahāmati, if there is something to be bound, there is also binding, because it is a cause of bondage. Mahāmati, speaking of destroyers in this way is what is called the characteristic of nonexistence. Mahāmati, it was with this in mind that I said: "It is better to hold a view of a person as large as Mount Meru than to hold the view of emptiness of one who is filled with conceit." Mahāmati, one who is conceited about nonexistence is a destroyer.

There are those whose thinking has fallen into individual and general characteristics. Because they do not know things to be mere appearances of

their own mind, they see external things as impermanent, perishing from one instant to the next. If they then conceive of the aggregates, elements, and sense sources as an unbroken continuum that undergoes change, and as free from the characteristics of letters, they too are destroyers.

Then, in order to teach this same point again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Existence and nonexistence are the two extremes,
As far as the domains of the mind extend.
When those domains are entirely abandoned,
The mind becomes even, utterly secluded, and at peace.

Since there is no grasping at the things that are objects,
It is not that there is no cessation.
Existing things are suchness,
Just as they are the domain of the noble ones.

That things arise from what has no cause,
And, having come about, then cease,
That causes and conditions exist or do not exist:
Such claims have no place in my teaching.

They are not made by tīrthikas or by buddhas,
Not by me nor by anyone else.
If they come about from a gathering of causes and conditions,
How could they become nonexistent?

Who, having gathered existing causes and conditions,
Would declare that they do not exist?
Those who speak wrong views about the arising of phenomena
Imagine existence and nonexistence through conceptual thought.

Whoever fully knows that nothing whatsoever arises
And that nothing ceases,
Seeing the world as void,
Is freed from both existence and nonexistence.

Then again the bodhisattva, the great being Mahāmati, said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me and to the other bodhisattvas the characteristics of the way of realization (siddhānta). If we become skilled in distinguishing the characteristics of the way of realization, I and the bodhisattvas will understand its characteristics. Having understood its

characteristics, we will quickly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect, complete awakening, and we will not follow after the characteristics of conceptuality, nor after māras and tīrthikas."

The Blessed One said, "Therefore, Mahāmati, listen very well and keep it in mind, and I will explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "So be it," and listened. The Blessed One said:

"Mahāmati, the characteristics of the way of realization of all śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and bodhisattvas are of two kinds, namely the way of realization and the way of teaching. Here, Mahāmati, the way of realization is this: it is focused on attaining the distinctive character of individual, self-known awareness; it is free from the conceptualizing of words and letters; it enters the undefiled realm; it is the intrinsic characteristic of the ground of self-realization; it has abandoned all unreal, conceptual perceptions; and, having subdued all tīrthikas and māras, it is resplendent with the light that is focused on the way of individual, self-known awareness. This is what is called the characteristic of the way of realization.

"And what is the characteristic of the way of teaching? It is the various teachings of the ninefold scripture. Teaching the Dharma, which is free from the characteristics of difference and nondifference, existence and nonexistence, and so on, with skillful means and in accordance with the inclinations of beings, and so causing them to attain liberation: this is what is called the characteristic of the way of teaching. Therefore, Mahāmati, you and the other bodhisattvas should strive in this."

Then, in order to teach this same point again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The way of realization and the way of teaching
Are individual self-awareness and the teaching.
Those who see them and discern them well
Do not fall under the sway of conceptuality.

If no real things exist
In the way that the childish imagine,
Why do those given to conceptuality
Seek liberation in the absence of things?

When conditioned things are each imagined,
Seeing them bound up with arising, perishing, and so on,
Makes the two views flourish:
This is error; there is no knowledge in it.

What is single is the true reality;
That which is faultless is nirvāṇa.
When the world is examined by conceptuality,
It is like an illusion, a dream, a plantain tree.

Though there is desire, hatred, and delusion,
No person truly exists.
From craving the aggregates arise;
Existence is like an illusion, like a dream.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the characteristic of false imagination. How do false imaginings arise? What is it that is called false imagination? With regard to which phenomena does false imagining take place?"

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, Mahāmati, excellent! Your intention to ask the Tathāgata about such a matter has arisen for the benefit of many people, for the happiness of many people, out of compassion for the world, and for the welfare, benefit, and happiness of gods and the great multitudes of humans. Therefore listen very well and keep it in mind, and I will explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Excellent, excellent!"

"Blessed One, so be it," he said, and listened. The Blessed One then said: "Mahāmati, conceptuality bound up with attachment arises from the many different kinds of objects and from the many kinds of unreal conceptualization. Mahāmati, it comes from attachment to what is grasped and to the one who grasps. It comes from not realizing that things are merely appearances of one's own mind, from falling into views of existence and nonexistence, and from greatly strengthening the views of the tīrthikas. It comes from attachment to the many external objects through the habitual tendencies of conceptuality. And the conceptuality of mind and mental factors arises from attachment to a self and to what belongs to a self."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, suppose that conceptuality bound up with attachment arises from the many different kinds of objects and from the many kinds of unreal conceptualization. Suppose it comes from

attachment to what is grasped and to the one who grasps, from not realizing that things are merely appearances of one's own mind, from falling into views of existence and nonexistence, and from strengthening the views of the tīrthikas. Suppose it comes from attachment to the many external objects through the habitual tendencies of conceptuality, and that the conceptualities of mind and mental factors arise from attachment to a self and to what belongs to a self. If so, Blessed One, then in the same way that it is turned away from the characteristics of the many external objects, from the characteristics of falling into existence and nonexistence, from being free of entity and non-entity, and from the characteristic of being free of views, the ultimate too, Blessed One, would be turned away from the characteristics of valid cognition, of the faculties, of the members of a proof, of example, and of reason. Blessed One, why is it that in the one case conceptuality bound up with attachment arises toward unreal objects as many kinds of entities, while toward the characteristic of the ultimate no conceptuality bound up with attachment arises? Blessed One, would you not be teaching an inconsistent causality, in declaring that it arises from the one and does not arise from the other?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, it is not that conceptuality arises from the one and does not arise from the other. Why is that? Because conceptuality of existence and nonexistence does not arise, because the entities that appear outside have no existence as entities, and because one realizes that things are merely appearances of one's own mind, conceptuality is not produced.

"Mahāmati, I explain it this way for the sake of others, the childish ordinary beings. Because of the many kinds of conceptualization in their own minds, the entity of karma becomes manifest, and so they become attached to the characteristics of the many kinds of conceptualized entities. I think: 'How might these childish ordinary beings give up the views that cling to a self and to what belongs to a self, and turn away from agent, from the causes and conditions of action, and from result? How might they, by realizing that conceptualization is merely an appearance of their own mind, have body and mind thoroughly transformed, become skilled in bringing all the grounds to completion, enter the domain of the Tathāgatas' personal self-realized awareness, and attain the turning away from the conceptuality that views the five dharmas, the natures, and entities?' For that reason and on that account I teach that conceptualities arise from attachment to the many unreal objects. By fully understanding the real meaning just as it is, liberation is attained, and

the many kinds of conceptualization no longer arise."

Then, to teach that same meaning once more, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Those who say the world arises
Through causes and through conditions
Cling to the concepts of the four extremes;
They do not know my way.

The world is not born from existence,
Nor likewise is it born from nonexistence,
Nor is it born from both existence and nonexistence,
And if it is not from what is neither existent nor nonexistent,
Why do the childish conceive of it
In terms of causes and conditions?

It is not existent, nor nonexistent,
Nor likewise both existent and nonexistent.
When one sees the world in this way,
The mind is transformed and attains selflessness as well.

All things are unborn,
Because they arise from conditions.
All are made by conditions,
And what is made has no self.

An entity does not produce an entity,
Because of the fault of there being two entities,
And because of the fault of there being no two entities;
Entities do not exist as two.

Examining conditioned phenomena well,
When the apprehender and the apprehended are wholly abandoned,
That is no-mind, that is mind-only;
That too I call mind-only.

"Only" is the abode of essential nature,
Free of both conditions and entities;
Supreme among the ultimate entities,
That I call mind-only.

The self imputed by convention
Does not exist as a substance.

The aggregates labeled as aggregates,
Non-entities, are likewise.

Sameness is of four kinds:
That of characteristics, and that arising from causes and from entities;
The third is the sameness of selflessness;
The fourth is that of the yoga of yogins.

Through the stirring of the habitual tendencies of conceptuality,
Mind arises in many forms,
And objects come to appear as external;
That is the world as mind-only.

What appears outside does not exist;
It is mind that appears as many things.
The setting forth of bodies and enjoyments
I explain as mind-only.

Wholly abandoning all views,
Free of conceiving and the conceived,
Without object and without birth:
That too I explain as mind-only.

Neither entity nor non-entity:
By abandoning entity and non-entity,
That mind is called liberated;
That too I explain as mind-only.

Suchness and the limit of reality,
Nirvāṇa and the dharmadhātu,
And the many mind-made bodies,
These too I explain as mind-only.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Since the Blessed One has said, 'Bodhisattva mahāsattvas should become skilled in words and in meaning,' how is a bodhisattva skilled in words and in meaning? And in this, what are words, and what is meaning?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, therefore listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One: "Excellent."

"Blessed One, so be it," he assented, and the Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, what is speech? It is the meeting of the conceptualizations of words and letters. Relying on the throat, the gullet, the lips, the tongue, the teeth, the palate and the cheeks, it arises from the cause, the habitual tendencies of the conceptualization that is expressed in speech. That is called speech.

"Mahāmati, what is meaning? It is that which has completely abandoned all the characteristics of conceptualization and the characteristics of expression. That is called meaning. Mahāmati, for the sake of such a meaning, the bodhisattva, the great being, goes alone into solitude. With the wisdom that comes from hearing, reflecting and meditating, he focuses on self-awareness and goes toward the city of nirvāṇa. Having transformed the body of habitual tendencies, he fully engages in the characteristics of the meaning of the distinctions within the domain of individual self-awareness, the grounds, and the other states of the grounds. That is the skill in meaning of the bodhisattvas, the great beings.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, the bodhisattva, the great being, who is skilled in speech and meaning, examines speech and meaning as neither different nor yet not different. Examining meaning and speech is likewise. If speech and meaning were different, they would not be causes that make the meaning clear. But speech follows the meaning, just as a lamp makes forms and so on clear.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, to cling, by relying on clinging to the words as they sound, to the unborn, the unceasing, what is by intrinsic nature completely in nirvāṇa, the three vehicles, the one vehicle, mind, intrinsic nature and so on, is to fall into the extremes of superimposition and denial. When a view stands in one way, while it is established and conceived in another, it appears as diverse conceptualizations, like an illusion. Just as an illusion appears in diverse ways, so childish ordinary beings conceive things otherwise, each in their own way, but the noble ones do not."

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"Those who, by conceptualizations that follow the words,
establish phenomena,
since they thus superimpose upon them,
fall at death and transmigration into the hells.
In the aggregates there is no self,

and the aggregates themselves are not the self.
They do not exist in the way they are imputed,
yet neither are they simply nonexistent.
If all things existed
just as the childish imagine them,
if they existed as they are seen,
then all would see the truth.
If phenomena had no reality at all,
there would be neither pure nor impure.
They are not as they are seen,
yet neither are they nonexistent."

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, I shall explain the characteristics of wisdom and consciousness. If you become skilled in distinguishing the characteristics of wisdom and consciousness, you and the bodhisattvas will understand and realize the characteristics of wisdom and consciousness, and will quickly and fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening.

"Mahāmati, wisdom is of three kinds: worldly, supramundane, and supreme supramundane. What is worldly wisdom? It is the clinging of the tīrthikas and of childish ordinary beings to existence and nonexistence. What is supramundane wisdom? It is the clinging of all śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas to thoughts that have fallen into specific and general characteristics. What is the wisdom that is supreme supramundane? It is that of the buddhas and bodhisattvas: the thorough discernment of phenomena as without appearance, the seeing of them as unborn and unceasing, free from the positions of existence and nonexistence. It is the ground of the Tathāgata, arising from the individual self-awareness of the selflessness of persons and of phenomena.

"Further, wisdom is of three kinds: the wisdom that realizes arising and perishing, the wisdom that realizes specific and general characteristics, and the wisdom that realizes non-arising and non-ceasing.

"Mahāmati, what arises and perishes is consciousness; what neither arises nor perishes is wisdom. What falls into signs and signlessness, falls into existence and nonexistence, and is born from causes of diverse characteristics is consciousness. What has wholly gone beyond the characteristics of existence and nonexistence is wisdom. Further, the characteristic of being accompanied

by arising is consciousness; the characteristic of being accompanied by non-arising is wisdom. Further, the characteristic of being unobstructed is wisdom; the characteristic of being obstructed by diverse objects is consciousness. Further, the characteristic of a means arising from the coming together of three things is consciousness; the characteristic of a nature without things and without means is wisdom. Further, the characteristic of attainment is consciousness; the characteristic of non-attainment is wisdom, for, because one realizes the domain of the wisdom of one's own noble individual self-awareness, it neither enters nor emerges, like the moon in water."

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"Consciousness accumulates karmas;
not accumulating, that is wisdom.
When one examines phenomena one by one,
realizes them as without appearance,
and attains the masteries and powers,
that is called wisdom.
Mind is what is bound to objects;
wisdom is the awareness that discerns thought.
From absence of appearance and from distinction,
wisdom comes to arise.
One who has abandoned mind, mentation and consciousness,
and the perception of thought,
and has attained the nonconceptual Dharma,
is an heir of the Victor, not a śrāvaka.
Utter peace, distinctive forbearance,
and from the pure wisdom
of the Tathāgata, virtuous meaning arises,
free of all activity.
His wisdom is threefold,
fully distinguished by the noble ones.
To conceive characteristics in it
is to be bound up with things."

It is not shared by the two vehicles,
And is free of the appearances of knowledge.
Clinging to the existence of things

Is what arises among the śrāvakas.
When mind-only has been transcended,
The wisdom of the Sugata is stainless.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, the tīrthikas hold nine kinds of doctrine of transformation, and from these arise the tīrthikas' views of transformation. They are: transformation of shape, transformation of characteristics, transformation of cause, transformation of kind, transformation of view, transformation of essential nature, transformation in the manifesting of conditions, transformation in the manifesting of activity, and transformation of things. Mahāmati, these are called the nine kinds of views of transformation. Because of them, all the tīrthikas come to teach a transformation that arises from existence and nonexistence.

"What is transformation of shape? It is seeing a shape turn into another. For example, when gold is made into vessels and ornaments of various kinds, it appears to have taken on various shapes, yet the essential nature of the gold does not change. They imagine that the transformation of all things is just like this.

"Some tīrthikas imagine it this way: things transform. Yet those conceptions are neither so nor otherwise, because they are mere conceptual constructions. Thus they hold that the transformation of all things should be understood as being like milk, curds, liquor, and the ripening of fruit. But because the transformations that the tīrthikas imagine do not exist, existence or nonexistence is nothing but the appearance of one's own mind, and external things are without any reality as things. Mahāmati, in the same way, ordinary childish beings are habituated to their own conceptual thought. Mahāmati, no phenomenon whatsoever arises or perishes. It is just as when forms in an illusion or a dream are seen to arise."

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Shape, place, and time, from transformation;
The faculties of the great elements,
The intermediate state, and birth in stages:
These are imagined, not by the wise.
The Victor does not conceive
Of dependent origination as they do.

Rather, the dependent origination of the world
Is just like a city of gandharvas.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain the meaning of the binding of all phenomena and the meaning of release. If we become skilled in discerning the characteristics of binding and non-binding, then I and the bodhisattvas, being skilled in the means concerning all binding, will not fall into the binding that clings to meanings just as the words say. Being skilled in the characteristics of the binding and non-binding of all phenomena, we will fully abandon the mind that conceptualizes words and letters. We will travel to all the buddha fields and go among the countless maṇḍalas of assemblies. We will illuminate everything with the powers, the masteries, the higher knowledges, the seals of dhāraṇī, various emanations, and light rays. With the mind of knowledge we will fully enter the ten ultimate stations. Because there is no deliberate striving in our practice, we will be like the sun, the moon, a jewel, and the four great elements. On all the grounds we will abandon the view that takes them as characteristics conceived by our own minds, and, seeing all phenomena as like an illusion, a dream, and so forth, we will enter the ground and the body of a buddha. Teaching the Dharma to all realms of sentient beings in whatever way suits them, we will lead them, bring them to understand all phenomena as like an illusion, a dream, and so forth, speak of abandoning conceptions of the positions of existence and nonexistence and of arising and perishing, and establish them in the meanings that are distinct. And so we will also attain a distinguished body."

The Blessed One said: "Excellent, Mahāmati, excellent! Therefore listen very well and keep it in mind, and I will explain it to you."

Mahāmati said, "I will understand it just as the Blessed One teaches," and listened. The Blessed One said:

"Mahāmati, the bindings that cling to all phenomena just as the words say are measureless. They are: the binding of clinging to characteristics; the binding of clinging to conditions; the binding of clinging to things and to the absence of things; the binding of clinging to conceptions of arising and non-arising; the binding of clinging to conceptions of non-cessation; the binding of clinging to conceptions of vehicle and non-vehicle; the binding of clinging to conceptions of the conditioned and the unconditioned; the binding of clinging to

conceptions of the grounds and the individual characteristics of the grounds; the binding of clinging to the conception that one's own conceptual thought exists without interruption; the binding of clinging to conceptions of the positions of existence and nonexistence, which are the abode of the tīrthikas; and the binding of clinging to the conception that the three vehicles and the one vehicle exist without interruption.

"Mahāmati, these and others besides are the bindings that ordinary childish beings make through their own conceptual thought. Because they bind themselves in this way, ordinary childish beings keep conceptualizing. Just as a silkworm spins its cocoon, they wrap themselves and others in the silken thread of conceptual thought, and cling to the characteristics of binding to existence and nonexistence."

Mahāmati, here there is no characteristic whatsoever of linking or of non-linking. Because conceptual thought does not arise when all phenomena are seen as utterly isolated, the bodhisattvas, the great beings, see all phenomena as utterly isolated.

Moreover, Mahāmati, they understand external things to be nonexistent and to have the characteristic of being appearances of their own mind, and so to be without appearance. They follow the discernment that there are only appearances of their own mind. They see that all things, existent and nonexistent, are without signs, and they see the linking of conceptual thought as utterly isolated. Because of this, for all phenomena there is no linking, and there is no characteristic of non-linking either.

Mahāmati, here nothing whatsoever is bound or liberated. It is otherwise for those whose minds have fallen into what is not true: they perceive that bondage and liberation exist. Why is this? Because in all phenomena neither existence, nor nonexistence, nor sentient beings are found.

Moreover, Mahāmati, childish ordinary beings have three kinds of linking, namely attachment, aversion, and delusion. Because they are linked by that attachment, which craves the future and delights in renewed existence, they become linked into the destinies of existence. Their linking is linking into the five destinies. Mahāmati, for one in whom linking has been cut off, there is no characteristic whatsoever of linking or of non-linking.

Moreover, Mahāmati, through clinging to the condition of the meeting of the three and to the application of activity, the linking of the consciousnesses arises without interruption. Through clinging to application there is linking into

existence. If one abandons the consciousness that arises from the condition of the meeting of the three, and sees the three liberations, no linking at all will arise.

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Unreal conceptual thought
Is called the characteristic of linking.
When one truly and fully knows it,
The net of linking will be cut.

Not knowing things as they are,
One follows after words.
Just like the silkworm,
One binds oneself with the net of linking.
Childish beings, tightly bound by conceptual thought,
Do not discern this linking.

From the Noble Sūtra of the Precious Descent into Laṅkā, the sixth fascicle.

Then Mahāmati again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, you have said: 'Whatever thing is imagined by whatever conceptual thought, those things are merely imputed; since they lack intrinsic nature, they are solely the imputed nature.' Blessed One, if it is merely the imputed nature alone, and not something that depends on the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of things, Blessed One, would this not entail the fault of having declared that affliction and purification are not real things? For all phenomena would be of the imputed nature alone, since they are not real things."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, so it is; it is just as you have said. Mahāmati, reality is not as childish ordinary beings imagine the intrinsic nature of things to be, and therefore that imputed nature does not exist as the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of things. Yet, Mahāmati, with the wisdom of the noble ones, just as the intrinsic nature of existing things is, so the noble ones realize that intrinsic nature of things through noble wisdom, noble vision, and the eye of noble discernment."

Mahāmati said: "Blessed One, if the noble ones realize the intrinsic nature of things in that way through noble wisdom, noble vision, and the eye of noble discernment, and not through the divine eye or the fleshly eye, and if it is not as childish ordinary beings imagine it, then, Blessed One, how will the

conceptual thought of childish ordinary beings be turned back, since they do not understand the thing that is the essential nature of the noble ones? Blessed One, those beings are neither mistaken nor unmistaken. Why is this? Because they do not understand the essential intrinsic nature of the thing as the noble ones know it, and they do not see the characteristic that is free from existence and nonexistence.

"Blessed One, the noble ones, by such vision, do not see things in the way such things are imagined, because they do not take the domain of particular characteristics as their domain. Blessed One, yet to them as well the characteristics of the intrinsic nature of things appear just like the imputed nature. Since no cause is taught, there is no cause; that is to say, by falling into the view of the characteristics of things, their domains become divergent. Since these are not as they truly are, there would thus be the fault of infinite regress, Blessed One, because the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of things is not understood."

"Blessed One, if the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of things does not come about through the cause that is the intrinsic nature of conceptuality, then how is it that these imaginings do not become imagining, and how does one come to understand them as imputed, just as they truly are? Blessed One, the characteristic of discrimination is one thing, and the characteristic of intrinsic nature is another. Blessed One, if their causes are dissimilar, why do beings not discriminate between conceptuality and the characteristic of intrinsic nature? Furthermore, why do childish ordinary beings not understand things just as they truly are? Yet you have said that, although it is taught to be like the imputed characteristic in order to rid sentient beings of conceptuality, it does not truly exist.

"Blessed One, why do you turn sentient beings away from clinging to existence and nonexistence, to the intrinsic nature of things that belongs to the view of existence, and to the domain of noble wisdom, and from clinging that falls into the view of existence, and then declare that the teaching of emptiness is without entity, and yet speak of an entity whose nature is noble?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, I do not teach that the teaching of emptiness is without entity, nor do I, falling into the view of existence, teach an entity that is the intrinsic nature of noble wisdom. Rather, in order to remove the grounds of fear for sentient beings, I teach the doctrine of emptiness to those beings who since beginningless time have clung to the

characteristic of the intrinsic nature of things, and who regard the intrinsic nature of the entity of noble wisdom as a characteristic and cling to it. Mahāmati, I do not teach an intrinsic nature of things. Nevertheless, Mahāmati, I have myself realized things just as they truly are, and I abide in the teaching of emptiness. Having abandoned the view of mistaken characteristics, I am well sealed with the seal of realizing, just as they truly are, the three gates of liberation, which are free from the views of what appears as one's own mind, of entity, and of nonentity. And by discerning and abiding, discerning each intrinsic nature of things individually with the intellect of personal self-knowing awareness, I have abandoned the characteristic of views that regard things as existent or nonexistent.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva great being should not put forward the proposition 'All phenomena are unborn.' Why is that? It is this: because every object of a proposition is without entity, and because the proposition has the characteristic of arising from its own causes, if one states as a proposition 'All phenomena are unborn,' that proposition is defeated. The way that one who makes the proposition 'All phenomena are unborn' defeats that proposition is this: the proposition itself arises from something on which it depends. Moreover, the proposition 'unborn' is itself included among all phenomena. Since a characteristic of being undefeated does not arise, if one proposes 'All phenomena are unborn,' that assertion is defeated. Mahāmati, the proposition that proposes that existence and nonexistence are unborn is included among all entities, and so the characteristic of existence and nonexistence is not apprehended. Mahāmati, if that unborn proposition is used to propose 'All entities are unborn,' even so it falls away from the proposition, because the characteristic of existent and nonexistent entities does not arise; therefore one should not put forward a proposition. As for an argument with five members, because of its many faults, because its members have the characteristic of causes that differ from one another, and because they are made, its members should not be put forward as propositions. Thus, although one should not propose that all phenomena are unborn, nor likewise that all phenomena are empty and without intrinsic nature, nevertheless, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva great being should teach that all phenomena are like an illusion and like a dream. Because they have the characteristic of appearing and not appearing, and because they deceive view and intellect, one should teach that all phenomena have the essential nature of an illusion and a dream. The exception is when it serves to remove the grounds of fear for childish ordinary

beings, Mahāmati, so that childish ordinary beings who have fallen into the views of existence and nonexistence will not be frightened and will not turn away from the Great Vehicle."

Then the Blessed One, in order to teach that same meaning again, spoke these verses:

Without intrinsic nature, they cannot be expressed;
they are without entity and without linking.
Like a corpse, these are imagined
by the wrong understanding of the childish.

That all phenomena are unborn
is not the doctrine of the tīrthikas.
In the end there is no arising at all;
things are established by conditions.

Since all phenomena are unborn,
the intelligent do not grasp at signs.
Because propositions arise from causes,
the learned abandon them entirely.

Just as one whose eyes are clouded by cataract
wrongly sees the appearance of hairs,
so too clinging to things as entities
is wrongly imagined by the childish.

Whatever the three realms impute,
no intrinsic nature of things exists.
By imputing an intrinsic nature to things,
those given to conceptions conceive.

By setting up sign, entity, and word,
the mind is disturbed and violently stirred.
The children of the Victor have utterly passed beyond
those conceptions and abandoned them completely.

Taking for water what is not water
arises from craving born of thirst.
Just so the childish are deceived;
the noble do not see in that way.

The vision of the noble is wholly pure,
born of the liberations and samādhi.

Having fully abandoned arising and perishing,
it moves freely in the imageless.

For the yogin in the imageless
there is neither entity nor nonentity.
When entity and nonentity are the same,
there the fruit of the noble arises.

How is it that entity and nonentity
come to be the same?
Because the mind does not know this,
outer and inner are violently stirred.
When at last it destroys this,
the mind sees sameness as well.

Then Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, as the Blessed One has said, when the object to be apprehended is not apprehended by cognition, then it is established as mere designation; since there is no grasped object that is established, there is also no grasping...

"Because there is no grasping, cognition does not engage either; it is merely a designated name." When this is said, Blessed One, is it because cognition does not understand the distinctness and non-distinctness of the particular and general characteristics of things that it does not perceive them? Or is it because the essential nature of things is overwhelmed by the variety of particular and general characteristics that cognition does not perceive them? Or is it because they are obstructed by mountains and rocks, by walls, by earth, water, fire or wind that cognition does not perceive them? Is it because they are too far away or too near that cognition does not perceive them? Or is it because the old, children and the blind do not possess the faculties that cognition does not perceive?

Blessed One, if it is because of understanding the distinctness and non-distinctness of the particular and general characteristics that cognition does not perceive, then it should not be called knowledge; it should be called ignorance, because although the object exists, it is not perceived. If it is because the essential nature of things is overwhelmed by the variety of particular and general characteristics that cognition does not perceive, then that too is ignorance and not knowledge. Blessed One, knowledge arises because there is something knowable. It does not arise from what is not a

thing. It is called knowledge because it is endowed with something knowable. If it is because of obstruction by mountains and rocks, walls, earth, water, fire and wind, because of great distance or nearness, or because the faculties are incomplete through old age, childhood or blindness, that cognition does not perceive, then that too is not to be called knowledge, and so it is ignorance, because although the thing exists, it is not perceived.

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, that is not ignorance in this way. It is knowledge, and therefore not ignorance. It was not with that hidden intention that I taught, 'When a perceived thing is not perceived by cognition, it is established as a mere designation.' Rather, because one does not understand that it is merely the appearance of one's own mind, and because cognition takes it that, as existence and nonexistence, external things and non-things are possible, it does not perceive things, and therefore cognition does not engage with the knowable. Knowledge that accords with the three liberations does not perceive either. The conceptualizers, whose minds have been imbued since beginningless time with the habitual tendencies of elaborating things and non-things, do not know in this way. Because their cognition does not know these things, they do not give up the conceptual thought 'there is no thing' with regard to the nature of the characteristics of external things. Positing what is merely the appearance of their own mind, they cling to grasping at the characteristics of self and of what is mine. Not understanding that it is merely the appearance of their own mind, they conceptualize knowledge and the knowable as separate. Because they conceptualize, even though they examine external things one by one as non-things, they do not perceive them, and so they fall back entirely upon the view of annihilation."

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"Although objects of perception exist,
cognition that does not discern them one by one
is not knowledge but ignorance:
so the logicians have declared.

Characteristics that are not distinct,
obstruction, and nearness and distance:
if knowledge does not realize these,
that is wrong knowledge.

The old, children and those gone blind,
although knowable things truly exist,
do not give rise to cognitions:
that too is wrong knowledge."

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, childish ordinary beings are warped by the wrong conceptuality of the unreal dysfunction of beginningless time. While warped, they are unskilled in the way of their own realized truth and in the way of explanation. Because they cling to the appearance of their own mind as characteristics of external things, they cling to what is spoken as skillful means, and they are unskilled in discerning the characteristic of the way of one's own realized truth, which is pure of the four alternatives."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "It is just as the Blessed One has said. Blessed One, please explain to me the way of explanation and the way of realized truth, so that I and the other bodhisattva great beings, being skilled in these two ways, may in the future give no opening for attack to ordinary beings and to those of the śrāvaka and pratyekabuddha vehicles."

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, Mahāmati, excellent! Therefore listen well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "I will do so," and listened. The Blessed One then said this to Mahāmati: "The Tathāgatas of the three times have two ways of Dharma, namely, the way of teaching and the way of one's own realized truth. The way of teaching is this: teaching the various collections of sūtras in accordance with the inclinations of the minds of sentient beings. That is called the way of teaching. The way of one's own realized truth is this: when yogis have completely abandoned the various conceptualizations of what appears from their own mind, then that which does not fall into the positions of one, different, both or neither; which utterly transcends mind, mentation and mental consciousness; which is the domain of the noble ones' individual self-aware knowing; which is free of the characteristics of causes, reasonings and views; and which is not known by any of the tīrthikas or the followers of the śrāvaka and pratyekabuddha vehicles who fall into the two extremes, that I have declared to be the Dharma of the way of one's own realized truth. Mahāmati, this is called the characteristic of the way of one's own realized truth and of the way of teaching. You and the other bodhisattva great beings should practice it and train in it."

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke this verse:

"My ways are of two kinds:
realized truth and teaching.
To the childish I explain in words;
for yogis there is realized truth."

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, it is just as the Blessed One once said: 'One should not train in or attend upon the doctrines of the Lokāyatas and the various clever sophists.

If one trains in them and attends upon them, one gathers material gain, but one does not gather the Dharma.' Since you said this, Blessed One, why did the Blessed One say so?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, the Lokāyatas gather and arrange various verbal compositions, reasons and examples. With these they deceive and bewilder childish ordinary beings. So they do not enter the way of genuine reality itself, and they do not understand any phenomena. Through mistaken conceptual thought they fall into the two extremes. They utterly confuse the childish, and they also destroy themselves. They take rebirth in the various destinies and do not attain liberation. This is because they do not understand that things are merely the appearance of their own mind, they have not abandoned the intrinsic nature of external things, and they cling to conceptual thought.

Therefore the Lokāyatas, with all their various clever eloquence, are not freed from birth, aging, sickness, death, sorrow, lamentation, suffering and agitation. They deceive others completely and leave them utterly bewildered.

Mahāmati, Śakra (Indra), the lord of the gods, was learned in many treatises and himself composed a treatise on grammar. A disciple of his, a Lokāyata, took on the form and guise of a nāga, went to the abode of Śakra, the lord of the gods, and made this wager: 'I will debate the Dharma with you. If you fail to defeat me, your thousand-spoked wheel shall be broken. If I am defeated, I will cut off my heads one by one and admit the fault of defeat.' Having made this wager, he debated the Dharma and defeated Śakra, the lord of the gods. He broke the thousand-spoked wheel and then came back to this world of humans.

Thus, Mahāmati, the Lokāyata sets out various reasons and examples. Even one who had become an animal could, with all kinds of verbal compositions, utterly bewilder gods and asuras and establish them in views of arising and destruction. What need, then, to speak of humans? Therefore, Mahāmati, the Lokāyatas should be entirely shunned. Because they bring about the cause from which suffering arises, one should not train in them or attend upon them.

Mahāmati, the Lokāyatas teach only the object as it is apprehended by body and intellect. Mahāmati, there are a hundred thousand of these Lokāyatas. In the later age, in the last five hundred years, they will break up those gathered in the teaching. When bad reasoning, its causes and its views spread, they will take in bad disciples.

So, Mahāmati, these Lokāyatas who break up the assemblies set out verbal compositions, reasons and various examples. They proclaim the things of the tīrthikas and cling to their own conditions, and so they have no way of their own. Mahāmati, because those tīrthikas have no treatise of a way of their own, the Lokāyatas expound at length to others countless, immeasurable hundreds of thousands of approaches to things. They themselves do not know that they have no way of their own, and that they are foolish and deluded Lokāyatas."

Then Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, suppose that the tīrthika Lokāyatas, by tying together verbal compositions, reasons and various examples, have no way of their own and cling to their own things. Then the Blessed One too teaches Lokāyata itself. For to assemblies of gods, humans and asuras gathered from many different quarters, you speak at length with all kinds of verbal compositions, beyond measure. Is that not also without a way of its own? Does it not fall among the knowledge and conventional expressions of the tīrthikas?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, I do not teach Lokāyata. Since there is no coming and no going, I teach only no coming and no going. Mahāmati, 'coming' means arising from an assemblage. 'Going' means destruction. No going and no coming means neither arising nor ceasing.

Mahāmati, the phenomena I teach do not fall into Lokāyata, and they do not belong among conceptual thoughts. Why is that? One does not cling to external things or to non-things, and one abides in what is merely the appearance of one's own mind. So one is not moved by conceptual thought of the two extremes. One understands that the domain of signs has no real things and is merely the appearance of one's own mind. So conceptual

thought about the appearances of one's own mind does not arise. The non-arising of conceptual thought is called liberation, because one has entered the three doors of liberation: emptiness, signlessness, and the absence of deliberate formation.

Mahāmati, I recall that once, when I was staying in a certain place, a Lokāyata brahmin came to where I was. Without asking whether I was at leisure, he said to me: 'O Gautama, is everything made?' At that time I said: 'O brahmin, to say that everything is made is the first Lokāyata.'

He asked again: 'Is everything unmade?' And I said: 'That everything is unmade is the second Lokāyata.'

He asked again: 'Is everything permanent? Is everything impermanent? Does everything arise? Does everything not arise?' At that time I said: 'Those are the sixth Lokāyata.'

Mahāmati, he asked further: 'Is everything one? Is everything different? Is everything both? Is everything neither? Does everything appear as arising from various causes?' At that time I said: 'Those are the eleventh Lokāyata.'

Then he asked me further, "O sir, is everything undeclared? Is everything declared? Is there a self? Is there no self? Does this world not exist? Does the world beyond exist? Does the world beyond not exist? Is there liberation? Is there no liberation? Is everything momentary? Is everything not momentary? And are space, cessation not brought about through analysis, and nirvāṇa, O Gautama, made, or unmade? Is there an intermediate state of existence? Is there no intermediate state of existence?" Mahāmati, I then spoke to him thus: "O brahmin, all who speak in that way are Lokāyatas. That is not what I teach. It is your Lokāyata."

"Brahmin, I teach only this: the dysfunctions of the various habitual tendencies of unreal conceptuality, accumulated since beginningless time, are the cause of the three realms of existence. Because one does not realize that what appears is merely one's own mind, conceptuality arises, and one then takes external things as objects. I am not like the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), for whom cognition arises from the coming together of three things: a self, the sense faculties, and objects. Brahmin, I am neither a proponent of causes nor a proponent of no cause. I designate as dependent origination merely the things of conceptuality, the grasped and the grasping. This cannot be understood by you and by those others whose continuum is cut off, who have fallen into grasping at a self."

"Mahāmati, nirvāṇa, space, and cessation do not exist as three different kinds. They are three merely in number."

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, at that time a Lokāyata brahmin said to me, 'O sir, do the three realms of existence come about because of ignorance, craving, and karma as their cause, or else do they come from no cause?' I then said to him, 'Both of these are Lokāyata.' He asked further, 'O sir, are all things included within their own characteristics and general characteristics?' And I said to him, 'This too is Lokāyata. Brahmin, as long as the mind stirs, and there is clinging to and conceptualizing of external objects, all of that is Lokāyata.'"

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, at that time the Lokāyata brahmin asked me again, 'O sir, is there anything at all that is not Lokāyata? I am the foremost of all the tīrthikas, and I teach arrangements of collections of words, of reasons, and of various examples.' I said to him, 'O brahmin, there is, but it is not something you possess. It is not without a tenet system, nor is it something that does not teach, nor does it fail to teach various collections of words, nor does it fail to set forth reasons and examples.' The brahmin said, 'What is it that is not Lokāyata, that is not without a tenet system, and that is not without teaching?' I then said to him, 'Brahmin, there is something that is not Lokāyata, but you tīrthikas are unable to know it, because you cling to external things with the elaborations of unreal conceptuality. It is this: conceptuality does not arise; by realizing that existence and nonexistence are merely appearances of one's own mind, conceptuality does not arise; there is no grasping at external objects, and conceptuality is completely pacified. That is called what is not Lokāyata. This is my Dharma, and so it is not yours.'"

"'O brahmin, to teach it in brief: the coming and going of consciousness, its dying and transmigrating, its birth, pleasure and suffering, activity, view, contact, clinging to various characteristics, coming together and linking to a new birth, craving, and clinging to causes; O brahmin, all of these and the like are the Lokāyata of you and those like you. They are not mine.'"

"Mahāmati, when I had answered thus the question put by the Lokāyata brahmin, he fell completely silent, and having no reply, he went away. Reflecting on the position of his own system, he thought, 'Because this śramaṇa, the son of the Śākyas, has gone utterly beyond all systems, he speaks of non-arising, of signlessness, of no cause, and of conceptuality not arising through realizing the characteristic of the appearances of one's own conceptuality.'"

"Mahāmati, this concerns what you asked me earlier: 'Why did you declare that one who studies and attends upon Lokāyatas of various eloquence gathers material things and does not gather the Dharma?'"

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, what is the meaning of the words 'gathering material things' and 'Dharma'?"

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, Mahāmati, excellent, that you reflect on and ask about such a meaning of words for the sake of future sentient beings. Therefore listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "I shall do so," and listened to the Blessed One's words. The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, what is called material things is this: taking and giving, touching and tasting, clinging to external objects, falling into views of the two extremes, and again producing the aggregate of suffering, birth, aging, sickness, death, sorrow, lamentation, and distress. Such illusions arise from craving. Therefore those who study and attend upon the Lokāyata, and the Lokāyatas themselves, are called 'material things' by me and by the other buddhas as well. This is called gathering material things and not gathering the Dharma."

Mahāmati, what is the gathering of the Dharma? It is this. One thoroughly realizes and understands that whatever appears is merely one's own mind. Having attained the characteristic of the selflessness of persons and of phenomena, one no longer gives rise to conceptual thought. Growing ever more skilled in the grounds, stage after stage, one turns back mind, mentation, and mental consciousness. There are the wisdom of all the buddhas and the perfect empowerment. One fully embraces the ten inexhaustible stations, and one gains effortless mastery over all phenomena. This is what is called Dharma. It does not fall into any view, any conceptual elaboration, any conceptual thought, any entity, or either of the two extremes.

Mahāmati, childish tīrthikas mostly fall into the two extremes of eternalism and annihilationism, but the wise do not. The eternalist view arises from holding to the doctrine that there is no cause. The annihilationist view arises from seeing external causes perish and from seeing causes and conditions as without real existence. Mahāmati, because it does not see arising, abiding, or perishing, this is called Dharma. Mahāmati, this is what is meant by material things and by Dharma, and you and the other bodhisattva great beings should train in it.

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

All the Lokāyata
taught by the tīrthikas is false.
Through concepts they see a doer and a deed,
and they have no tenet of their own.

This tenet of mine alone
has wholly abandoned doer and deed.
Free from the Lokāyata,
I teach it to my disciples.

Since mere mind is not apprehended,
one does not conceive of two minds as separate.
Grasped and grasper have no real existence,
and both eternalism and annihilation are abandoned.

As long as the mind is active,
so long is there Lokāyata.
When conceptual thought is not active,
one sees one's own mind.

When coming, an entity is said to arise;
when going, the entity does not appear at all.
If one clearly realizes going and coming,
conceptual thought, too, does not arise.

Permanent and impermanent,
made and unmade,
this world and the world beyond:
all of these are the way of the Lokāyata.

Then Mahāmati again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, as for what is called nirvāṇa, to what sort of phenomenon is the name nirvāṇa given, when the tīrthikas each produce their own conceptions of it?"

The Blessed One said, "Therefore, Mahāmati, listen very well and bear it in mind, and I shall explain to you how the tīrthikas conceive of nirvāṇa, and how their conceptions do not accord with nirvāṇa."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "So be it," and listened. The Blessed One then spoke as follows:

"Mahāmati, some tīrthikas conceive these to be nirvāṇa: the cessation of the aggregates, elements, and sense sources; freedom from desire for objects; seeing phenomena as impermanent; the non-arising of the domain of mind and mental factors; not recalling past, future, or present objects; the aggregates of appropriation being exhausted and ceasing like a lamp; and conceptual thought no longer arising, because it has been destroyed like a seed. But Mahāmati, a view of destruction is not what is called nirvāṇa.

"Some say that liberation is going from place to place. Some say that liberation is when the conceptualization of objects ceases and one becomes like the wind when it has died down. Some say that liberation is the destruction of the seeing of knower and knowable. Some conceive of liberation as seeing the permanent and the impermanent. Some think that the many perceptions of signs will bring about the causes that produce suffering. Because they are not skilled in the fact that what appears is merely their own mind, they are afraid and terrified of signs. Delighting in and longing for the seeing of signlessness, they conceive this to be nirvāṇa. Some understand the specific and general characteristics of all inner and outer phenomena, hold that past, future, and present exist as real entities, and conceive of nirvāṇa as what is imperishable. Some conceive of nirvāṇa as the imperishability of the self, the person, the sentient being, the life principle, and all phenomena.

"Some tīrthikas, their wisdom burned by the fire of wrong views, see Nature (prakṛti) and the Person, and say that what the Person brings forth from the existence of these two is called Nature. They conceive of nirvāṇa as the transformation of the qualities (guṇas), like the primordial darkness, and as the agent of the qualities. Some conceive of nirvāṇa through the exhaustion of merit and demerit, some through the exhaustion of the afflictions and through knowledge, and some through seeing that saṃsāra is truly made by the Lord (Īśvara). Some hold that the states of saṃsāra produce one another, and that there is no other cause whatsoever. Thus they cling to a cause, and being deluded they do not understand it; and because they do not understand it, they conceive this to be nirvāṇa.

"Some tīrthikas conceive of nirvāṇa as the attainment of the path of true reality. Some conceive of nirvāṇa as seeing the possessor of qualities and what is produced by the qualities as an aggregate, as one, as different, as both, or as neither. Some hold that things arise from intrinsic nature, and seeing the intrinsic nature of things as being like the variegated colors of the peacock, the source of the various jewels, or the sharpness of thorns, they

conceive this to be nirvāṇa.

"Mahāmati, some conceive of nirvāṇa through understanding that the twenty-five categories of existence are reality; some through protecting the king's realm and upholding the teaching of the six policies. Some see time as the agent and understand that the arising of the world depends on time, and from this understanding they conceive of nirvāṇa. Some conceive of it through entities, some through the absence of entities, and some through the full knowledge of entities and the absence of entities.

Some, seeing that there is a difference between the conceptualization of entities and nirvāṇa, conceive of that as nirvāṇa. Thus, although the tīrthikas have taught various conceptions of this kind, these are not in accord with reason, and so the wise have rejected them. Mahāmati, all of these people conceive of nirvāṇa with a mind that falls into the two extremes. Although the tīrthikas imagine nirvāṇa through conceptions such as these, in it nothing whatsoever arises or ceases. Mahāmati, when those various nirvāṇas of the tīrthikas are examined by means of their own treatises and their own knowledge, none of them can be established at all. Just as their conceptualizing mind and mentation come and go and move about, so not one of them attains nirvāṇa.

Mahāmati, the nirvāṇa that I have taught is this. It is to be skilled in, and to realize, that things are mere appearances of one's own mind. It is to abandon completely both clinging to external things and the four extremes. It is to see the real just as it abides, and so not to fall into the two extremes of conceptualizing what appears to one's own mind. It is, because neither grasped object nor grasping subject is apprehended, not to see anything as established by any valid cognition, and to abandon such cognition completely, thinking, "Since it is confusion about suchness, it should not be taken up." It is to attain the Dharma of one's own noble, personally realized knowledge. It is to realize the two kinds of selflessness, to abandon the two afflictions completely, to purify the two obscurations, and to abandon the two kinds of death and transmigration once and for all. It is, by refining the grounds higher and higher, to enter the ground of the Tathāgata and attain the profound samādhis such as the one like a reflection and the one like an illusion. And it is to abandon mind, mentation, and mental consciousness completely. This is what is taught as nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, you and the other bodhisattva mahāsattvas should train in this, and should swiftly abandon all the views of the tīrthikas concerning nirvāṇa.

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The tīrthikas' views of nirvāṇa,
whatever separate conceptions arise,
are born from the imaginings of the mind;
in them there is no means to liberation.

Deluded about what binds and what is bound,
because they have abandoned skill in means,
the tīrthikas who conceive of liberation
will never bring liberation to birth.

The ways the tīrthikas see things
proceed in many different cognitions;
for them there is no liberation,
because of foolish, deluded conception.

The foolish tīrthikas, every one,
conceptually see an agent and an act.
Those who speak in terms of being and nonbeing,
for them there is no liberation.

The childish delight in conceptions;
they will not come to hear of true wisdom.
Discourse is the abode of the three sufferings;
the true is the cause of suffering's destruction.

Just as reflections in a mirror
appear, and yet do not exist,
so in the mirror of the conceptual mind
the childish see a duality as existing.

Not knowing mind and its object,
twofold conceptuality arises;
when mind and object are fully known,
conceptuality will not arise.

Mind is what turns into the manifold;
since characteristic and characterized are abandoned,
though acts appear, they do not appear
in the way the childish imagine them.

Because the three realms of existence are mere conceptuality,
there are no external objects;
conceptuality appears in manifold forms,
and this the childish do not understand.

In sūtra upon sūtra conceptuality is explained;
it never goes beyond mere names.
Apart from the expressions themselves,
there is nothing whatsoever to be expressed.

From the Noble Sūtra of the Precious Descent into Laṅkā, the seventh fascicle.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain the very nature of a perfectly complete buddha. Then I and the other bodhisattva mahāsattvas will become skilled in the nature of the Tathāgata, and will bring both ourselves and others to understand it."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, ask whatever you wish, and I shall explain it just as you ask."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, is the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, to be called made or unmade, an entity or a cause, a characteristic or the basis of characteristics, an expression or what is expressed, cognition or what is to be cognized? With such words as these, is he to be called different from them or not different?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha, is neither the entity of such words nor their cause. Why is that? Because either way faults would follow. Mahāmati, if the Tathāgata were an entity, he would be made, and so impermanent. Being impermanent, all entities too would then be the Tathāgata, and that is accepted neither by me nor by any of the tathāgatas. If, on the other hand, he were not made, then, since he could not be apprehended, all striving would be pointless, because he would be nonexistent, like the horn of a rabbit or the son of a barren woman. Mahāmati, that which is neither an entity nor a cause is neither existent nor nonexistent. That which is neither existent nor nonexistent is beyond the four extremes. The four extremes are the expressions of the world. What is beyond the four extremes does not fall into the four extremes. Because it does not fall into them, the wise accept it. In the same way, the meaning of all the words for the Tathāgata should be understood.

"Mahāmati, the intelligent should likewise understand the meaning of my statement that all phenomena are selfless. The nature of selflessness is selflessness itself: all phenomena exist as their own entity, but do not exist as the entity of something else. It is like an ox and a horse. Mahāmati, for example, in what is not the entity of an ox or of a horse, that entity of an ox or a horse is neither truly existent nor nonexistent. Yet it is not that it lacks its own characteristic.

Likewise, Mahāmati, it is not that all phenomena lack their own characteristics. Although they do have their own characteristics, childish ordinary beings are unable to understand selflessness, because they conceptualize in this way. Likewise, the emptiness, the nonarising and the absence of intrinsic nature of all phenomena should be understood in the same way.

Likewise, the Tathāgata is neither different from the aggregates nor identical with them. If he were not different from the aggregates, he would be impermanent. If he were different, all practices would become pointless. If they were two, they would be different. Take the horns of a cow: because they are alike, they are not different, and because there is a distinction of long and short, they are not non-different either. So it is with all phenomena. Mahāmati, the right horn of a cow is different from the left horn, and the left horn is different from the right horn. Therefore the two horns should be understood as certainly different. In the same way, long and short and the various forms are also different from one another.

Mahāmati, the Tathāgata too is neither different nor non-different from the aggregates, the elements and the sense sources. Likewise, the Tathāgata is neither different nor non-different from liberation. For this reason the Tathāgata is designated by the name "liberation." If the Tathāgata and liberation were different, he would be produced from the characteristic of form, and because he would be produced from the characteristic of form, he would be impermanent. If they were not different, the characteristic attained by yogins would have no distinction. Yet since yogins do see a distinction, they are therefore neither different nor non-different. Likewise, knowledge and the knowable are neither different nor non-different.

Mahāmati, that in which knowledge and the knowable are neither different nor non-different is neither permanent nor impermanent, neither agent nor made, neither conditioned nor unconditioned, neither the intellect nor what is to be cognized, neither the characteristic nor the basis of the characteristic. It is not

the aggregates, nor is it different from the aggregates. It is neither the explanation nor what is to be explained. It is neither one nor different, neither both nor neither; and because of this, it is free from all means of valid cognition. What is free from all means of valid cognition is beyond words. What is beyond words is unborn. What is unborn is unceasing. What is unceasing is utterly at peace. What is utterly at peace is nirvāṇa by its very nature. What is nirvāṇa by its very nature is without entity and without cause. What is without entity and without cause is without an object of apprehension. What is without an object of apprehension has passed beyond all conceptual elaboration. What has passed beyond all conceptual elaboration is the Tathāgata. Whatever is the Tathāgata is the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha himself. Mahāmati, that is what is called perfect and complete buddhahood. Mahāmati, perfect and complete buddhahood is free from the sense faculties and from all means of valid cognition.

Then, in order to teach that same meaning once again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Utterly free of the faculties and means of valid cognition,
Without entity and without cause,
Wholly rid of intellect and what is cognized,
Rid too of characteristic and basis of characteristic:
The aggregates, conditions and the like, and the Buddha,
Cannot be seen as one or as different.
If there is no seeing of them,
Why then should one conceptualize?

Not made and not unmade,
Not an entity and not a cause,
Not the aggregates, not abiding in the aggregates,
Nor is there any mixture with something else.
Entities do not exist
In the way that they are imagined;
Yet know that they are not nonexistent either:
This is the true nature of phenomena.

Because there comes to be existence, nonexistence exists;
Because there comes to be nonexistence, existence exists.
One should not grasp at nonexistence,
Nor should one imagine existence.

Those corrupted by self and no-self,
Who engage in mere sounds,
Sink down into the two extremes,
And bring ruin on themselves and the world.
One who is wholly freed from every fault
And thoroughly examines my way
Has the right understanding;
Such a one does not revile the great Guide.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, in the sūtras the Blessed One has spoken of no arising and no ceasing, and elsewhere the Blessed One has also said that no arising and no ceasing is a designation of the Tathāgata. Did the Blessed One speak of no arising and no ceasing because there is no entity, or is it another synonym for the Tathāgata?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, although I teach that all phenomena are unarising and unceasing, the positions of existence and nonexistence do not appear."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, if all phenomena are unborn, then even the word 'phenomenon' would not be apprehended, since all phenomena are unborn. But if there is some phenomenon to which the name belongs, may the Blessed One please explain it."

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, Mahāmati, excellent! Listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall analyze it and explain it to you."

"So be it," said Mahāmati to the Blessed One, and as he listened, the Blessed One spoke thus: "Mahāmati, I do not teach that the Tathāgata is a nonentity, nor do I speak of all phenomena by way of nonarising and nonceasing. And because it does not depend on conditions, even though it is unarising and unceasing, it is not meaningless.

Mahāmati, when I teach "the unborn" as an epithet for the name of the Tathāgata whose Dharma body is mind-made, this is not within the range of the tīrthikas, the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas, or the bodhisattvas who abide on the seventh ground. Mahāmati, that word "unborn" is a synonym for the Tathāgata.

Mahāmati, it is like Indra, Śakra, Purandara, and so on. A single thing has many synonymous names. Yet having many names does not make it many things, and neither is it without an intrinsic nature. In the same way, Mahāmati, in this Sahā world system I am known to the ears of the childish by three hundred thousand countless names. Although they speak my names, each in their own way, they do not know that these are synonyms for the name of the Tathāgata.

Mahāmati, some beings know me as the Tathāgata. Some know me as the Omniscient One. Some know me as the Buddha. Some know me as the Protector of the World. Some know me as the Self-Knowing One. Some know me as the Guide. Some know me as the Leader. Some know me as the Chief Guide. Some know me as the Sage. Some know me as Brahmā. Some know me as Viṣṇu. Some know me as the Lord (Īśvara). Some know me as the Principal (pradhāna). Some know me as Kapila. Some know me as the Limit of Reality. Some know me as the Moon. Some know me as the Sun. Some know me as the Master. Some know me as the Unborn. Some know me as the Unceasing. Some know me as Emptiness. Some know me as Suchness. Some know me as Truth. Some know me as Reality. Some know me as the Essential Nature of Phenomena. Some know me as Nirvāṇa. Some know me as the Permanent. Some know me as Equality. Some know me as the Nondual. Some know me as the Signless. Some know me as Liberation. Some know me as the Path. And some know me fully as the Mind-Arisen.

Mahāmati, by these and other names, three hundred thousand countless names, neither more nor fewer, everyone in this world system and in others fully knows me, like the moon in water, as neither emerging nor entering. But childish ordinary beings do not truly know me, because they have fallen into the two extremes. Even so, they honor me and make offerings to me. Yet because they are not skilled in the way words convey meaning, they cannot distinguish the names, and because they do not know their own principle, they cling to the various expressions and perceive the unborn and unceasing as nonexistence. They do not understand that the different synonymous names of the Tathāgata are like Indra, Śakra, and Purandara, and because they are confused about the ultimate principle of their own, they cling to all phenomena exactly as the sounds express them.

Mahāmati, those foolish people say this: "The meaning is just as the word is; the meaning is nothing other than the sound. Why is that? Because there is no meaning at all apart from it, there is nothing other than the sound. It is sound

alone." Mahāmati, those whose minds are scorched by wrong views do not fully know the nature of sound, and so they do not understand that sound has arising and ceasing, while meaning has no arising and ceasing.

Mahāmati, every sound falls into letters. Meaning does not fall into them, because it has abandoned both existence and nonexistence, and because it takes no birth and has no body. Mahāmati, the Tathāgata does not teach a Dharma that falls into letters, because neither the existence nor the nonexistence of letters is observed; rather, he teaches the Dharma through what does not fall into letters. Mahāmati, if some say, "The Tathāgata does not teach a Dharma that falls into letters," they speak falsely, for the nature of reality is free of letters.

Therefore, Mahāmati, the buddhas and bodhisattvas, myself among them, have not spoken a single letter, nor will they speak one. Why is that? Because phenomena are free of letters. Yet neither do they teach what is unconnected with meaning, for expression is the conceptual thought of sentient beings. Mahāmati, if all phenomena were not taught, the teachings would perish. If the teachings perished, there would be no buddhas, bodhisattvas, pratyekabuddhas, or śrāvakas. And if they did not exist, who would teach what to whom?

Therefore, Mahāmati, a bodhisattva, a great being, should not cling to the sounds of what is spoken in teaching, but should explain the teachings of the sūtras extensively, in accordance with the dispositions of beings. For since the hopes and afflictions of sentient beings are not all of one kind, I and the other buddhas teach the Dharma to beings of various differing inclinations in order to turn back mind, mentation, and mental consciousness, and not for the attainment of the state of the noble wisdom that is individually self-aware.

Mahāmati, bodhisattvas, great beings, who have understood all phenomena to be without appearance, to be the mere appearance of their own mind, and who have abandoned the two conceptualizations, should rely on the meaning and not rely on the letter. Mahāmati, any son or daughter of good family who relies on the letter ruins themselves with respect to the ultimate and is unable to bring others to realization. Fallen into the stream of wrong views, they proclaim these to the assemblies. Being unskilled in all phenomena, all the grounds, and all signs, they do not comprehend the various senses of words. But if one is skilled in all phenomena, all the grounds, and all signs, comprehends the various senses of words, and comes to possess the real

meaning, then one satisfies oneself with the bliss of the genuine signless, and also establishes sentient beings in the equality of the Great Vehicle.

Mahāmati, when one upholds the Great Vehicle, one upholds the buddhas, the bodhisattvas, the pratyekabuddhas and the śrāvakas. By upholding the buddhas, the bodhisattvas, the pratyekabuddhas and the śrāvakas, one upholds all sentient beings. By upholding all sentient beings, one upholds the true Dharma. By upholding the true Dharma, one does not cut off the lineage of the buddhas. One who does not cut off the lineage of the buddhas attains the knowledge that enters into the distinguished states. The bodhisattva great beings who have attained the knowledge that enters into the distinguished states are always born apparitionally. Because they establish the Great Vehicle, they display a variety of forms through the strength of the ten masteries. Because they fully understand the dispositions, the inclinations and the characteristics of the afflictions of sentient beings, they teach the Dharma just as it truly is.

Here, what is called "teaching just as it truly is" is nothing other than suchness. That which has the characteristic of neither coming nor going, and in which all conceptual elaborations are completely pacified, is called suchness.

Mahāmati, sons of good family and daughters of good family should not grasp the words literally and cling to them, because suchness is free of names and letters. Mahāmati, if someone points out a thing to a fool with the tip of a finger, that fool looks at the fingertip and so does not reach the true meaning. In the same way, childish ordinary beings also grasp and cling to the fingertip of literal words, and, not letting go of it until the moment of death, they are unable to attain the ultimate suchness that lies beyond the fingertip of literal words.

Mahāmati, it is like this: small children ought to eat food that has been cooked, and ought not to eat what has not been cooked. If they eat what is uncooked, they fall ill with a disorder of the bowels, because they do not know how to prepare food step by step. Mahāmati, in the same way, non-arising and non-cessation too are not agreeable unless they are brought about through skillful means. Therefore, Mahāmati, one should strive to accomplish them through skillful means, and should not follow the words, as one would by looking at the fingertip. For this reason, Mahāmati, one should earnestly apply oneself through skillful means to the meaning of suchness.

Here, the meaning of suchness is utter solitude; it is the cause of nirvāṇa. Words accord with conceptual thought, and conceptual thought gathers up saṃsāra. Mahāmati, the meaning of suchness is obtained from much learning. Mahāmati, much learning is this: being skilled in the meaning, not being skilled in the words. One who is skilled in the meaning does not follow any of the doctrines of the tīrthikas; thus he himself does not follow them, nor does he cause others to follow them. This is called possessing great virtue and much learning. Therefore those who seek the meaning should rely on much learning, that is to say, on those skilled in the meaning. Those who are the opposite of this, who cling to words, should be entirely abandoned.

Then again the bodhisattva Mahāmati, through the blessing of the Buddha, said this to the Blessed One:

"What the Blessed One has set forth as non-arising and non-cessation is nothing marvelous at all. Why is that? Because the tīrthikas too say that the cause is unborn and unceasing. The Blessed One too has said that space, cessation not brought about by analysis, and the realm of nirvāṇa are unborn and unceasing. Blessed One, the tīrthikas also say that the worlds arise from a cause. The Blessed One too has declared that the worlds arise conditioned by ignorance, craving, karma and conceptual thought. The difference between their 'cause' and this 'condition' is merely one of name. The causes and conditions of external things are likewise. Therefore, Blessed One, there turns out to be no difference between what the Blessed One says and what the tīrthikas say.

"The tīrthikas also speak thus: 'Atoms, the Principal (pradhāna), the Lord (Īśvara), Prajāpati and so forth, together with the nine substances, are unborn and unceasing.' And the Blessed One too has declared: 'Because all things are unborn and unceasing, neither existence nor nonexistence is apprehended.' The tīrthikas also say: 'Because the four great elements are indestructible, their own characteristics neither arise nor cease. The four great elements are forever great elements; although they pervade all destinies, they do not abandon their intrinsic nature.' Since they say this, what the Blessed One has declared is just the same. That is why I say this is not greatly marvelous.

"Blessed One, please explain the distinction that is greatly marvelous and that sets you apart from the tīrthikas. If there is no distinction, then the tīrthikas too would be buddhas, since they likewise hold non-arising and non-cessation. The Blessed One has also said that it is impossible for many buddhas to

appear in a single world system. Yet if we go by what has been declared in this way, many buddhas would appear in a single world system, since there is no distinction."

The Blessed One said to Mahāmati: "The non-arising and non-cessation that I teach are not the same as the non-arising and non-cessation of the tīrthikas. Why is that? Those tīrthikas, because they hold that things have an intrinsic nature, do not attain the characteristic of what is unborn and unchanging. But I do not fall in this way into the extremes of existence and nonexistence."

Mahāmati, I am free from the positions of existence and nonexistence, and free from arising and perishing. I am neither a thing nor a nonthing. Because things appear like a magical illusion and like the various forms in a dream, they are not nonthings either. If one asks how they are nonthings, it is like this: form has no characteristic of intrinsic nature, the objects that are apprehended appear and also do not appear, and they are not grasped by an apprehender. Therefore all things are neither things nor nonthings.

Thus, when one realizes that everything is merely the appearance of one's own mind, conceptual thought does not arise, and because one is utterly at ease, worldly activities are completely pacified. Childish, unskilled ordinary people imagine that activities exist, but the noble ones do not. Unreal conceptual thought is like a city of gandharvas, like a magical illusion, like an emanated person. Mahāmati, it is as when, within a city of gandharvas, many various throngs of illusory and emanated persons come out and go in. Childish, unskilled people, with their conceptual thought, say, "These truly come out; they go in." Yet in reality there is nothing that can be called coming out or going in, because it is nothing but conceptual thought.

In the same way, Mahāmati, childish, unskilled ordinary people produce error about what has no arising and no cessation. In that there is nothing whatever, conditioned or unconditioned. Like an illusory person, although it arises, in reality there is no arising or ceasing at all in it, because neither thing nor nonthing exists at all. All phenomena are likewise: they are free of arising and ceasing. Yet childish, unskilled ordinary people, having fallen into the unreal, give rise to the conceptual thought of arising and ceasing, but the noble ones do not.

Here, "unreal" means that the intrinsic nature of things is neither as it is imagined nor otherwise. If one were to imagine it otherwise, one would become attached to the intrinsic nature of all things, and so would not see its

utter isolation. If one does not see its utter isolation, one will not become free of conceptual thought. Therefore, Mahāmati, one sees the Supreme through the signless, not through signs. Because seeing in terms of signs is the cause of taking birth, it is not the Supreme.

Mahāmati, in the signless, conceptual thought does not arise. Because there is no occurrence and no cessation, I speak of nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, as for nirvāṇa: by seeing the real meaning just as it is, the former conceptual mind and mental factors are abandoned, and the noble wisdom of the Tathāgata, known individually by oneself, is attained. That, I have taught, is nirvāṇa.

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

To reverse those who assert arising,
I have set forth the meaning of non-arising.
The Dharma I have explained in this way
the childish are unable to understand.

Since all phenomena do not arise,
they are without substance and without arising.
Dream, illusion, city of gandharvas:
though things exist, there is no cause.

Why is it taught as unarisen,
as without intrinsic nature, and also as empty?
When aggregations are utterly abandoned
and the intellect understands, things do not appear.
Therefore emptiness, the unarisen,
I have explained as without intrinsic nature.

Since in this way each one is an aggregation,
things appear, yet they do not exist.
When analyzed, there is no aggregation;
yet it is not as the tīrthikas view it either.

Like a dream, an illusion, floating hairs,
a mirage, or a city of gandharvas,
all the various things of the world
appear with the characteristic of having no cause.

To tame those who assert a cause,
the meaning of the unarisen is proclaimed.

Because non-arising is proclaimed,
the way of the Dharma is not cut off.

Those who proclaim causelessness
are the dreadful tīrthikas.
How, and for what reason,
and why, would anything come to arise?
Where things have come together,
they speak of there being no cause.

When conditioned phenomena are well examined,
there is neither causelessness nor cause;
the views of those who speak
of arising and perishing then turn away.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati put a question in verse:

For what reason is there no arising?
Or is it that there are no things?
Or is it with reference to conditions?
Or do you say that phenomena exist yet do not arise?
A name without meaning is not fitting.
Please explain it, making distinctions.

Then the Blessed One spoke in verse:

It is not that nonthings do not arise,
nor is it a designation dependent on conditions.
The name is not there because things exist,
nor is the name without meaning.

What is not the domain of any tīrthikas,
of śrāvakas or of pratyekabuddhas,
or of those on the seven grounds,
that is the characteristic of non-arising.

Causes and conditions utterly abandoned,
utterly free of all activity,
a sentient being of utmost subtlety abides;
having abandoned characteristic and basis of characteristic,
the transformation of that body
I call non-arising.

Neither external things nor nonthings,
no grasping on the part of sentient beings,
all views completely abandoned:
this I call non-arising.

Thus absence of intrinsic nature,
emptiness and the rest, should be distinguished.
It is not called empty because of emptiness;
it is called empty because of non-arising.

From the coming together of the assemblage of causes and conditions,
arising and perishing come to exist.
Apart from the assemblage of causes and conditions,
there is no arising and no perishing.
Apart from the assemblage of causes and conditions,
there are no distinct things.
"One" and "different"
are the conceptions of the tīrthikas.

Existent and nonexistent things do not arise;
they are neither existent nor nonexistent.
Except for the changing of the assemblage,
nothing whatever is perceived.
Since the assemblage exists merely conventionally,
things are linked to one another.
Apart from the linking of causes and conditions,
the meaning of arising is not tenable.

Because there is no arising, they do not become things,
and the faults of the tīrthikas are abandoned.
Only the linking of conditions is taught;
the childish do not understand it.

If, apart from the connection of conditions,
one says that things arise,
that is to assert causelessness,
and it destroys the meaning of connection.

Just as a lamp makes forms visible,
if connection likewise made things visible,
then it would follow that things
exist apart from the connection.

Since nonexistent things have no arising,
they are like the nature of space.
When one has turned away from connections,
there is nothing for the intellect to conceive.

There is, moreover, another non-arising:
the nature of reality attained by the noble ones.
That in which arising does not occur
is the patience of non-arising.

When one fully discerns
all these worlds as mere connection,
then, having entirely abandoned all connection,
one attains samādhi.

Ignorance, craving, karma, and so on:
these are the inner connection.
Insentient things, the lump of clay, the wheel,
the seed, and so on, are the outer.

If one claims that some other thing exists
that arises from causes and conditions,
since that is not the meaning of connection,
it too will not be established.

If arising has no intrinsic nature,
whose connection would it be?
Because they produce one another,
they should be understood as cause and condition.

The qualities of solidity, moisture, heat, and motion
are imagined by the childish.
Apart from enumeration there is no other phenomenon;
therefore it is taught that there are no things.

Just as physicians who heal diseases,
though their treatise is not different,
teach a variety of remedies
according to the particular differences of the diseases,

so I too, in order to dismantle
the diseases of affliction of those beings,
having fully understood their faculties,

teach them the gateways to liberation.

Though afflictions and faculties differ,
the Dharma is not manifold.
Teaching the Dharma of the single vehicle alone:
that is the Great Vehicle.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, all the tīrthikas also conceive of impermanence. And the Blessed One too has declared, 'All formations are impermanent; they are of the nature to arise and perish.' What is the meaning of this? Is it mistaken, or is it correct? How many kinds of impermanence are there?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, among the tīrthikas there are seven kinds of impermanence, but these are not in my teaching. What are the seven? Some of them say this: 'To cease after having been actively brought into being is impermanence.' Some say, 'The destruction of shape is impermanence.' Some say, 'Form itself is impermanence.' Some say, 'The state in which form changes is called impermanence: because things uninterruptedly link up and perish of their own accord, just as the distinct differences in milk turning into curd and so on cannot be seen, so too impermanence as destruction operates in all things.' Some say, 'Things are impermanence.' Some say, 'The nonexistence of things is impermanence.' Some say, 'Because all phenomena are unarisen, impermanence enters into all phenomena.'

"Here, Mahāmati, what is called impermanence as the nonexistence of things is this: the own-characteristic of the four great elements and of what derives from the elements perishes, and the intrinsic nature of the four great elements is not apprehended and does not arise. As for what is called the impermanence of non-arising: since it is permanence and impermanence, all phenomena, existent and nonexistent, do not arise, and when they are broken down even to the minute particle, they are not seen. This is the meaning of non-arising; it is not arising. Therefore this is the characteristic of the impermanence of non-arising. Those who do not understand this fall into the tīrthikas' notion of impermanence as arising.

"Mahāmati, impermanence as a thing is something imagined by one's own mind; it is not a thing that is permanent or impermanent. Why is that? It is like this: impermanence itself does not perish by its own essential nature. Mahāmati, this is the activity of impermanence, because all things become

nonexistent. Apart from impermanence, nothing else whatsoever is observed to render the existence of all phenomena nonexistent, in the way that sticks, potsherds, and stones destroy things. Because in direct perception each is seen as not distinct, impermanence is the activity of things, but there is no distinction between agent and action, because there is no distinction such as 'this is impermanence, this is the action.' If agent and action were not different, all things would be permanent and would lack the nature of a cause.

"Mahāmati, the absence of essential nature of all things has a cause, but it is not something to be known by childish ordinary beings. If it were not a cause, it would produce dissimilar things. If it did produce them, then all things would be impermanent, and since things would also be dissimilar, agent and action would be without distinction; yet all would be seen as having distinctions. If essential nature were impermanence, then, should it fall into the characteristic of the nature of a cause of action, all things would not be complete. If it falls into the characteristic of a cause that acts upon all things, impermanence itself would be impermanent. Because impermanence itself would be impermanent, all things would not be impermanent; they would be permanent. If impermanence had entered into all things, it would fall into the three times: past form is endowed with having perished; what is future is unarisen, because the form has not arisen; and present form is endowed with the characteristic of perishing. Here, form is a particular accumulation of the great elements. The intrinsic nature of the great elements and of the forms derived from the elements does not perish, because it is free from difference and non-difference. Thus all the tīrthikas conceive of the great elements as imperishable."

Mahāmati, if one knows that all of the three realms of existence, the elements and the forms derived from the elements that abide there, are subject to arising and perishing, then what, apart from the great elements and the derived forms, do the tīrthikas have in mind when they conceive of "impermanence"? For they hold that the four great elements do not arise and that their characteristic of intrinsic nature does not perish.

Among these, what is called the impermanence that is the cessation of a first beginning is not the four great elements themselves. It is so because, moreover, the four great elements are distinct, their characteristics are each distinct, and each has its own characteristic. Since no difference among them is apprehended, since they have no such difference, and so on, there is no further beginning; and the absence of any beginning of a second kind of

combination is to be known as impermanence.

Among these, what is called the impermanence that is the destruction of shape is this. They say that the four great elements and the forms made from them as their cause do not perish, and do not perish right down to the limit. Mahāmati, "down to the limit" means divided down to atoms. When one examines them one by one in their destruction, the shape and the long and short in which the four great elements and the derived forms are seen as distinct are no longer apprehended. Since it is not the four great elements that perish, the four great elements do not perish. Through the view that shape is what perishes, they fall into the doctrine of the Sāṃkhyas.

Among these, what is called impermanence as form itself is this. Since form itself is impermanence, it is those shapes that are impermanent, not the great elements. If the four elements were impermanent, they would not be spoken of in the reckoning of the world. If there were no thing for the world to speak of, one would fall into the view of the worldly Lokāyatas, because they see all things as mere words of expression and do not see the arising of anything with its own characteristic.

Among these, what is called the impermanence of transformation is this: form appears to change into another thing, but not the great elements. Just as when things made of gold, ornaments, appear to change, the nature of the gold does not perish, though the shape of the ornament perishes; so too with the transformation of other things and the like. In these and similar ways the tīrthikas conceive views of impermanence. Thus, when fire burns the great elements, it does not burn their own characteristic. If, each on its own, their own characteristics destroyed one another, then it would follow that the elements and the forms made from them as their cause would be cut off.

Mahāmati, my Dharma, in its very arising, is neither permanent nor impermanent. Why is that? It is because external things are not determined that the three realms of existence are taught to be mind only; it is not taught that there are various characteristics, arising and perishing. Because of the distinctions in the aggregation of the great elements, and because of elements and what derives from elements, there comes to be the conceptualizing of the two kinds of things as grasped object and grasping subject. One fully understands these two conceptions, is free from the two views of external things as existent and as nonexistent, and realizes that all is the mere appearance of one's own mind, which arises from the conditioning of

conceptual thought and is not unconditioned. Thus, because the mind is free from the conceptualizing of things and non-things, all phenomena, worldly, transcendent, and supremely transcendent, are neither permanent nor impermanent. By not realizing that all is the mere appearance of one's own mind, one falls into the stream of the bad views of the two extremes; all the tīrthikas fail to understand their own conceptual thought. Since those ordinary beings have no basis whatsoever, childish ordinary beings do not understand that worldly, transcendent, and supremely transcendent phenomena arise in this way from the conceptualizing of words.

Then, to teach this very meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

"A first beginning, then a full cessation,
Shape, and the change into another state,
Things, and form, are impermanent:
So the foolish tīrthikas conceive.
Yet for things there is no perishing;
The elements abide in the nature of elements.
The tīrthikas with their notion of impermanence
Sink into a variety of views.
For those tīrthikas
There is no arising or perishing at all;
The nature of the elements is permanent,
So how can they conceive of impermanence?
All is the appearance of mind only;
Mind too proceeds in two ways,
As grasped object and as grasping subject.
There is no self, and nothing that belongs to a self.
Brahmā is the trunk and the root;
Branches and leaves pervade everywhere.
Thus have I taught:
These are their mind only."

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati again addressed the Blessed One, saying: "Blessed One, please explain the characteristic of the sequence and connection of the attainment of cessation for all bodhisattvas, śrāvakas, and pratyekabuddhas. If I become skilled in the characteristic of the sequence and connection of the attainment of cessation, then I and other bodhisattvas will not abandon the gateway to the bliss of the attainment of cessation, and will not fall into the delusion of the śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas, and tīrthikas."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, listen very well and hold it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, please explain," and the Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, bodhisattva great beings of the sixth stage, as well as śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, bring about the attainment. Bodhisattva great beings of the seventh stage enter the attainment in each and every instant of mind; they enter the attainment through fully abandoning the characteristic of the intrinsic nature of all things. Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas do not, for śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, having a conditioning intellect, fall into the characteristics of grasped object and grasping subject, and in that way enter the attainment of cessation.

Therefore, on the seventh ground one does not enter absorption by means of attention. Because one has attained the characteristic of the non-distinction of all phenomena, one does not gradually attain the various things that have characteristics. One comprehends the specific characteristics of all virtuous and nonvirtuous phenomena, and since that is what entering absorption is, on the seventh ground there is no entering absorption with a virtuous mind.

Mahāmati, for bodhisattvas on the eighth ground, and for śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, the conceptuality of mind, mentation and mind-consciousness, together with perception, comes to a halt.

The bodhisattvas from the first ground up to the seventh examine one by one that this threefold realm is nothing but mind, mentation and mind-consciousness, that it is free of self and of what belongs to a self, and that it is the activity of their own conceptuality. Childish ordinary beings, however, do not comprehend this. They have fallen into the characteristics of various external things. Because their own characteristics have become the twofold thing of grasped and grasper, they follow after ignorance. Since beginningless time they have been thoroughly imbued with the habitual tendencies of the dysfunction of conceptual proliferation.

Mahāmati, for the bodhisattva great beings on the eighth ground, and for the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, nirvāṇa is the same. But the bodhisattva is fully sustained by the intelligence of samādhi, and therefore does not pass into complete nirvāṇa through the bliss of the doors of samādhi. If they were not sustained in this way, the ground of a Tathāgata would not be brought to completion, all work for sentient beings would be abandoned, and the lineage of the family of the Tathāgatas would be cut off. Therefore the buddhas, the

blessed ones, reveal the inconceivable and immeasurable qualities of a Tathāgata. The śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, because they are carried away by the bliss of the doors of samādhi, conceive of it as nirvāṇa.

Mahāmati, I shall set forth for the seventh ground skill in and familiarity with the characteristics of mind, mentation and mind-consciousness. I shall set forth skill in and familiarity with grasping at self and what belongs to a self, with the gathering together of the selflessness of persons and of phenomena, with arising and perishing, and with specific and general characteristics. I shall set forth skill in the powers of the four discernments, which are free of doubt, and I shall distinguish the doors of samādhi, the linking of the successive grounds, and the factors conducive to awakening.

The successive grounds are established so that the bodhisattva great beings do not remain ignorant of specific and general characteristics, are not unskilled in the seven grounds, and do not fall onto the wrong path of the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas). Yet, Mahāmati, in truth nothing at all here arises or perishes. Rather, the linking of the successive grounds and the various activities of the three realms are merely appearances of mind, and childish ordinary beings do not comprehend this. Because childish ordinary beings do not comprehend it, I and those buddhas have taught the linking of the successive grounds and the various activities of the three realms.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, on the eighth bodhisattva ground the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas are intoxicated with the bliss of the absorption of cessation. Because they are unskilled in the mere appearance of their own mind, they fall into specific and general characteristics, they are obscured by habitual tendencies, and, falling into the selflessness of persons and of phenomena, they hold it as a phenomenon. Through conceptuality they come to know it as nirvāṇa; theirs is not an intelligence devoted to perfect solitude.

Mahāmati, although a bodhisattva sees the bliss of the doors of samādhi, he possesses his former aspirations, loving tenderness and great compassion, and knows the distinctions of the ten culminating states. Therefore he does not, through conceptuality, conceive of it as nirvāṇa. Since in this way no conceptual notion of nirvāṇa arises in him, he completely abandons the conceptuality of grasped and grasper, and because he comprehends all phenomena as nothing but appearances of his own mind, conceptuality does not arise. He does not fall into a conceptuality that clings to the characteristics of the intrinsic nature of mind, mentation, mind-consciousness and external

things. Nor does he fail to produce the causes of the qualities of a buddha. Because he arises in accordance with wisdom, he attains the ground of a Tathāgata's self-aware realization.

It is like a person who, in a dream, sets out to cross a river, and wakes up before reaching the far shore. Having woken, he thinks, "Was that real, or was it unreal?" Yet it was neither real nor false. Rather, it appeared out of the dream of mind, mentation and mind-consciousness, through the habitual tendencies of various perceptions caused by beginningless seeing, hearing, discriminating and cognizing, through shapes and various places, and through falling into the characteristics of existence and nonexistence.

Mahāmati, in the same way, the bodhisattva great beings on the eighth bodhisattva ground see the arising of the characteristics of conceptuality. Having advanced through effort from the first ground to the seventh, by the practice of seeing all phenomena as like an illusion and so forth, they turn back from the activity of the conceptualizing mind of grasped and grasper. Having applied themselves to the qualities of a buddha, they attain what they have not yet attained. Mahāmati, this is the bodhisattvas' indestructible practice of nirvāṇa: having completely abandoned mind, mentation and mind-consciousness, they attain acceptance of the unarisen nature of phenomena.

Mahāmati, in the ultimate there is no succession and no linking. This is the teaching of the Dharma that is free of appearance and devoid of conceptuality.

Then, in order to teach this very meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Mind-only and no-appearance,
this abiding and the buddha ground
have been taught by the buddhas
of the three times, past, future and present.

Mind-only is the seventh ground,
no-appearance is the eighth ground;
those two grounds are called "abiding,"
and the buddha ground is supreme.
Self-aware wisdom, utterly pure:
that is my ground.

The abode of the Lord (Īśvara) and of the Supreme
is discerned and well arrayed.
Like an illuminating, blazing fire,
its light rays appear, pervading everywhere.
Its blazing rays do not harm the eyes;
it tames the three realms of existence throughout.
Through emanations it shows the abodes of the three existences.
Some were emanated long before,
and there they teach the vehicles,
all of them by the Tathāgata.
The tenth ground is the first;
the first is the eighth;
the ninth, moreover, is the seventh,
and the seventh is the eighth;
the second is the third;
the fourth is the fifth;
and the third is the sixth.
Where there is no appearance, what order can there be?

From the Noble Sūtra of the Precious Descent into Laṅkā, the eighth fascicle, which is the last.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati addressed the Blessed One (the Buddha) with these words: "Blessed One, is the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha, permanent, or is he impermanent?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly complete buddha, is neither permanent nor impermanent, because both positions are faulty. If he were permanent, there would be the fault of there being a creating agent. The non-Buddhists (tīrthikas) say that the permanent is what is not made by a maker. Therefore the Tathāgata, though permanent, is not permanent in that sense, because otherwise there would be the fault of an unmade permanence. If the Tathāgata were impermanent, there would be the fault of the impermanence of what is made. Since the characteristics of the aggregates and the things that bear those characteristics would not exist, it would follow that he is annihilated, just as the aggregates are destroyed; yet the Tathāgata is not annihilated.

"Mahāmati, if everything that is made is impermanent, then everything would incur the fault of impermanence, like pots, cloth and so on, and so the

accumulations and endeavors for omniscience would become meaningless, because they are made. And everything that is made would also be the Tathāgata, because there would be no distinguishing cause. Therefore the Tathāgata is neither permanent nor impermanent.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, the Tathāgata is not permanent in the way that space is. If he were permanent as space is, the accumulations of the noble wisdom realized individually within oneself would incur the fault of being meaningless. Mahāmati, space, for example, is neither permanent nor impermanent. Because it is free of permanence, impermanence, oneness, difference, both, and neither, and of the faults of permanence and impermanence, it cannot be expressed. Therefore the Tathāgata is not permanent.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, if the Tathāgata were permanent in the sense of being unborn, he would be like the horns of a rabbit, a horse and so on, permanent as something unborn, and so all practices would become meaningless. Since there would be the fault of an unborn permanence, the Tathāgata is not permanent.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, there is also another sense in which the Tathāgata may be understood to be permanent. Why is that? It is this: because the wisdom of uninterrupted direct realization is permanent, the Tathāgata is permanent. Mahāmati, whether tathāgatas appear in the world or do not appear in the world, the nature of reality abides invariably. The uninterrupted abiding of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas and the tathāgatas does not abide in space, and it is not something that childish ordinary beings can understand.

"Mahāmati, the wisdom realized by the tathāgatas is imbued with discernment. But, Mahāmati, the Tathāgata is not imbued with mind, mentation, mental consciousness, the aggregates, the elements and the sense sources. Mahāmati, all three existences arise from false conceptualization, but the tathāgatas do not arise from false conceptualization.

"Mahāmati, permanence and impermanence come about because there are two things; they do not apply to the nondual. The nondual is utterly solitary. Because all phenomena have the characteristic of being nondual and unborn, therefore the tathāgatas, the arhats, the perfectly complete buddhas, are neither permanent nor impermanent.

"Mahāmati, as long as verbal conceptualization operates, so long is there the fault of permanence and impermanence. But when the conceptualizing mind is exhausted, the unpacified view of permanence and impermanence held by childish ordinary beings is abandoned. Therefore the wise should utterly abandon the imprints of permanence, of impermanence, and of what is neither permanent nor impermanent."

Then, in order to teach that very meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

When the accumulations become meaningless,
the faults of permanence and impermanence arise.
When there is no conceptualizing mind,
permanence and impermanence are wholly abandoned.
From firmly asserting a thesis,
meanings arise mixed up and apart.
When one realizes equally that all is only one's own mind,
verbal expression is not found.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati again addressed the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain to me the arising and the destruction of the aggregates, the elements and the sense sources. If there is no self in them, who is it that arises, and who is it that ceases? Childish ordinary beings, because they abide in arising and destruction, do not understand the exhaustion of suffering and do not realize nirvāṇa."

The Blessed One said: "Excellent! Therefore listen well, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "I shall do just so," and listened as instructed, and the Blessed One spoke these words to Mahāmati:

The tathāgatagarbha, which is the cause of virtue and non-virtue, pervades every birth of beings. Like a dancer, it therefore displays the changing forms of beings. Because it is not understood to be free of self and of what belongs to a self, birth comes about through the joining of conditions, the coming together of three. And the tīrthikas, failing to understand it, cling to it as a creator. Since beginningless time it has been thoroughly permeated by the habitual tendencies of the dysfunction of conceptual proliferation, and so it is called the all-base consciousness. Together with the seven consciousnesses it is generated from the ground in which ignorance abides. Like the waves of the ocean, it constantly produces bodies and its continuum is unbroken. It is free

of the faults of permanence and impermanence. It is entirely removed from the doctrines that assert a self. By nature it is stainless, and ultimately it is completely pure.

The other consciousnesses are subject to arising and perishing. Mentation, mental consciousness and the rest, together with their seven moments, take up the various shapes and positions of objects, caused by false imagination. They cling to names and signs. They do not understand that the characteristic of form is the appearance of one's own mind. Because they do not comprehend suffering and pleasure, they do not reach the state of liberation. Desire arises, bound up with names and signs, and once desire has arisen, they become cause and object of support. Some think, "When these faculties of feeling cease, they will gradually no longer arise." Imagining it otherwise through the conceptuality of their own minds, and not knowing suffering and pleasure, they enter the absorption of the cessation of feeling and perception and attain the fourth dhyāna. Such yogins, skilled in the true reality and in liberation, form the notion that this is liberation. Yet what has not been fully relinquished and has not been transformed is what is called the tathāgatagarbha, the all-base consciousness.

The seven consciousnesses go on in saṃsāra and do not cease. Why is that? Because the consciousnesses arise from its cause and its object of support. It is not the domain of the yogins of the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas. Because selflessness is not realized, it produces the aggregates, elements and sense sources, which are comprised of particular and general characteristics. When the tathāgatagarbha is seen, the five dharmas, the natures, and the selflessness of persons and of phenomena all turn back. Because the progression through the stages of the grounds has become distinctive, one cannot be shaken by the views of other tīrthikas, and this is called abiding on the bodhisattva ground called the Immovable.

One then attains the ten paths that are the doors to the bliss of samādhi. Held by the intellect of samādhi, one discerns the inconceivable qualities of the Buddha. Through one's own aspiration one does not take up the bliss of the doors of samādhi, and without dwelling in the limit of reality, one proceeds to the personal realization of the noble ones. One attains the path of yoga not shared with the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas, or any of the tīrthikas, the ten paths of the noble lineage, and the mind-made body of wisdom that is free of the deliberate formation of samādhi.

Therefore, Mahāmati, bodhisattva mahāsattvas who desire distinction should purify the tathāgatagarbha called the all-base consciousness. Mahāmati, if there were no all-base consciousness, what is called the tathāgatagarbha would have neither arising nor perishing. But, Mahāmati, since there is arising and perishing for both the childish and the noble, yogins enter the personal realization of the noble ones and do not abandon the practice of dwelling at ease in this very life.

Mahāmati, this tathāgatagarbha, the all-base consciousness, is by nature completely pure. Yet all the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, and all who hold speculative views, see it as impure because it is obscured by adventitious afflictions. The tathāgatas do not. Mahāmati, because the Tathāgata has direct perception as his domain, he sees it as one sees an amalaka fruit in the palm of the hand.

Mahāmati, having established this meaning through the power of miraculous ability, I taught and explained, for the sake of Queen Śrīmālā and of other bodhisattvas whose wisdom is sharp and complete, that the tathāgatagarbha called the all-base consciousness arises together with the seven consciousnesses. Because the śrāvakas cling to seeing the selflessness of persons, Queen Śrīmālā, through the power of the Buddha's blessing, explained the domain of the Tathāgata. It is not the domain of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas, or the tīrthikas. Mahāmati, the tathāgatagarbha, the all-base consciousness, is the domain of the Tathāgata alone, and of other wise bodhisattvas whose wisdom is sharp and who rely on the meaning. Therefore, Mahāmati, you and the other bodhisattva mahāsattvas should strive and train diligently in this tathāgatagarbha, the all-base consciousness, and should not form the notion that merely hearing and knowing about it is enough.

Then, to teach that very meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The profound essence of the Tathāgata,
together with the seven consciousnesses,
proceeds into the two kinds of grasping;
the wise abandon it entirely.

Like images in a mirror, the mind appears,
imbued with tendencies from beginningless time.
When one fully realizes it just as it truly is,
things are without the nature of things.

Just as a child looks at the fingertip
and does not look at the moon,
so those attached to letters
will not see my truth.

The mind abides like a dancer;
mentation is like the jester;
the five consciousnesses are like companions;
they gaze on the dances of conceptual thought.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati said this to the Blessed One:

"May the Blessed One please explain the defining mark of the analysis by which one comes to fully understand the five dharmas, the natures, the consciousnesses, and the two kinds of selflessness. By this, I and the other bodhisattvas will connect the sequence of all the grounds, analyze these dharmas, and enter into all the qualities of a buddha. Entering into all the qualities of a buddha, we will go as far as the ground of the Tathāgata's self-realization."

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, listen well and keep it in mind."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "I shall do just so," and listened. The Blessed One said:

"Mahāmati, the defining mark of the analysis of and full entry into the five dharmas, the natures, the consciousnesses, and the two kinds of selflessness is this: name, sign, conceptuality, correct knowledge, and suchness. When yogins meditate on these, they fully enter the noble way of the Tathāgata's self-realization, abandon views such as permanence, annihilation, existence, and nonexistence, and come directly to abide in the blissful absorption in the present life.

"Mahāmati, because they do not understand the five dharmas, the natures, the consciousnesses, the two kinds of selflessness, and that external things are the appearance of their own minds, ordinary beings engage in conceptuality, but the noble ones do not."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, how is it that conceptuality arises in foolish ordinary beings but not in the noble ones?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, because foolish ordinary beings cling to the names and signs of conventional designation, they follow the mind. Having followed it, desiring the various colors of signs, those whose thinking has fallen

into views of self and what belongs to a self cling to attractive forms. Having clung to them, because they are obscured by ignorance, they give rise to attachment. Having become attached, they accumulate karma arising from desire, aversion, and delusion. Having accumulated it, they bind themselves with conceptuality, just as a silkworm makes a cocoon. Beings who have fallen into the cocoon in the ocean of saṃsāra are like a water wheel. Thus, because of delusion, not knowing that things are by nature free of self and what belongs to a self, like an illusion, a mirage, or the moon in water, they generate all kinds of false conceptuality. Not knowing that things, free of characteristic, basis of characteristic, arising, and perishing, are born from the conceptuality of their own minds and do not come from the Lord (Īśvara), time, atoms, or the Principal (pradhāna), foolish ordinary beings follow name and sign.

"Here, Mahāmati, as for sign: what is made to appear by eye consciousness is called form. In the same way, what is made to appear by ear, nose, tongue, body, and mind consciousness is called sound, smell, taste, the tangible, and phenomena. This is called sign.

"Mahāmati, conceptuality is that by which, having imputed many names, one makes signs distinct, thinking, 'This is so and not otherwise.' Whatever names there are, such as elephant, horse, chariot, foot soldier, man, and woman, that is called conceptuality.

"Mahāmati, correct knowledge is that by which those names and signs are not apprehended, and which is like a traveler going back and forth. Because the consciousnesses do not arise, it is without permanence; being without annihilation, it does not fall to the level of any tīrthikas, śrāvakas, or pratyekabuddhas.

"Furthermore, Mahāmati, by that correct knowledge, bodhisattva great beings neither establish names and signs nor fail to establish names and signs, and so they completely abandon the two views of superimposition and denial. The non-arising of name and sign is called suchness.

"Mahāmati, because a bodhisattva great being who abides in suchness attains the domain of non-appearance, he attains the bodhisattva ground Joyful. Having attained the bodhisattva ground Joyful, he passes entirely beyond the tīrthikas and all the destinies of the lower realms, and he abides correctly in the way that transcends the world. Familiar with the characteristics of phenomena, analyzing all phenomena as illusion-like and so on, with the

characteristic of the way of the self-realized Dharma, and free of the marvelous-seeming characteristics of the logicians' views, he gradually attains up to the Cloud of Dharma. In that interval too, his samādhis, powers, empowerments, and superknowledges increase, and he attains up to the ground of the Tathāgata. Having attained that, he displays everywhere manifold emanations like the moon in water and brings sentient beings to maturity. Having perfected the ten ultimate stations, he makes distinctions for sentient beings of various inclinations and teaches the Dharma, yet the Dharma body is free of the formative activity of mind. This is called what bodhisattvas attain having entered suchness."

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, are the three natures included within the five dharmas, or are they each established with their own characteristics?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, the three natures, the eight consciousnesses, and the two kinds of selflessness are all included within the five dharmas. Mahāmati, those names and signs are the imagined nature.

Mahāmati, in dependence on that conceptualization, mind and mental factors arise together with name. Just as the sun and its rays arise together, that which distinguishes and grasps the various characteristics one by one is called the dependent nature. Mahāmati, correct wisdom and suchness, because they are indestructible, are called the perfected nature.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, conceptualization, which is the appearance of one's own mind, is divided into eight kinds, namely: the all-base consciousness (ālayavijñāna), the mind (manas), the mental consciousness, and the five groups of consciousness. Here, signs are imagined upon unreal characteristics; when the two graspings, at a self and at what belongs to a self, cease, the two kinds of selflessness arise. Therefore, Mahāmati, these five dharmas include the individually self-cognized noble wisdom of the śrāvakas, the pratyekabuddhas, the bodhisattvas and the tathāgatas, the linking of the grounds, their sequence, and all the qualities of a buddha.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, the five dharmas are sign, name, conceptualization, suchness and correct wisdom. Mahāmati, among these, sign is what appears as location, as the characteristic of shape, and as the characteristics of form and so on. That is called sign. When that very sign has a name such as "pot," and one thinks, "This is so and not otherwise," that is called name: having assigned many names, it makes the signs clear. The mind and mental factors

that conceive "pot" and the like are called conceptualization. That those names and those signs are ultimately unobservable, that neither beginning nor end can be known, that phenomena have no mutual relation, and the freedom from false conceptualization: this is called suchness. The intrinsic nature that cannot be observed even in the final and definitive ascertainment of reality, that, as the characteristic of suchness, I and the tathāgatas have entered into, and have explained to all sentient beings exactly as it is, have designated, and have made clear. That characteristic which, once one has entered into it, one correctly realizes, which is free of annihilation and permanence, in which conceptualization does not arise, which accords with the way of individually self-cognized noble wisdom, and which is not apprehended by any tīrthikas, śrāvakas or pratyekabuddhas: that is called correct wisdom.

Mahāmati, these are called the five dharmas. The three natures, the eight consciousnesses, the two kinds of selflessness, and all the qualities of a buddha are included in them. Therefore, Mahāmati, you should train yourself diligently in this, and train others in it as well, and you should not follow others.

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

The five dharmas and the three natures,
The eight consciousnesses themselves,
And the meaning of selflessness in its two kinds:
In these the whole Great Vehicle is contained.

Name, sign and conceptualization
Are the characteristic of two natures;
Correct wisdom and suchness
Are the characteristic of the perfected.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati again addressed the Blessed One: "The Blessed One has said that the buddhas of the past are as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges, and that it is the same for those of the future and the present. Blessed One, should this be taken in its meaning just as the words say, or is there some other meaning? Blessed One, out of your compassion, please explain."

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, it should not be taken in its meaning just as the words say. The tathāgatas of the three times are not truly as numerous as the sands of the river Ganges. Why is that? Because they transcend worldly

thought, they cannot be illustrated by examples.

"Thus, childish ordinary beings cling to permanence, and as the bad views imagined by the tīrthikas grow in them, their saṃsāra becomes endless. In order to make them thoroughly weary of the wheel of wandering in saṃsāra, and to set them to undertake exceptional diligence, they are taught, 'The tathāgatas are easy to see; they are not like the udumbara flower.' For otherwise, thinking, 'They are hard to see,' they would give up their effort.

"At other times, looking to those who are to be trained, it is said, 'The tathāgatas are extremely hard to see, like the udumbara flower.' Yet the udumbara flower has not been seen, is not seen, and will not be seen by anyone, whereas the Tathāgata is seen by the whole world. So it is not in order to establish my own principle that it is said, 'The appearance of tathāgatas is like the udumbara flower.'

"Mahāmati, the establishment of my own principle transcends worldly thought, so childish ordinary beings would not believe it. For the domain of individually self-cognized noble wisdom there is no example. The Tathāgata of reality transcends mind, mentation and mental consciousness, and so cannot be illustrated by visible signs.

"Nevertheless, Mahāmati, there is no fault in my teaching by way of an example that the tathāgatas are equal in number to the sands of the river Ganges. Mahāmati, it is like this: the sands of the river Ganges are trampled and stirred up by fish, turtles, śiśumāras (river dolphins), lions, elephants, horses, humans and wild animals, yet the sand does not conceive, 'These are harming me,' because it is pure by nature and unstained by impurities."

In the same way, the powers, the superknowledges, the faculties and the rest are the sands in the great river Ganges of the self-realized noble wisdom of the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha. All the non-Buddhists (tīrthikas), humans, wild animals and the like may trouble them and stir them up, yet because the Tathāgata has no intentions, no conceptual thought arises in him. The Tathāgata is utterly solitary and has no perception of intention. By the power of his former aspirations he establishes sentient beings in the bliss of samādhi, and so he does not think, "I am being troubled." In this he is like the sands of the Ganges, with no difference at all. Moreover, this is because he has completely abandoned attachment, anger and delusion.

For example, the sands of the Ganges have the nature of the characteristic of earth. Even when everything is burned up in the conflagration at the end of

the eon, the great element of earth does not give up its nature, because it arises together with the fire element. Foolish ordinary beings may imagine otherwise, that it burns, but it does not burn, because it is the cause of the fire element. In the same way, Mahāmati, the Dharma body of the Tathāgata is indestructible, like the sands of the Ganges.

Mahāmati, for example, the sands of the Ganges are measureless. In the same way, the light rays of the Tathāgatas are also measureless: in order to bring sentient beings to maturity, all the buddhas illuminate every circle of their assemblies.

Mahāmati, for example, if one were to search among the sands of the Ganges for some other, different sand, one would never find it. In the same way, Mahāmati, for the Tathāgata, the Arhat, the perfectly complete Buddha there is no saṃsāra, and there is no arising or ceasing, because the causes and conditions of existence have been cut off.

Mahāmati, for example, the increase and decrease of the sands of the Ganges cannot be known. In the same way, Mahāmati, the wisdom of the Tathāgata that brings sentient beings to maturity neither increases nor decreases, because it is not something of a bodily nature. What is of a bodily nature is subject to destruction, but the Dharma body of the Tathāgata is not of a bodily nature.

For example, however hard one presses the sands of the Ganges, no oil is found. In the same way, even if all the tormenting sufferings of sentient beings do harm to the Tathāgata, he does not abandon the dharmadhātu until sentient beings have been brought to complete nirvāṇa, because of his own samādhi, the bliss of his aspirations, and his great compassion.

Mahāmati, for example, the sands of the Ganges flow along with the current of the water; they do not do so without water. In the same way, Mahāmati, all the teachings taught by the Tathāgatas flow along with the current of nirvāṇa, and that is why it is said that they are "equal to the sands of the Ganges." The Tathāgata does not follow after goings, because flowing along and going have the sense of destruction. Mahāmati, because the prior limit of saṃsāra cannot be known, and since it is not known, how could one speak of going? Mahāmati, if what is called "going" has the sense of annihilation, foolish ordinary beings do not understand this.

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, if sentient beings do not know the prior limit of saṃsāra, how will they come to realize liberation?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, it is known when the cause ceases, namely the habitual tendencies of conceptuality, the dysfunctional state of conceptual elaboration from beginningless time, and when one sees things as mere appearances of one's own mind. The transformation of the basis of the external object and of the conceptualizing body is called liberation; it is not destruction. Therefore what is called 'without limit' is not nothingness. Because people conceptualize, synonyms and names such as 'without limit' have been made. When both outer and inner are thoroughly examined, there is no other, separate sentient being apart from conceptuality. Therefore knowing, the knowable and all phenomena are utterly solitary. Conceptuality arises because the conceptuality that is the appearance of one's own mind is not fully understood; if it comes to be fully understood, it will cease."

Then, in order to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

When the guides are thoroughly examined,
like the sands of the river Ganges,
they have no destruction and no going,
nor are they without an end.
It is by way of sameness
that the tathāgatas are examined.
Like the sands of the Ganges and the rest,
they have wholly abandoned every fault;
they enter the current, their nature is permanent:
that is a buddha, that is buddhahood itself.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati again spoke to the Blessed One, saying, "Blessed One, please explain the characteristic of all phenomena perishing in an instant. Blessed One, how is it that all phenomena are momentary?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, then listen well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, so be it," and he listened. The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, 'all phenomena' are these: the virtuous and the nonvirtuous, the morally determinate and the indeterminate, the conditioned and the unconditioned, the mundane and the supramundane, the blameworthy and the blameless, the defiled and the undefiled, the appropriated and the unappropriated. Mahāmati, in brief, mind, mentation, mental consciousness and the habitual tendencies are the cause of the five

aggregates of appropriation, and they make the habitual tendencies of mind, mentation and mental consciousness grow. Foolish ordinary beings imagine these to be virtuous or nonvirtuous. Mahāmati, the bliss of samādhi and dwelling happily in this very life through the meditative attainments are called the undefiled virtue of the noble ones."

Mahāmati, what are called virtuous and nonvirtuous are the eight consciousnesses. What are the eight? They are the tathāgatagarbha, which is proclaimed as the all-base consciousness; mind; mentation; mental consciousness; and the group of the five consciousnesses. These are not spoken of by the tīrthikas.

Mahāmati, the group of five consciousnesses, together with mind, mentation and mental consciousness, arise and perish one after another, marked as virtuous and nonvirtuous. Because they proceed as an unbroken stream, they do not perish; and once a body has come about, they also come to arise and perish. Because it is not understood that things are merely appearances of one's own mind, as soon as one consciousness ceases another arises. The mental consciousness, which grasps the particular features of the spheres, arises together with the five groups of consciousness and does not remain even for the duration of an instant. That is what is called momentary.

Mahāmati, as for what is called momentary: the tathāgatagarbha, which is proclaimed as the all-base consciousness, is momentary through the habitual tendencies of the consciousness that arises together with mentation. It is not momentary through the undefiled habitual tendencies. Ordinary childish beings do not understand this. Because they cling to the doctrine of momentariness, they do not understand that all phenomena are both momentary and non-momentary. Because they view things as annihilated, they destroy even the unconditioned phenomena.

Mahāmati, the seven consciousnesses do not enter saṃsāra. They do not experience suffering and pleasure, nor are they the cause of nirvāṇa. Mahāmati, it is the tathāgatagarbha that experiences suffering and pleasure. It proceeds and turns back together with the cause. Intoxicated by the grounds of abiding and the abode of ignorance, ordinary childish beings do not understand the view of momentariness, and their minds become permeated by conceptuality.

Furthermore, Mahāmati, gold, vajra, the relics of the Tathāgata, and the essential nature of one who has attained distinction never perish. Mahāmati, if

the attainment of realization were momentary, the noble ones would become ignoble; but the noble ones do not become ignoble. Gold and vajra do not diminish even for as long as an eon. That being so, why do ordinary childish beings, who are unskilled in what I have taught with hidden intent, imagine that all outer and inner phenomena are momentary?

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati again said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, the Blessed One has declared that if one practices the six perfections to their completion, one will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. What are the six?"

The Blessed One said, "Mahāmati, the perfections are of three distinct kinds: worldly, transcendent, and supremely transcendent.

"Mahāmati, as for the worldly perfections: clinging to the grasping of self and what belongs to self, holding to the two extremes, taking up various places of birth, and devoted to forms, sounds, smells, tastes and tangible objects, they bring the perfection of generosity to completion. So too with moral discipline, patience, diligence, meditative concentration and wisdom. They accomplish the superknowledges of ordinary childish beings and are born in the world of Brahmā.

"Mahāmati, as for the transcendent perfections: the śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas, because they have fallen into grasping at nirvāṇa, practice the six perfections and are devoted to the bliss of their own nirvāṇa.

"As for the supremely transcendent perfections: there is the understanding that the appearances of one's own mind are mere conceptualization; there is the non-arising of the conceptuality that comes from grasping one's own mind dualistically; there is the taking up of existences among beings without sharing their lot; and there is non-attachment to the characteristics of one's own mind and of form. In this way, for the benefit and happiness of all sentient beings, one produces the perfection of generosity.

"Having produced supreme application, to keep conceptuality from entering into that very object is moral discipline; that is the perfection of moral discipline. To accept that very non-arising of conceptuality and to know fully the grasped and the grasper is the perfection of patience. That by which one strives in application during the first and last parts of the night, so that, in accord with yoga, conceptuality does not enter, is the perfection of diligence. For conceptuality to be completely reversed and for one not to fall into grasping at the nirvāṇa of the śrāvakas is the perfection of meditative

concentration. Therein, having examined with wisdom that the conceptuality of one's own mind is without substance, one does not fall into the two extremes; through the transformation of the former bodily basis one does not perish; and one attains the way of the noble ones, which is individual self-awareness. That is the perfection of wisdom."

Then, to teach that same meaning again, the Blessed One spoke these verses:

Empty, impermanent, momentary:
so do the childish conceive.
Like a river, a lamp, a seed,
they conceive the meaning of momentariness.

Momentary means the turmoil of afflictions stilled,
utterly secluded, free of agency.
The non-arising of phenomena
is what I teach as the meaning of momentary.
That things arise and then perish
I do not teach to the childish.

A continuous stream of things without interruption
is permeated by conceptuality.
Ignorance acts as the cause,
and from it mind comes forth.
As long as forms have not arisen,
what portion is there in between?
Immediately upon its having perished,
another mind arises after it.
If form does not remain in time,
on what as its object does mind arise?
Since it comes forth from those,
it is born from an unreal cause.
How, then, can what is unestablished
be known as perishing in an instant?

The meditative absorption of yogins,
the vajra, the relics of the Buddha,
the celestial palace of the abode of luminosity:
these are things in the world that do not perish.

Those abiding in the attainment of the true Dharma,
The perfect knowledge of the Tathāgata,

And the monks who have attained sameness:
How could these be seen as momentary?
The forms of gandharvas' cities, illusions and the like
Are not momentary.
Yet with regard to unreal form and the rest,
People look upon them as real.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati again addressed the Blessed One, the Buddha, saying: "Blessed One, you have prophesied that arhats too will fully awaken to unsurpassed, perfect and complete enlightenment. If so, they will be equal to bodhisattvas, without any distinction. If sentient beings are of a nature to pass into nirvāṇa, who will fully awaken to enlightenment?

"Further, it has been declared that from the night on which the Tathāgata fully awakened to unsurpassed, perfect and complete enlightenment until the night on which he passed into parinirvāṇa, he did not utter a single syllable, nor did he give any reply.

"Further, because the tathāgatas are always in meditative equipoise, they have neither conceptual thought nor discursive analysis. It is the emanated Tathāgata who emanates the deeds of a buddha.

"Further, why was it said that consciousnesses have the characteristic of perishing from one moment to the next?

"Further, the mighty Vajrapāṇi always follows and guards the Tathāgata. And it was said that no first limit is posited.

"Further, there are māras, the deeds of Māra, the ripening of misdeeds, the brahmin girl Cañcā, the wandering mendicant woman Sundarī, the return with an empty alms bowl, and other such karmic obstructions. If that is so, why has the Blessed One, though he has attained the wisdom of omniscience, not become free of faults?"

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, then listen well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "Blessed One, so be it," and listened. The Blessed One said:

"Mahāmati, it was taught for the sake of the nirvāṇa without remainder. In order to inspire those who practice the conduct of bodhisattvas, and in order that those who practice the conduct of bodhisattvas in this world and in

others, yet are inclined toward parinirvāṇa by the vehicle of the śrāvakas, may turn back from the śrāvaka vehicle and strive diligently in the Great Vehicle, it was the emanated buddha who gave the prophecy to the śrāvakas, not the buddha of the nature of reality. Mahāmati, for that reason the śrāvakas were prophesied as not different from the bodhisattvas.

"Mahāmati, here 'not different' means that śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and the buddhas, the blessed ones, are of one taste with regard to the obscuration of the afflictions and to liberation; it is not so with regard to the abandonment of the obscuration to knowledge. Mahāmati, the obscuration to knowledge is purified through the distinctive seeing of the selflessness of phenomena, while the obscuration of the afflictions is abandoned through prior familiarization with the seeing of the selflessness of persons. Then, through the cessation of the seven consciousnesses, liberation from the obscuration regarding phenomena, and the cessation of the habitual tendencies of the all-base consciousness, ultimate purity comes about.

"Because it was said with the ancient abiding Dharma in mind, there is no thing earlier or later.

"Because of his ultimate aspiration, the Tathāgata teaches the Dharma without conceptual thought and without discursive analysis. Because he emanates through perfect wisdom, and because his mindfulness is unimpaired, he has neither conceptual thought nor discursive analysis.

"Because the habitual tendencies of the abiding grounds and of the ground where ignorance abides have been abandoned, the two kinds of affliction are abandoned, he is free of the two kinds of death and transmigration, he has realized the selflessness of persons and of phenomena, and the two obscurations are abandoned.

"Mahāmati, the seven, namely the mind, the mental consciousness, the eye consciousness and the rest, are momentary. They are devoid of the side of the virtuous and undefiled cause of habitual tendencies, and they are devoid of that which no longer revolves in saṃsāra. Mahāmati, buddha-nature, the tathāgatagarbha, is the cause of revolving in saṃsāra and of nirvāṇa, of happiness and of suffering. Those whose minds are distracted by emptiness and childish ordinary beings do not understand it.

"Mahāmati, the one whom the mighty Vajrapāṇi follows and guards is the emanated buddha, not the true Tathāgata. Mahāmati, the true Tathāgata is free of all faculties and all means of valid cognition, and so is beyond the

faculties and means of valid cognition of all childish ordinary beings, śrāvakas, pratyekabuddhas and tīrthikas. Because he abides in bliss in this very life and has attained the forbearance that knows phenomena without interruption, he is not one to be guarded by Vajrapāṇi.

"No emanated buddha is born from karma. The buddha magically emanated is neither the Buddha nor other than the Buddha. Like the potter's wheel and the other causes, it performs the tasks of sentient beings, and though, endowed with the major marks, it teaches the Dharma, it does not explain the domain of the individual self-awareness that is the abode of its own way.

"Further, Mahāmati, because the seven groups of consciousness cease, childish ordinary beings generate the view of annihilation. Because they do not realize the all-base consciousness, they generate the view of permanence. Because of their own conceptual thought, they do not know the first limit. Through the cessation of one's own conceptualizing intellect, one becomes liberated. Because the habitual tendencies of the abiding grounds and of the ground where ignorance abides have been abandoned, all faults are abandoned."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses to set forth that very meaning perfectly:

The three vehicles are not vehicles;
the Tathāgatas do not pass into extinction.
All are prophesied to buddhahood
and are declared to be free of faults.

For the sake of attaining the wisdom of realization,
for nirvāṇa without remainder,
and also to encourage the faint-hearted,
for this reason it is taught with a hidden intent.

The wisdom that buddhas bring forth
is taught as the path that discerns suchness.
The vehicles are not vehicles;
that is not nirvāṇa.

Desire, form, existence, and views
are taught as the grounds of the four abidings.
They arise from the mental consciousness;
mind dwells in the house of consciousness.

The cessation of mind
and of the eye and other consciousnesses is taught as impermanence.
Or else, regarding it as nirvāṇa,
they take it to be permanently abiding.

Then the bodhisattva Mahāmati made a request in verse:

"Should bodhisattvas and others
who seek unsurpassed awakening
eat and drink meat, liquor,
garlic and onions, or not?
Unsurpassed Supreme Lord,
out of compassion, please explain this to me.

Fools crave it greedily;
it brings a foul stench and lack of renown;
when dead, it is the food of beasts of prey.
How could it be fit to eat?
What fault is there in eating it,
and what virtue in not eating it?
The merit and wrong of eating and not eating,
out of compassion, please explain to me."

Having made this request in verses, the bodhisattva Mahāmati further said this to the Blessed One: "Blessed One, please explain for me and others the faults of eating meat and the virtues of not eating it. When I and the other bodhisattvas, now and in the future, teach the Dharma with discernment to the various beings who are attached to and crave meat as food, those beings will look upon one another with minds of loving-kindness. Having gained minds of loving-kindness, they will abide on their respective grounds, clearly understand purity, and swiftly awaken fully to the ultimate, unsurpassed, perfect and complete awakening. The śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas will rest upon their own grounds, and having rested, they too will attain unsurpassed awakening. If even the tīrthikas, who hold evil doctrines and speak falsely, who have wrong views and cling to permanence and annihilation, forbid the eating of meat and do not allow meat to be eaten, then what need is there to say that the Tathāgata, the protector of the world, who has perfected the true Dharma, does not partake of meat?"

The Blessed One said, "Excellent, excellent, Mahāmati! Therefore listen very well and keep it in mind, and I shall explain it to you."

Mahāmati said to the Blessed One, "So be it," and listened to his words.

The Blessed One said: "Mahāmati, for immeasurable causes and reasons meat should not be eaten; nevertheless, here I shall explain to you just a summary.

Namely, living beings, for a very long time and through their mutual causes and conditions, have always been one another's kin. Because of this awareness that they have been kin, meat should not be eaten.

Butchers sell the meat of donkeys, mules, camels, foxes, dogs, oxen, horses, humans, wild beasts and the like all mixed together; for that reason meat should not be eaten.

Because meat arises from semen and blood, meat should not be eaten.

When beings smell its odor, all of them become afraid and terrified. Just as with butchers, caṇḍālas and the like, when dogs see them they are alarmed and afraid and set upon them. For that reason meat should not be eaten.

Further, because it does not let loving-kindness arise in yogins, it is not fitting to eat meat.

Because ignoble people become greedy and foul-smelling and are without good renown, meat should not be eaten.

Because the practices of vidyā-mantras will not succeed, meat should not be eaten.

Because in this way killing gives rise to a mind of craving the very moment a form is seen, one does not eat meat.

Because the gods shun those who eat meat, meat should not be eaten.

Also because it makes the breath foul-smelling, meat should not be eaten.

Because it brings many bad dreams, meat should not be eaten.

Because when one dwells in solitary places and forests, tigers, wolves and the like will smell its odor, meat should not be eaten.

Because it makes one unable to keep moderation in food, meat should not be eaten.

Because yogins will not develop thorough disenchantment, meat should not be eaten.

Because I have always taught that whatever one eats and drinks, one should regard it as the flesh of one's own son and as medicine, meat should not be

eaten. If someone says, 'I have allowed meat to be eaten,' that is impossible.

Further, Mahāmati, in times past there was a king called Siṃha Saudāsa. He ate various kinds of meat and came to eat even human flesh. Because of this, his ministers, relatives and the host of his kinsfolk turned against him, and his former powers too were cut off, so that he fell into misery. Therefore, since eating meat has such dangers, meat should not be eaten.

Further, Mahāmati, those who take life kill and sell because they desire profit. The fools who eat meat buy meat with money. Those who take life, desiring profit, use hooks and nets to kill in many ways the creatures that move through the sky, that dwell in water and that walk on land, and so they seek profit. Mahāmati, there is no meat whatsoever that could be called 'not commissioned, not sought, and not suspected.' Therefore meat should not be eaten.

Mahāmati, formerly I prohibited five kinds and ten kinds of meat, but in this sūtra I prohibit all of it, in every form and at all times, along with every allowance given as a skillful means.

Mahāmati, for the Tathāgata, the arhat, the perfectly and completely awakened Buddha, there is nothing at all to be eaten, so what need is there to speak of eating the flesh of fish? Nor does he cause others to do so. Because great compassion goes before him, he regards all sentient beings as an only son; therefore he does not allow the flesh of a son to be eaten."

Then the Blessed One spoke these verses to set forth that very meaning again:

Because they were once our kin and friends,
because it is mixed with what is foul and impure,
because it arises from semen and blood,
and because all who catch its scent are terrified,
meats and onions,
chives, shallots and the like,
and liquor that brings every kind of heedlessness,
the yogin should always abandon.
Sesame oil too should be avoided,
and beds with holes bored in them as well,
because the tiny creatures
in them are greatly terrified.

From food, heedlessness arises;
from heedlessness, conceptual thought arises;
from conceptual thought, desire arises;
therefore one should not eat it.
Through the force of food, desire arises;
desire bewilders the mind;
bewilderment gives rise to craving for existence;
and one is not freed from saṃsāra.

For profit, beings are killed;
for meat, money is paid.
Since both are doers of evil deeds,
after death they fall into the Howling Hell.
Were there no notion of ordering it or seeking it,
there would be no meat pure in three respects either.
Since it does not exist without a cause,
therefore one should not eat it.
Therefore the yogin
should abandon all of them.
The buddhas, the blessed ones of the ten directions,
all strongly condemn it.

They devour one another,
and after death fall among the beasts of prey.
They will be born foul-smelling and despised,
and they will be born as fools.
Mostly they are born among caṇḍālas,
among hunters and Ḍombas,
or else they are born among ḍākinīs;
they will be born among the piśācas.
In all the wombs of rākṣasas,
cats and the like, they will be born.

In the Hastikakṣya and the Mahāmegha,
in the Aṅgulimālīya Sūtra,
and in this Sūtra of the Descent into Laṅkā,
I have strictly prohibited meat.
Those who shamelessly eat it,
condemned by the buddhas, the bodhisattvas
and the śrāvakas,

will always be born as fools.
Earlier too I taught that all meat
seen, heard or suspected is to be avoided.
Because the sophists did not understand this,
they are therefore born in the abodes of meat-eaters.

Just as the fault of desire
obscures the liberation of the noble ones,
so meat, liquor, garlic, onions and the like
obstruct the noble path.
People in times to come,
meat-eaters speaking out of delusion,
will say, "Since meat is without evil and permissible,
the Buddha allowed it to us."

Regarding food as medicine,
and likewise as the flesh of one's own child,
knowing the Dharma and giving rise to disenchantment,
the yogin should go for alms.
For whoever abides in a compassionate mind,
I have taught complete disenchantment.
Tigers, wolves and beasts of prey
may always dwell in company with one;
but if one eats meat,
sentient beings become afraid.
Therefore yogins,
with compassionate minds, should not eat meat.

Meat-eaters lack compassion and wisdom;
they turn their backs on liberation;
they go against the banners of the noble ones;
therefore it is not fitting to eat it.
One will be born in a brahmin family,
or else in the abodes of yogins,
born into households wise and wealthy:
this comes through the power of abandoning meat.

Thus ends the chapter called The Heart of the Speech of All the Buddhas, from the Noble Sūtra of the Precious Descent into Laṅkā.

By command of the glorious divine emperor, the monk and translator Gö Chödrup translated and edited it, drawing on the commentary composed by the Chinese master Wenhui.

Translator's Notes

• The line rendered "The whole world is like a dream" reads khor zug in the text; I have taken it as a variant of khor yug, "all around, entire". The "faculties" in the opening description may correspond to the masteries (vaśitā) of the Sanskrit. The verse "The yogin of the peaceful Sage" could also be read as "The Sage, the peaceful yogin"; I follow the sense of those who see the Sage as free of arising.
• "Gathered in six terms" renders the Tibetan literally; the Sanskrit of this sūtra here asks about the six seasons, which the Tibetan wording does not obviously reflect. In "fields shaped like the sun and moon" the Tibetan reads "tree" (shing), evidently a slip for "field" (zhing), which the surrounding lines require. "How does the Saṅgha come to be split" follows the evident sense of "schism" (dbyen) for the written "isolated" (dben). The "nine, like lutes and drums" is translated as written; its exact referent is unclear. The Tibetan units "measure" (bre), "shudok" and "olmasé" could not be securely identified with Indian measures; the last two are given in phonetics. The earlier mention of "mind is present in the seven grounds" and the series of particle measures (hare, sunbeam, nit, sheep, barley) follow the traditional Abhidharma scale of minute units.
• The Tibetan weight units nam, srang and zho are rendered with the Indian units dharaṇa, pala and karṣa; the exact equivalences are not certain. The line "how men, the young, and groves" is obscure in the Tibetan and rendered literally. "Hundred statements" in Mahāmati's question follows the Tibetan, which abbreviates the hundred and eight.
• □□□□□□□□□□, literally "one of great desire," is taken here as this sūtra's rendering of icchantika, a being cut off from the roots of virtue, as the Sanskrit list of 108 statements has it. The pair □□ / □□□□□□□□ is given as "gods" and "asuras," since □□□□□□□□ is the standard word for asura, though in the pattern of the list it could also be read as "non-gods."
• The passage announces seven kinds of intrinsic nature but lists only six. The Sanskrit Laṅkāvatāra lists samudaya, bhāva, lakṣaṇa, mahābhūta, hetu, pratyaya, and niṣpatti; here the first two appear to be fused into "the assemblage of entities." The list has been translated as it stands.

This Tibetan version (Toh 108) was made from the Chinese of Guṇabhadra, and several sentences are compressed or awkward. Examples are "since it is not a part of that" and the clause about "the means" existing as the characteristics of cause and result. These are rendered literally.
• Here □□□ is rendered "masteries" (Skt. vaśitā, the bodhisattva's ten masteries), not "empowerment," since it is listed with the superknowledges in describing an advanced bodhisattva. The sentence on mental consciousness near the end is terse in the Tibetan. It is rendered as closely as the syntax allows, following the sense of the Sanskrit Laṅkāvatāra.
• The line rendered "The eight are undivided in character" reads in the Tibetan as mi 'jigs ("fearless"), which makes no sense here. I have taken it as a slip for mi 'byed ("undivided"), which fits the context and the Sanskrit (abhinnalakṣaṇā). In the prose list of attainments, dbang is rendered "masteries" (vaśitā) rather than "empowerment," since empowerment is named separately just before it.
• The verse line rendered "Through analysis, reality is taught to yogins who are beginners" reflects the Tibetan's combination of "analysis" with "beginners" (las dang po pa); the Sanskrit

parallel is worded differently. "The natures" after "the five dharmas" refers to the doctrinal set of the (three) natures (svabhāva) central to this sūtra.
• In the sentence "If it is not different, then, because conceptuality arises from that cause...," the Tibetan as written reads "if it is different," repeating the previous condition. The argument and the following clause ("because it is not different from the horn") require "not different," so I have translated the evident reading. In this section □□□□□ is the mental continuum, not "tantra." In the verses, "the natures" refers to the three natures (svabhāva), and "the storehouse" is the storehouse consciousness (ālaya).
• "Dependent buddha" renders the Tibetan "buddha of the support," which here corresponds to the Sanskrit niṣyanda-buddha, the "outflow" buddha derived from the buddha of the nature of reality (dharmatā-buddha). "Imagined nature" and "dependent nature" are the parikalpita and paratantra natures of the three-nature doctrine. In the sentence on the way of noble self-awareness, the Tibetan reads "by thoroughly examining" the wrong views; the Sanskrit sense is that it shines by turning away from them.
• The clause on "the force of the characteristic of a cause that is self-made" is translated as the Tibetan reads; the doctrinal sense (that the tīrthikas' permanent principle depends on a producing cause and so cannot be permanent) is clear from context though the phrasing is compressed. "The transformation of the all-base" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, the "turning about" of the basis (āśrayaparāvṛtti) in Yogācāra terms.
• The Tibetan says the śrāvakas have "abandoned" the afflictions of habitual tendencies, whereas the Sanskrit and the doctrinal sense (they still have the inconceivable death of transformation ahead) would require "not abandoned"; it is translated as it stands. Likewise the double negative about bodhisattvas ("it is not that they do not fully pass into nirvāṇa") is rendered literally; the Sanskrit parallel says they do not pass into nirvāṇa, which fits the following sentence. "Icchantika" renders the Tibetan "those of great desire"; the sentence "these icchantikas are not icchantikas" is obscure in the Tibetan and is translated literally.
• "Icchantika" renders the Tibetan "one of great desire," the standard rendering of this term. "He is filled with joy" plays on the name of the first ground, Pramuditā, "the Joyful." "Cloud of Dharma" is the tenth ground, Dharmameghā.
• "Dysfunction" renders □□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. dauṣṭhulya), the latent negative tendencies of conceptual elaboration. In the verse, "abode" renders □□□□□□□, corresponding to Sanskrit pratiṣṭhā in the triad body, enjoyments and abode. □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□ is rendered "koṭis of niyutas" as a very large number; the exact value of □□□□□□□□ varies among Tibetan number lists.
• In the opening verse, □□□ is rendered "masteries" (Skt. vaśitā), the sense required beside the powers and superknowledges, not "empowerment." In the nonduality passage the Tibetan reads that entities "exist" (□□□□□□□□□□□□□) by way of causes with distinct characteristics; the Sanskrit transmits the opposite, "because there is no cause of distinct characteristics." The translation follows the Tibetan as written, but a lost negation in the Tibetan is possible.
• The Tibetan here reads □□□□□□□□□□, literally "fearless." In this list of the attributes of the non-Buddhist self, the sense required is "imperishable" (Skt. avyaya), so it has been translated that way rather than with the glossary's "fearlessness." □□□□□, among the potter's tools, is obscure; it is rendered "rod" on the basis of the Sanskrit daṇḍa in the parallel list.
• In the description of the eighth ground, the Tibetan grammar leaves it open whether the five dharmas, the natures, and the two selflessnesses are what one is free from or what characterizes the mind-made body; the Sanskrit speaks of a turning away from them, so I have read them as things one is free from. In the list of the mind-made body's qualities, □□□ is read as the bodhisattva's "masteries" (vaśitā), not as ritual empowerment. □□□□□, one of the potter's conditions, is an uncommon word; the Sanskrit lists a stick (daṇḍa) in this position, so it is rendered "a stick." The sixth cause, □□□□□□□□□□□□□, is translated as the Tibetan has it,

"dependent cause"; the surviving Sanskrit reads upekṣā-hetu, "cause of indifference."
• "Dysfunctional tendencies" renders the Tibetan term that stands for Sanskrit dauṣṭhulya. In the third kind of speech, the explanation about recalling harm done by enemies suggests the sense of grievance or injury; the Sanskrit parallel speaks of clinging to evil reasoning. In Mahāmati's request the Tibetan repeats the word for "expression" twice; it is taken, as in the Sanskrit parallel, as "expression and what is expressed."
• In the verses, the line rendered "the wisdom of self-awareness, the limit of reality" may also be read as two items in apposition ("self-aware wisdom and the limit of reality"). The term rendered "illusions" (Tibetan mig yor) can also mean an optical illusion or a mirage. The sense is the same either way.
• "Grasping at a nourisher" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□, corresponding to Sanskrit poṣa, one of the standard designations of a self alongside ātman and pudgala. In the final simile the phrase □□□□□□ is taken in its verbal sense "to display, cause to appear", and □□□□ is taken as a spirit animating the figure, likely the vetāla of the Sanskrit parallel. The construction of this sentence is compressed, and its exact syntax is uncertain.
• In the first type of concentration, the Tibetan reads "that which does not bring perception to cessation," whereas the Sanskrit is usually understood as "up to the cessation of perception." The translation follows the Tibetan. The obscure verse items "a tree's reflection in water" and "a spent fire" are tentative readings of terse Tibetan. In the list of false doctrines, the Tibetan word usually meaning "essential nature" here stands for primal nature (prakṛti) of the Sāṃkhya, and "inherent nature" for svabhāva.
• □□□□□□□□□□□□□ (Skt. adhiṣṭhāna) is rendered "sustaining power" throughout rather than "blessing," to reflect its sense in this sūtra as the empowering support of the buddhas. "The refuge to which yogins go" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□, which could also be understood as "what yogins resort to" or "the goal of yogins."
• "A tenet with something intervening and a tenet with nothing intervening" renders the Tibetan literally; the point seems to be that the Buddha's causal teaching and the tīrthikas' differ only as mediated versus immediate causation, though the Sanskrit is commonly read as saying there is no real distinction between the two tenets. "This third one" follows the Tibetan as written; the corresponding Sanskrit speaks of a simultaneous rather than a gradual establishment. The world-system names are reconstructed: "Unblinking" as Animiṣa, and "Heaped Fragrance" as Gandhakūṭa; the Sanskrit text may give the second as Gandhasugandha.
• "Delusion" renders □□□□□ (Skt. bhrānti, error, delusion). "Negative tendencies" renders □□□□□□□□□□ (dauṣṭhulya). The final sentence breaks off where the argument continues into the next piece, and it is translated as the Tibetan stands.
• The three "groups" correspond to the technical Abhidharma categories nāmakāya, padakāya and vyañjanakāya (groups of names, phrases or sentences, and letters or syllables). The first verse is compressed in Tibetan; it is rendered to follow the prose argument that things are called illusion-like not through a shared property but because they are unreal and perish like lightning. In the passage on the tīrthikas, "set straight" renders a verb literally meaning "to establish, arrange"; the sense is to correct or guide those who cling.
• "The view of the transitory collection" renders the standard term for the view that the aggregates constitute a real self (satkāyadṛṣṭi). The phrase rendered "from the outset, has seven more lives" corresponds to the Sanskrit idea of "at most seven rebirths." "Bodies that answer their aspirations" is an interpretive rendering of a compressed Tibetan phrase.
• The phrase rendered "the long-standing ignorance and clinging are abandoned" reads, as written, "unknowing and higher knowing" (mngon par shes pa). In this context "higher knowing" makes little sense. The similar-looking "clinging" (mngon par zhen pa), a term used earlier in the passage, is evidently intended, and the translation follows that reading. "Clinging"

to moral discipline renders the Tibetan for holding moral discipline and vows as supreme (śīlavrataparāmarśa), the third of the three fetters.
• "The ten culminating states" renders a term that likely corresponds to the ten niṣṭhāpadas, the ten great culminating vows of the bodhisattva. "Capacity for activity" for the fire element follows the Tibetan literally.
• The Immovable Ground is the eighth bodhisattva ground (acalā bhūmi). In the list of qualities, the term usually glossed "empowerment" is here rendered "masteries" (vaśitā), as the context of powers and superknowledges requires. The phrase "the characteristic of a body does not fall apart" follows the Tibetan as it stands; its sense in context is not fully clear.
• In the verse line "Its cutting off is the domain of the noble ones," the Tibetan verb could also be read as "explaining"; "cutting off" follows the sense of the Sanskrit Laṅkāvatāra. In the last verse the Tibetan reads "by realization" (rtogs pas); this is taken as a slip for "by conception" (rtog pas), which the context requires.
• The phrase rendered "the habitual tendencies of faults" reads in the Tibetan as if it contained a negative ("not faulty"). This seems to be a slip, and the passage has been translated by sense as "faults". Elsewhere the obscuration the śrāvakas have not abandoned is often given as the obscuration of the knowable, but here the Tibetan says the obscuration of afflictions, and the translation follows it. "The death and transmigration that still involves real entities" renders the Tibetan literally. In the tradition this passage is usually linked to the inconceivable death-transformation that remains for arhats.
• The passage on the five acts of immediate retribution is compressed in the Tibetan and has no explicit change of speaker: it reads as spoken by Mahāmati, though in substance it is a teaching (the Sanskrit places such statements in the Buddha's mouth). The clause ending in "except" (ma gtogs) has been rendered by its evident sense: realization remains possible for such persons, but only through the conditions named. "Born together with its class and free of deliberate effort" renders the Sanskrit nikāya-sahaja-asaṃskāra. The Tibetan list of birth stories omits the Vyāsa found in the Sanskrit; it is translated as it stands.
• "Deliverance" renders a Tibetan term that usually means "arising"; here it corresponds to Sanskrit niḥsaraṇa, "release, emergence," as in the Sanskrit Laṅkāvatāra, which the context supports. "Destroys" and "destroyer" render a term that corresponds to Sanskrit vaināśika, a nihilist who annihilates, that is, one who explains things away.
• "The way of realization" renders grub pa'i mtha'i tshul (Skt. siddhāntanaya), here meaning inwardly realized truth as opposed to the way of teaching (deśanānaya), not "tenet system." In the description of the way of realization, the phrase "not real" (yang dag pa ma yin pa) has been read as qualifying the following "conceptual perceptions" that are abandoned. The alternative reading, attaching it to the preceding "intrinsic characteristic of the ground of self-realization," yields poor sense.
• In Mahāmati's restatement the Tibetan reads "realizing that things are merely appearances of one's own mind," without the negative found in the Buddha's preceding statement, which he is repeating. Since realizing mind-only cannot be a source of attachment, the negative has evidently dropped out, and the translation follows the Buddha's wording, "not realizing."
• The line rendered "wisdom is the awareness that discerns thought" reads rnam rtogs rig pa, which may stand for rnam rtog ("conceptual thought"); the Sanskrit parallel speaks of wisdom operating in reflection, and the sense is somewhat uncertain. In the verses, dbang is taken as the bodhisattva "masteries" (vaśitā), not ritual empowerment.
• □□□□□□□□□□□□ (Sanskrit saṃdhi, "joining, linking") is rendered "binding," its opposite "non-binding," and □□□□□□□□□□□□ "release." Other translators render the pair as "attachment and non-attachment." The "ten ultimate stations" (□□□□□□□) are most likely the ten inexhaustible vows or aspirations (niṣṭhāpada) of a bodhisattva.
• "Linking" renders the Tibetan term for connection or attachment (Skt. saṃdhi or anusaṃdhi),

which here covers both conceptual binding and rebirth-linking. "The meeting of the three" refers to the conjunction of sense faculty, object, and consciousness. The final paragraph of Mahāmati's objection is terse and difficult, and its rendering follows the most plausible construal of the Tibetan.

• "Without linking" renders the Tibetan for rebirth-linking or continuity (Skt. pratisandhi). "Otherwise" in the prose (Tibetan gzhan du na) is taken in the sense of Sanskrit anyatra, "except," so the passage means that propositions are acceptable only to keep the childish from fear. The opening questions are densely phrased, and their rendering follows the Tibetan syntax closely.

• In Mahāmati's second paragraph the Tibetan reads "because of understanding" the distinctness and non-distinctness of characteristics, without the negative that appears in his opening question ("does not understand"). I have translated it as written, but the argument likely intends the same "not understanding." The final sentence is cut off and continues in the next piece. Here □□□□□□□ has its ordinary sense of attending upon or serving a teacher or doctrine, not the ritual sense.

• In the definition of "coming," the Tibetan literally reads "arising from the assembling of goings (or beings)." I have rendered it as "arising from an assemblage," following the evident sense that coming means arising through accumulation.

The third door of liberation is here given as "absence of deliberate formation" rather than the more usual "wishlessness." I translated what this text says.

The numbering of the Lokāyatas (first, second, sixth, eleventh) is translated exactly as given.

• The terms rendered "undeclared" and "declared" here refer to the questions the Buddha set aside (avyākṛta) rather than to the Abhidharma sense of morally indeterminate. The phrase rendered "whose continuum is cut off" is terse and its exact sense uncertain; it may point to those holding annihilationist views. "Material things" renders the Tibetan for Sanskrit āmiṣa, worldly gain or carnal enjoyment, contrasted with the Dharma.

• "Material things" renders □□□□□□ (Skt. āmiṣa), contrasted throughout with Dharma. In "conceive of nirvāṇa as what is imperishable," the Tibetan reads □□□□□□□□□□ ("fearless"); the parallel clause that follows has □□□□□□□□□ ("imperishable"), and the context of really existent past, present, and future requires that sense, so it has been read as a copyist's slip. "The six policies" renders □□□□□□□□□□□ (ṣaḍguṇa), the six measures of royal statecraft. "Twenty-five categories of existence" refers to the Sāṃkhya principles (tattvas).

• "If the Tathāgata were an entity" reads the Tibetan □□□□□□□ ("is or is not") as a copyist's slip for □□□□□ ("if he were"), which the argument plainly requires. In the description of nirvāṇa, the Tibetan says literally "clinging to external things and ... the four extremes completely abandoned"; I take "abandoned" to govern both clauses, which matches the doctrinal sense: not clinging to external things.

• In the cow's-horn example the Tibetan reads "not different" twice; the second clause, giving the reason "because there is a distinction of long and short," must mean "not non-different," and it is translated so. In this passage □□□□□□ means the sense faculties (indriya), both in the prose and in the first verse line, not the god Indra.

• The sentence "if some say, 'The Tathāgata does not teach a Dharma that falls into letters,' they speak falsely" is translated as the Tibetan reads. The Sanskrit parallel instead says that whoever teaches a Dharma fallen into letters is babbling, so the negation in this Tibetan may be a scribal variant. "Because there is no meaning at all apart from it" renders an unusual phrase; the Sanskrit parallel has "because meaning is bodiless."

• "The ten masteries" renders □□□□□□□, the ten vaśitā of a bodhisattva; the glossary sense "empowerment" does not apply here. In the list "space, cessation not brought about by analysis, and the realm of nirvāṇa," the Tibetan reads literally "cessation of the analyzed that

has not ceased" (□□□

plainly requires "not falling into the two extremes," and this has been translated. The phrase rendered "taking up existences among beings without sharing their lot" is obscure in the Tibetan and its exact sense is uncertain. In the verses, vajra stands among things that do not perish, in the sense of diamond.

• In this passage □□□□□□ means "faculties" (indriya) in a list with the means of valid cognition, not the god Indra, so it is translated as "faculties." "The ancient abiding Dharma" renders □□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□□, the timelessly abiding nature of things invoked elsewhere in the sūtra to explain why the Buddha "spoke not a syllable." The phrase "forbearance that knows phenomena without interruption" is a literal rendering of a compressed expression whose exact technical sense is not certain.

• The phrase rendered "set upon them" translates □□□□□□□□□□□□, whose exact sense (attacking or barking) is uncertain. "Not commissioned, not sought, and not suspected" renders the three conditions under which meat was traditionally considered permissible.

• This Tibetan version was translated from Chinese, and several items follow Chinese terms. "Chives" and "shallots" render □□□□ and □□□□□□□, which appear to be transcriptions of Chinese names for pungent alliums; the exact plants are uncertain. "Sesame oil" for □□□□□□□ follows the Chinese parallel. "Ḍākinīs" for □□□□□□□ and "Ḍombas" for □□□□□□□□ follow the parallel lists in the Chinese and Sanskrit versions. The lines on "meat pure in three respects" are terse. The point is that meat never arises without someone's ordering or seeking it, so no meat is truly pure. The name of the Chinese commentator, Wenhui, is reconstructed from the Tibetan transcription □□□□□□□ and is tentative.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.